Primary Attraction

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28806558.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Plot What Plot/Porn Without Plot, Stranger Sex, Workplace Sex, Construction Crew Leader Adora, Engineer Catra, Semi-Public Sex, Wall Sex, Strap-Ons, Desk Sex, Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), She Likes to Think At Least, Car Sex, Strap Sucking, dirty dirty talk, Plot Starts to Creep in at Ch 3, More chapters could be added

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Primary Attraction + Bonus Scenes

Collections:
Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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by MxSinshine

Summary

Catra usually didnt hate her job that much, but one infuriating contractor who wont stop pestering her was more than enough to make her lose her cool. She decides to confront this 'Adora' to tell the crew leader off.

She might end up being the one getting off though...

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

Hey all!

Okay, the words haven't been my friends lately, as I struggle to get anywhere with any of my WiPs. At the (possibly joking) behest of my friends, I ended up cranking out this quick, indulgent little PWP smutshot. Hoping it'll be the tinder to get some real work done, but regardless I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra crammed the hardhat over her head, hating that she didn't just keep the one specially made to fit over her ears in her truck. Being out in the field wasn't part of her main job description (truthfully she wasn't even sure why she'd been issued the personal protective gear *or* the work truck, but hey, that was her company's choice, not hers) and she almost always worked from home. Why go somewhere with *people* when she could perform one hundred percent of her tasks remotely? Still, her boss Netossa asked that she at least show up once every couple months, just to know she was alive and functioning. It was annoying, but she could deal. She didn't totally hate her job (most days) and Netossa generally let her do her own thing. She could work whatever hours she wanted, so long as the job got done correctly and on time.

However, today was proving to be a day where she definitely hated what she did for a living. She had battled traffic to come into the office (on a Friday no less) and was almost immediately bombarded with texts as soon as she sat down at her desk. *Adora, AGAIN?!* She silently screamed at her phone as she read the rambling message. Enough was enough. She swiped a vest from the closet and swiped a hardhat from someone's desk. Scorpia tried to ask her where she

was off to so soon after arriving for the day, but one pointed look clearly told the short-haired woman to not even try. She scurried away with her coffee, bidding her Wildcat a nice weekend.

Yet another text chimed through in the amount of time it took for her to climb back into her truck. This time it was a picture paired with another entirely too long message. Catra groaned as she beheld it, not emotionally prepared to have another day of *this* . Hopefully when she showed up at the site- which to her annoyance was an hour and a half away, she could finally slap some sense into this contractor. It wasn't that complicated of a job;install a new pole out in the middle of nowhere so the farmers could get their internet and maybe not lose power so frequently (the nearest transformer was a good distance away;the voltage drop was ridiculous, maybe the cows weren't complaining but the clients sure were). Not even a particularly detailed pole at that;45'tall, medium class, only had a secondary line to attach and a couple comms. Sure the new transformer as well, but these bozos wouldn't be taking care of that piece. They literally just had to stick a large cylinder of wood in the ground and make sure the buzzing lines didn't touch so no one would get killed. Since it was an agricultural area the split neutral was a bit different, but if this crew couldn't manage to install an extra copper pole or two in the ground they really had no business being out here in the first place.

And obviously it *was* beyond them because their idiot crew leader had called her no less than 7 times over the past week about this job, not even counting all the texts and stray emails. Catra finally made up her mind that if pictures and overhead views from Google Earth wouldn't do it, not to mention her *extremely detailed blueprints* and all the time she'd spent on the phone with this woman, she'd go out and show this dumbass exactly where she could stick her pole.

"Where's Adora Grayson?" Catra demanded, without preamble, as she approached a shrimpy blond dude. He was obviously just the traffic signaler, though why he was even here she had no idea. *She* certainly hadn't called for a traffic control plan; just one more thing she'd have to take up with this so-called leader. It was a two lane road with a huge shoulder for god's sake! Their equipment wasn't blocking any part of the street. There was no reason to have someone here to direct traffic when they were literally just surrounded by corn and sleepy farms; just a waste of time and resources. She really hated Adora from the very pit of her stomach.

"Uhhhh. Who can I say is here?" The worker blinked at her, eyes more than a little wide. She supposed the lashing tail and bared fangs had something to do with his nervousness, not that she really cared about his comfort in the slightest. She was far too peeved for that.

"Catra. The designer." She said flatly. It sounded way more prestigious than it actually was. Her job was low-fat engineering; she evaluated the poles based on measurements taken by people out in the field, ran them through a couple of engineering programs and drew up construction plans telling the crews what to do. Normally it was pretty easy work, she cranked out a few jobs a week, but with how much this Adora Grayson had been hounding her about every last detail. Well, her lack of production this week was just one more thing to be irritated over.

"Oh. Right, right. Um, okay." He began to look around wildly, obviously searching for an adult to help him navigate this situation. Fortunately for him, a short, built woman with dreads came up to investigate.

"What's going on, Kyle? Who's she?" The woman sneered, not giving Kyle a chance to answer. She turned to face Catra, arms across her chest. "Listen lady, we don't let just anyone with a hardhat and vest wander up here. This is a damned construction site."

Catra gritted her back teeth together, claws sliding out of their own accord as she fought to gain control herself. Who did this punk think she was, addressing her like that? Truly, what random person wore personal protective equipment like a damn hardhat if they didn't need to? It was pretty fucking obvious that she belonged here. The bounds of this person's stupidity were endless; Adora must have trained them. "Well, you just explained everything I needed to know. You all are struggling so hard because you obviously can't *read*." She tapped the logo on the stupid flourescent vest she was forced to wear when at an active construction site. It proudly displayed the name of her company in bold, dark lettering. "I work for the place that hired your stupid asses. I also *designed* this whole fucking job, so yeah, I think I can be here. Especially since I have the hardhat and vest."

The dark skinned woman sniffed, unimpressed and unshaken by the information. "So? Why you here?"

She might actually smack this woman. "Just point me to Gayson. Your fearless leader has been blowing up my phone since apparently you idiots can't follow the pretty pictures I spend hours making."

utting a thumb behind her back, the crew member cackled. "Y eah, that sounds like Adora, calling on the ladies. Big trailer in the back. Cant miss it. Ill even text her so she knows 'The Designer ' is coming." The woman rolled her eyes as she emphasized Catra' s title. "Kyle, round up the guys. W e're going to lunch early . Let these two big shots figure it out."

"Grayson." Catra stated shortly , letting herself into the trailer. She didnt bother to knock, figuring that since her crew had warned her , Adora wouldnt be too surprised by her appearance.

"Hey-ya! The designer herself." Adora said warmly , smiling as she stood from the makeshift desk in her mobile office. "Not often we get a desk lackey out here."

"T rust me, this was *not* in my plans for the day." Catra crossed her arms over her chest, absently noting just how thick Adora' s were. It was very apparent it wasnt just her crew out hauling and lifting. "But someone keeps calling me, so here we are."

"How could I not call someone who looks so darn cute in that safety vest?" The crew leader mocked, eyeing down the length of Catra' s body, before she settled into a cocky grin. "Here we are, indeed. Gotta say , maybe I shoulda come in myself when we were bidding for this job. Might have met you a little sooner . Missed opportunity... But you're here now at least."

Catra was taken aback by the familiarity in the woman's tone, not to mention her suggestive gaze, but she shook off her confusion. She was not going to be distracted by this buff moron *no matter* how damn good she looked in her tight black shirt and dark wash jeans. Her heavy soled, steel toed boots added several extra inches on an already tall frame. Catra cleared her throat, trying to get back to the reason for her visit. "Flattery gets you nowhere with me, so drop it. You've called me countless times over the last few days to pick at every little detail. Your most recent text said you can't find the stake marking the new pole. Since you're such an incompetent, I thought I'd come and do your job *for you*."

Adora certainly didn't seem perturbed by Catra's brush-off or biting words, almost more pleased at hearing them. She gave a good natured smile and laughed, shaking her head at herself. "Yeah, this one has been a bit tricky, huh? That primary configuration"…

"Do NOT bring up those damn primary lines again!" Catra cut in, slamming herself down into the open chair in front of Adora's desk in a huff. They had spent nearly an hour yesterday going back and forth with one another over it. Adora was convinced it was one size, Catra *knew it was* another. That would have to wait until next week though, because these jokers had already wasted most of the day trying to find the spot for the new pole. She'd get them on the right path and then go back to her apartment and not talk to another soul for at least two weeks. This amount of socializing could not be healthy for her, especially when it was with pigheaded, blonde idiots.

"I'm telling you, it's 336." Adora shrugged as Catra tried to not notice exactly how well-defined her deltoids were as they moved. This woman must *live* at the gym. Her eyes glazed over as she continued to ruminate about Adora's shoulders. *A comfy place to sit…* Adora

continued on, thankfully not catching the faraway look to Catra's eyes as she got lost in a most inopportune, steamy daydream. She might have said more prior but Catra tuned back in again at, "Look, since you dont believe me, why dont you and I go take a look. Y ou can count the wires yourself and show me where this invisible stake is."

Catra pushed the last remaining dregs of her less than polite thoughts away, refocusing herself once more. She rose from the chair and turned on her heel to leave. "Exactly why Im here, Grayson. Let' s get going."

Less than five minutes later, after confirming with her crew to pack it up for a long lunch, Adora and Catra were walking down the road right of way to the west. Catra knew the stake was about 150' away from the area they had just walked away from. She'd had some trouble figuring out where to put the new pole location given the amount of brush and growth along the roadway, but there was a small brick building, possibly an old gas utility shed, that she'd had her fielder put the post close to. That was certainly easy enough to spy in the distance. She scowled at the idiocy of the team her company had hired to do this work, but was it a wonder they sucked so bad when Adora was in charge?

"So, how long you been designing for?" Adora asked amicably as they trotted down the shoulder, carefully avoiding the ditches and gullies in the gravel.

Catra sighed. Of course the blonde would try for chitchat;she was exactly the type. "W e *really* dont need to fill our time with small talk.

Im going to show you that youre an idiot, then be on my way . Maybe in the future Ill be unlucky enough to be paired with you again, but we certainly arent trying for a friendship in all of this."

Adora gave a small smile and mimicked zipping her mouth shut, shoving her hands in her jeans pockets. She began to whistle as they walked, which was not the least bit annoying to Catra. Not at all.

Fortunately for her short fuse, they arrived at the abandoned brick shack before much longer. Catra's mismatched eyes narrowed as she scanned the area for the red-tipped piece of wood that would mark where her pole needed to go. It was nowhere to be found. "Where is it? What did you do with it?" She faced the much taller woman headon, jabbing a finger in her direction.

Adora laughed, the sound coming right from her belly. "You.you think I removed the stake? Why would I do that, Cat?" She glanced down at the hand that was positioned in the middle of her chest and smirked. Catra hadnt quite realized that shed actually touched the other woman while accusing her. It made the tips of her ears burn, all the more so when Adora seemed perfectly content with it staying right there. Of course, Catra herself also made no attempt to remove it. It was just the tip of her finger , but even through Adora's shirt, she found the burn of the other woman's skin most pleasant in a highly irritating manner. She could indulge for a couple seconds longer if they both werent going to mention that it was happening in the first place. Adora continued to speak. "Let' s look around for it. Im sure the property owner saw this thing in the ground and decided it didnt need to be there. Probably tossed it to the side or something. Well find it, Ill grab my measuring tools and well put it back."

There was so much wrong with what the blonde was suggesting, but Catra also did not feel like alerting her fielder to come out to put a post in the ground when she was perfectly capable of doing that herself. Getting someone out here would just take more time and she knew there weren't any underground lines they could accidentally hit. The risk was pretty minimal, even if corporate would probably frown at her methods. But what they didn't know ... "Fine. And don't call me Cat. You don't know me."

"What can I call you then? Madame Designer?" Adora teased with a lazy smile, finally reaching up to Catra's finger and removing it from her person. She did not immediately release her grasp, their hands falling awkwardly between them, still intertwined. Adora jerked her head in the direction of the abandoned outbuilding. "Wanna check back behind there first?"

Catra gave a small nod, allowing herself to be pulled along by the blonde. When they reached the area behind the building, Adora made some pretense of looking around in the tall grass for the missing piece of wood, before shrugging it off as a lost cause. She turned to face the shorter woman, eyes twinkling. "So. We doing this?"

Catra bit her lip, not really needing to ask what the blonde meant by this'. Not with how close she was standing. Not with how their hands were still laced. Not when Adora had the audacity to look like *that* , with that body, those arms ... She was truly the worst. "You are the most *annoying* person on the face of this planet."

"Yeah, yeah." Adora drolled, not the least bit waylaid by the insult. She paused, then licked her lips. "Fingers or mouth?"

The brunette threw her hardhat somewhere off to the side, shrugging out of her neon vest. That shit was like the opposite of sexy and had no business on her person at the moment. As much as she hated this arrogant asshole, the idea of seeing her on her knees in front of her was certainly worth every agonizing moment they had spent talking this week. Catra was anxious to get to it already. "Use your stupid mouth. Since it'll get you to shut it finally."

"Shut it? I don't think you'd like that at all, princess. I'm good, but probably couldn't get you off quite as well... But I *do* think you'll like exactly what this 'stupid mouth' is capable of." Without another word, Adora pushed her against the rough brickwork of the building. She wasted no time parting Catra's lips open with her tongue, her hands already exploring the lithe frame of the woman in front of her. She cupped her tits, while running her other hand over her waist. Her hand was so large, Catra swore one was almost enough to completely encircle her. They were so firm and sure in their motions that Catra was already swallowing the moans that threatened to escape. There would be no dealing with the blonde after this if she vocalized her appreciation so readily.

Catra matched Adora's kiss with equal ferocity, adding not so gentle nips from her sharp teeth. The other woman tensed at every bite before somehow coming at her with even more force. It was an enthralling back and forth; a physical altercation of animalistic attraction. She felt no small amount of satisfaction at the low growl she pulled from the other woman as her claws dug into the shoulders she had been admiring a short time before. Spurred on by the

pleasing knick of pain, Adora pulled away, giving her a lopsided grin. "Kitty's got claws"…

Catra rolled her eyes. "And she likes to use them.' Yeah, yeah, heard it all before."

"Oh, so you've done this before then? Suddenly I don't feel so special any more."Adora needled playfully , trailing a line of kisses down her neck. Catra's eyes shuddered closed for a second at the much different sensation. She was relieved when she felt the other woman's teeth graze her skin. It was not nearly enough, not even close to as hard as she liked it, but anything *soft* was dangerous;not what she was looking for with any of this. She certainly wouldn't give Adora the satisfaction of begging for more either.

"You're not *special* . You're an absolute pain in my ass who just so happens to want to go down on me. This is purely a business arrangement."

"A pain in your ass, huh?" Adora considered for a moment before placing her hands firmly on Catra's ass, giving it a nice squeeze followed by a most appreciative slap. Catra squeaked at the unexpected motion, moving her hands up from Adora's shoulders to fist through her short hair. She gave it a yank as a reprimand, but that only seemed to fuel the blonde all the more. "Yours sure is fine.But I'm definitely getting sidetracked here. Like you said. Time to get down to business."Without warning, she pulled Catra's leggings down, the now half bare woman shivering at the sudden exposure.

Adora gave a long, low whistle. “ *Madame Designer!* You can't possibly say this wasn't in the plans for your Friday , because no panties? Hmm, hmm, hmmm...”

“Shut the fuck up and just fuck me already! God, you're just absolutely terrible. Cocky for no damn good reason, stupid as shit since you can't tell a triplex from a bare aluminum conductor.” In retrospect, it sounded a lot better in Catra's head. In her defense, she had her pants off with a complete stranger and was about to get eaten out in semi-public. The brain thoughts weren't exactly coherent at the moment.

“Y ou really wanna talk wires when you're the one who' s bare around here?” Catra just pushed down on Adora' s head in response, trying to put the woman where she wanted her to be. *Anything to get her to finally stop talking* . Adora laughed at her attempt to position her, clucking her tongue. “Ah, ah, ah kitten! Flattered that you want me so bad, feeling's mutual by the way, but that's not what I had in mind.”

Before Catra could ask what thought such a brainless twit like her could possibly have rolling around in that skull, she was lifted straight up into the air by the muscled arms she'd been so admiring earlier . She was certain that she squeaked again, but it quickly melded into a deep groan as she felt Adora's hot breath surround her core. Catra was balanced perfectly on Adora's shoulders, back against the rough wall, the blonde's mouth so delightfully close yet far away from where she needed her to be. She glanced down to the face below her, as if needing to confirm her current position with her own eyes. A bright blue gaze met her before giving her a wink. “Ohh, gonna watch me, huh? Kinky .”

Catra was given no chance to respond as Adora closed the distance with one wide swipe of her tongue that quickly melded into darting perfection. It was embarrassing as hell to admit that first brush was almost all she needed to come, but it had been a while since she'd indulged in anything other than her own hand. And Adora was irritating beyond all measure, but *fuck* if she didn't know what she was doing. She laved at Catra's swollen clit with practiced measure, periodically abandoning her onslaught to tease the tip of her tongue at her entrance, refusing to go any deeper each time. Every time she did so, a chant of "Fuck, fuck, fuck, goddammit, *I hate you*!" sounded from Catra's mouth, her hands pushing the blonde's head forward to bring her tongue inside. Adora resisted the force, content to keep Catra on edge. Finally Catra had enough and ripped the other woman's head back, one hand coming around to the side of her neck. She didn't dare squeeze, but her grip wasn't a loving caress either. Catra growled, "Get your fingers in me *now*."

The asshole gave her a lazy smile, eyes heavily lidded over. "Figuring out my likes so easily. Probably bad form to not ask first, though. But I'll say it now; choke me, baby and I'll come *real* hard."

"Bold of you to think you're even getting anything from me after this." Catra retorted, wondering how obvious her lie was. Of course she wanted her hands over every chiseled pane, wanted to return the favor and make the blonde beg for release. But Adora certainly didn't need to know that. She might think Catra liked her or something. That simply wouldn't do. "Fingers. Now."

"Sure thing, Madame." Another infuriating wink as Adora's hand snaked up between her thighs. For one terrifying second Catra

thought the teasing would only continue, until she felt one blissfully thick digit enter her. She audibly sighed in relief, before it qickly turned to panting yelps as Adora fucked her soundly, sucking her clit as she did.

At the dual ministrations, Catra suddenly had no control over her reactions. Any attempt to mask her noises was now a laughable thought- Adora just felt too good and was hitting the right spots too perfectly. She hated how easily she responded to each thrust of the woman's fingers (now two, knuckle deep, relentlessly driving into her), how it made her hips stutter to feel Adora's mouth work against her. Desperate moans and needy cries poured from Catra as she grinded herself down, taking everything Adora had to offer and only wanting more. The rough stonework of the building she was against was probably tearing up her back even through her shirt, but her only lament was that the scratches wouldnt be from Adora' s fingernails.

It did not take long for Catra to be pulled over the edge, Adora driving her masterfully. With one final surge she fisted her hands through the blonde's hair, holding her head in place as Catra qivered and shook around her . She was certain her thighs were a vice grip around Adora's head, but she really couldn't care less so long as the woman remained standing. Adora slowed her motions, letting Catra work through the last pulses of her release. She slumped backwards, trying to catch her breath as she rested against the structure behind her. Catra swore she felt the other woman press one reverent kiss to her center before she vacated the area, but that was far too disturbing a thought to even consider. She had no room for tenderness, particularly from strangers who were nothing more than an irritating but fantastic lay.

"So."Adora began, slowly lowering Catra back down to the ground once she had nodded that she was ready. Adora massaged her shoulders a little, rolling them out. Ruefully she realized it was a bad day to be in a black t-shirt since she had ended up wearing a dripping woman like a scarf. The crew was going to have a field day heckling her about what she spent her lunch hour doing. She already made up her mind to send them home early;this work shit could wait until Monday. As Catra made herself decent once more, Adora fought for a topic she and the woman she'd just fucked against a wall could possibly have to talk about. Work really was about the only option, since Carra had so vehemently shot down her attempt earlier to play the Get to Know You game. "About that pole stake"…

Catra sighed as gathered up her discarded bottoms, pulling them on her again. At least she hadn't been stripped entirely;that would be completely mortifying. She grumbled, not quite ready to face Adora now that everything was said and done. "I'll replace it on Monday morning."

"You or?"…

"Yes, me. I would have done it today, saved us both a lot of trouble, but I don't exactly carry those posts around with me."

Adora looked thoughtful for a moment, then nodded, rocking back and forth on her heels. "I'll tell the crew to come in late Monday then, but I'll be here first thing. Just in case you need a hand."

The brunette narrowed her eyes, before the corner of her mouth crooked up into a grin. "A hand, huh?" She cast her eyes around the area once more, glancing up at the lines above them. "I might stick around after too. Supervise your dumb asses and make sure you don't fuck things up too badly. You already managed to waste an entire day here."

The blonde arched a brow, ignoring the jibe at her productivity. "You know, we still need to figure out that primary size. We wanna make sure to get the right spool on the new pole."

Catra felt a cluster headache begin to build behind her left eye. So hot, but so absolutely aggravating. "... We can argue about that next week."

"My trailer's wide open for you any time." Adora replied, before feigning nonchalance. "Actually it is right now if you wanna... the guys won't be back for a while yet."…

"Shut up, Grayson." Catra began to walk back towards where she had parked, hips swaying of their own accord as she knew the other woman was watching intently. "You can wait until Monday, like a good girl."

"Yes, Madame Designer." Adora toned, trailing after her like a lost puppy. It wasn't often that two people would be looking forward to Monday morning at work so much.


@candycornsnake1

Chapter End Notes

(If any one is curious, my Adult Life is as a Designer. This Fic was fueled after I bitched enough times about some stupid crew leader trying to tell me how to do my job. One thing lead to another and well. If you liked it... go thank rokumonshi. Or itcanprobablysmellfear. LegendaryDork certainly didnt discourage it nor did I hear TheMidgardSerpent say anything.

Y'all are terrible and I love you so much for it.)

(PS;I did not fuck that crew leader . Wouldnt want to leave y'all wondering. 😖)

Now contains the amazing art piece done by Candycornsnake! Thank you again my friend, it is wonderful. Check out their other amazing (NSFW) artwork on T witter @candycornsnake1

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Despite her adventure on Friday, Catra treated the weekend like any other. She slept in as late as she damn well pleased on Saturday morning, laid around in her pajamas for the majority of the afternoon. Scorpia called her up on Saturday night to invite her to lunch the following day, citing that her bestie had seemed a little out of it the day before so they definitely needed a hang sesh. Catra tried to beg off, stating she wasnt interested in the slightest, but Scorpia barrelled on ahead with, "Oh, I dont accept any of that."

True to her word, Scorpia appeared at her door at the ungodly hour of 11 AM on a *Sunday* , chattering on about dim sum as Catra begrudgingly got dressed. "You'll just love it, Wildcat! Family style eating and just all so *tasty* . The soup dumplings alone!" Her friend looked near to tears over merely talking about the dish.

Catra ended up glad she relented, because the dumplings really were that good. She did pitch a fit when her friend tried to drag her to the mall of all places after eating. "Scorpia. No one goes *shopping* anymore. What the hell is still even open?"

"Oh, Wildcat, not the mall-mall. That place is a ghost town, wooo buddy! I think even the Cinnabon bailed." Catra nodded, thinking her point had been made. Once Hot Topic and Auntie Anne's left, it was for sure dead. Those franchises would die on that hill though. "I'm talking about the Outlets! 60% off or more!"

Which is how Catra ended up at the outlet mall, paused outside the door to a shop and shaking her head wildly. A poster with a pair of buxom babes in flimsy undergarments stared down at her from either side of the entrance. "Uh-uh, no way . Jesus Christ, Scorp. Did you

bring me *lingerie* shopping!?There are boundaries in friendships. Learn them!"

"Not specifically , but yknow . We're here, it' s here..."The tall woman shrugged. "and it' s almost my anniversary. I know what my lady likes."

"... Sadly , so do I, for as many times as you've told me *way* too many details."Forlornly Catra made her way into the V ictoria's Secret outlet, trying to project as much Leave me the fuck alone, I *do not* require any assistance'into her body language for the benefit of any "helpful"sales associates.

Scorpia made a beeline right to the pretty, skimpy things, completely abandoning her friend to sulk in the chairs by the dressing rooms. Fortunately no employees had tried to accost her as she made her way there, probably thinking she was the person Scorpia was buying for. What a terrifying image.

She grew bored after a while, her phone no longer distracting her from the looks the other shoppers were giving her as she stewed in stormy silence. She considered for a half moment checking her work email, but she wasn't *quite* at that level yet. Catra had no idea where Scorpia went and was just generally over the bright lights and din of the store. She shot a quick text that her friend would find her outside, possibly laying across a bench, dead, after choking on the perfume stink of Vickie's.

She tried to keep her eyes focused forward as she headed to the exit, but a flash of red caught her eye. Catra had a *very* similar thong shoved in the back corner of her top drawer;an artifact from the last failure of a relationship she had. As was apparent on Friday, she usually opted to go without, but maybe.She shook of f the thought with a stern glint to her eye and made it out of the store unscathed.

At least Scorpia didn't keep her waiting for too much longer , tottering out with several bags in claw. She offered to show Catra her purchases, but the brunette gave a firm "Hell no!"to that and they

continued on, Scorpia wanting to stop in at nearly every store. As a result of her friend's love of capitalism when it was offered at a discount, Catra ended up back at her apartment far later than she was anticipating. Not late by any stretch, but that many hours out in the real world had left her feeling drained. She puttered around a little aimlessly, trying to shake off whatever was bugging her, before tucking into some leftovers she found in the back of her fridge. As she ate, she typed out a quick email to Netossa to say that she'd be taking a personal day tomorrow and Tuesday. It wasn't like her to do, but Catra had plenty of PTO and they could just deal. She saw several emails that made her roll her eyes, but it wasn't anything that couldn't wait. She turned on something mindless to zone out to in the dwindling hours of her Sunday evening, eventually falling asleep to the quiet drone.

The first thing that Catra noticed when she woke was that her neck was incredibly sore. It wasn't unlike her to crash on the couch; sometimes it was just far too much effort to drag herself to the bed. But she'd fallen asleep half upright, head in a rigid position against the arm of the couch, and her phone was resting against her chin. Doing while flicking through the bottomless pit of despair and inane content that made up Twitter. Kind of pathetic in retrospect.

The second thing she noticed was that it was ungodly early, like "I've only ever seen this hour after crawling home from the bar" level of early. Despite the time, she found herself weirdly awake. She supposed that getting every last second of her hastily decided-upon vacation wasn't a terrible plan, though two or three more hours of sleep would have been vastly preferable. With a sigh, Catra rolled out her stiff neck and padded into the kitchen, French press coffee on her mind.

Cup of joe in hand, Catra curled up in her window seat with a book, a large, fluffy afghan draped over the bottom half of her body. The sun was just beginning to rise, but there was enough light to read by. She'd been looking forward to the novel immensely; the sequel to some space necromancer book everyone was talking about. The first

one was pretty cool, but this continuation? Turned out to be way too much to follow this early in the morning. The stick was angry *and* insane;she really couldnt deal with both right now , choosing to set it aside for the time being.

Glancing at her shelf, no other books looked super appealing. She was between Netflix shows right now, and rewatching something she'd seen a million times before sounded dull. Catra began to grow irritated;awake far earlier than normal on a day that she didnt have to work, with the promise that work would only be far more insistent as a result of her desire to take a day or two for herself. The crook in her neck was starting to release, but still felt absurdly tight. Maybe a hot bath would help that particular complaint.

A short while later, she sunk into the scalding water with a noise that was a cross between a sigh of relief and a wince. The old clawfoot tub had been touted by the landlord as a major selling point of her apartment;practically the sole reason she should put up with the lack of central air, the drafty windows, and a kitchen that was barely wide enough for two people to fit. In truth, Catra did not give a flying fuck about it, only agreeing to rent this space because it was cheap as hell and at least the tub had been updated to also have a showerhead. But today was already weird enough since she was awake at 6:30 AM, so why not make it even stranger by taking a bath too?

The activity was outside her norm, but the heat from the water was loosening the crick in her neck considerably. She was grateful for the ease, but still felt.wired, for lack of a better word. On edge, but not quite anxious. Catra gritted her teeth in frustration, willing her mind to stay focused on the hot water she was stewing in, utterly determined that she *would relax, dammit* even if her thoughts were just as resolute to stray towards forbidden topics. It didnt take long for the bath to be judged a futile effort;she quickly toweled off, and wrapped herself in the plush robe she'd treated herself to in a rare moment of consumer therapy.

Cloaked in the soft Turkish cotton robe, Catra lay down on the middle of her bed. Sleep seemed beyond her still, but maybe if her body relaxed a little, her mind would follow suit. Her hand had been resting by the outside of her thigh, inert against the comforter, but slowly made its way up and inward. She stifled a moan at the first brush of her fingertip against her aching bud. She paused to revel in the shudder of pleasure, a little surprised to find herself as turned on as she was. Catra let her thoughts drift into the mindset of things that would normally make this activity a rousing success before picking up the pace with her fingers. The images that came to mind at these times were never very focused on specifics, just the idea of large hands and firm muscles holding her down were enough for her breath to quicken. She lost herself to that, until… *a flash of blue eyes peering up at her with a devilish smirk* . Catra gave an involuntary moan, working her fingers a little more wildly at the memory of digging her claws into short, blonde hair and pressing that handsome face harder into her dripping cunt. Realizing what was happening, Catra recoiled against the place her lust had dragged her, halting her motions entirely.

Convinced she'd gotten a grip on herself again, Catra started up once more. Everything was going well;a nameless, faceless top above her, ready to drive her over the edge. Within minutes, she was there, so close, just needed one flash of dirty inspiration and her fingers crooked just right, to give herself the release she so craved... but a tall frame with infuriating swagger invaded her mind, clawing for her undivided attention. Ripping her hand away from herself with a guttural growl, she cursed the universe out for being such a *fucking bitch* and rolled out of bed. Within minutes she had thrown on clothes (totally whatever she could reach;she hadnt spent time laying out an outfit yesterday afternoon, never) and was in her car, mind scrambling to come up with a plan on what to do once she actually got there.

"Hey there, Madame Designer! Good to see ya."Adora rose from her desk with a bright smile as the door to her trailer opened, rushing

forward the short distance to greet her visitor. "Hope you like it black."

Catra blinked at the cup of coffee being extended to her. She really hadn't been sure how this would go; stuck somewhere between *Adora, I was trying to jerk off earlier and couldn't stop thinking about your hot mouth on my clit; mind helping a gal out?* and just pinning the blonde to the floor and grinding one out on her before leaving to get on with her life. But however it would unfold, being handed a cup of coffee as part of her greeting hadn't factored into any of the scenarios that played in her head during her drive here. As a reflex, Catra snorted and crossed her arms over her chest, refusing to look Adora in the eye. "Already had coffee today."

The blonde seemed to deflate a little, but kept up a good face. "Right. Of course, of course. Might be cold anyway, I, uh, was expecting you a little earlier"…

"Expecting me? Hmph, that's pathetic even for you." Normally derision felt pretty good, but at the confused *and* hurt puppy dog look in Adora's blue eyes, something sunk in Catra's chest. "Look, I know I was supposed to come put that stake in for you first thing but I forgot I had today and tomorrow off. That's why I'm so late." She gave a little wave of her hand, hoping to distract Adora from what was probably the clumsiest cover she had ever tried in her life. Only if Adora were truly an idiot would she be buying tickets to what Catra was trying to sell. "Just gimmie that coffee." Though it was definitely breaking most of the rules she'd set for herself during her drive over by here accepting the cup, she still grumbled out a low, "Thanks."

"Uh, yeah. Don't mention it." Adora said with a perplexed look on her face. She ultimately decided to not give the explanation much more thought, choosing instead to sit back down in the chair behind her desk and gesturing for Catra to take a seat at the one across from her.

The blonde drummed her fingers across the side of her cup, looking around her own mobile office as if it were her first time here. She

stopped fidgeting with her cup in favor of pushing a pen around the top of her desk. That kept her amused for a good 30 seconds until it fell to the floor and rolled away, lost under a cabinet. Catra impassively observed the restless behavior, wondering if an orgasm was really worth having anything to do with this awkward moment. Seeming suddenly to make up her mind about something, Adora gave a definitive nod, and spoke once more. "I thought about you all weekend."

Catra tried to not choke at the words, because *of course* she'd been mid-sip as they were uttered. She found out on Friday that Adora wasn't the type to mince words, but she really went for it here. What the hell do you say to that? "... Okay."

Probably not the response the blonde had been hoping for, but she also didn't seem too dismayed by it. "Yeah. Gotta say, princess, you left me definitely wanting more on Friday. And then when you were so late this morning..."

"It's 9 AM. What the hell time did you get here?" Catra spat out, not exactly appreciating that her supposed tardiness was being brought up again. Adora should be thanking her lucky stars she'd decided to show up at all. *Wanting more… What, does she think I owe her anything?*

"Oh, uh. A while ago." The blonde waved off the question entirely. "But anyway, I'm just really glad to see you here because honestly, Madame, I wanna fuck you again."

Between the intensity of the look Adora was giving her, eyes blown a little wider than normal, leaning forward in her chair just to be that much closer, Catra was left feeling a certain kind of way. As Adora leaned forward, she leaned back, a picture of ease and comfort even as heat began to curl low in her abdomen. A purr wanted to escape her chest, but like hell she was going to let that happen. Her tail lashed once behind her, multicolored eyes narrowing as she considered the words. "Fuck me, huh?" Adora nodded, eying Catra greedily. Before the blonde could open her mouth to say anything

more, let alone move from her seat to follow up on her wants, Catra was on the prowl. With a limber grace she rose from her chair, setting the barely touched lukewarm coffee on a filing cabinet, and climbing into Adora's lap to straddle her fully.

Adora crooked a smile with a stuttered breath, eyes glazing over as Catra made herself comfortable. "Yeah. *So badly.*"

Catra gave a hum of approval and lowered her hips down, immediately feeling the hard press of something hit her thigh. With a quick, sharp movement she grasped the source and pushed backwards with her hand. Adora gasped at the contact, going rigid, fingernails digging into the arms of her chair. "Packing at work, Grayson? How presumptuous of you." Catra gave another jerk, with a squeeze.

"Ah! Ah, *ahem*, uh. Well, I usually do, um, pack. Just more comfortable with something, yknow, there most of the time." Adora explained. Sure this was going in the direction she had been hoping for their morning, was the exact reason why she had told her crew to not even bother showing up before lunch (if at all), but damn if it just wasn't the hottest thing to have Catra take the lead. An unforeseen but very happy turn of events, one even a service top like her could revel in. "But it's a pack and play. I wasn't sure what size you, *Ah! Jesus you're good at that*, wasn't sure what size you preferred so I do have others with me"…

Catra leaned back a moment, not quite removing her hand from the tantalizing bulge in Adora's jeans, but definitely pulling away enough to give the blonde a most withering look. "Are you telling me that you brought 'The Bag' with you? My god, are we in our early twenties? Did you have to sneak out of your dorm to get here?"

"Hey! Some would find that very considerate of me." The other woman protested with a slight pout. She then cocked a grin, shuddering her eyes slightly as Catra continued to stroke the length of her. "And I'm *all* about my lady's pleasure."

With her other hand, Catra reached up and grabbed Adora's chin, tilting it up so they were nearly face to face. She narrowed her eyes to bare slits, trying to ignore just how blue Adora's were as they peered up at her in surprise. "Let's get one thing settled right here and now, Grayson. No matter what, no matter how many times you rail me, or how good it is... I am *not* your 'lady'."

You're not yet, at least. Adora chose to keep this comment to herself; the back-and-forth lunge and parry was half the fun in all this. But with all her posturing, Adora certainly didn't want to scare away such a worthy match as Catra was proving to be. Adora could go on with her little game if it amused her so much, but not without ruffling her fur as much as she could along the way. "You think it's gonna be good, huh?"

"That's the only reason I came here, you moron! Like I really would want to see your stupid face otherwise."

Adora considered for a moment, resting her hands on the waist so conveniently placed in front of her. She ran her thumbs along it, appreciative of the choice to wear a maroon crop top to a construction site. So completely unprofessional, but that stripe of exposed, tight midriff had Adora practically salivating already. "So this is another business proposal' like last week?"

"Duh. What else would it be?" Catra drove a fingertip into the blonde's forehead, poking the spot where a brain ought to be. She was pretty sure Adora's model came without one installed. "It's not as if I *like* you or anything."

The blonde arched a brow at the woman atop her lap, rolling her eyes with a warm smile. "Right, because that would be so embarrassing for you... Talking is fun and all, but you do want my cock, right?"

Catra stilled at the question, only managing to halt her sharp intake of breath at the last second. Maybe she'd wanted to get her mouth on her pussy; it might have been all she'd thought about as she sped

here, the salty sweet taste as she fluttered her tongue against the hard, swollen clit. But Catra was adaptable and the thought of getting stretched out by this beautiful, blonde butch already had her dripping. "Ugh. Yes. But you know what? I can't even stand the sight of you." The brunette released her grasp on the strap, Adora groaning a little at the loss of contact, and stood. She turned away and slowly began to work her leggings down. Catra took her time, knowing even while faced away that Adora was drinking in every centimeter of newly exposed skin. She flushed at the idea of it; a way to put this braggart in her place. The satisfaction was doubled when she heard Adora groan from low in her chest at the sight of Catra's lacy red thong.

"Oh, so you do have underwear. It must have just been laundry day on Friday." Adora cracked, licking her lips at the whisper of gossamer fabric that framed Catra's perfect 'spank me raw' ass. She knew the jibe wasn't going to go over well, but sometimes Adora's mouth ran before her brain could catch up. It happened quite frequently around hot women and Catra was damn near the sexiest she'd ever seen.

The brunette growled, turning back around to imperiously address the other woman. "Stop talking, you moron. Take your pants off, now." Adora obeyed with a crafty grin, dutifully unbuckling her belt, sliding it out of the loops. She held it in her hand for a moment, raising a questioning eyebrow in Catra's direction. She scowled heavily at the implication, not needing the blonde to fill in the gaps for her. Apparently Adora thought she was a rope bunny. "Yeeeah, not sure what you think you'll do with that. Do I look like someone who'd let a stranger restrain them?"

"Nah, more like the type that lets them get nose deep in you against a wall." Adora chuckled at her own wit and stood, kicking off her boots, and unzipping her jeans to shimmy out of them.

Tight black boxer briefs displayed the sizeable bulge that had Catra begging for a cool drink. She pushed away her weakness and growled. "Bring that up again, and I swear ..." She didn't have an end

to that threat, but Catra was certain she could make it most unpleasant if need be.

The blonde considered for a minute, weighing if it was worth the risk to push. But from the way Catra's throat bobbed with a thick swallow as Adora shed her bottoms, she was far more interested in sealing this deal than making some dumb joke. Adora replied, nonplussed by the bared fangs from her soon to be bedpartner. "But actually , princess, the belt's for my hands, if you so agree. I like to try to get out;it gets real fun when I do."She waggled her eyebrows with a smirk that was just dripping in suggestion.

Catra considered the words, mind trying to catch up to what exactly was being proposed. That.wasn't what she'd been picturing but it wasn't terrible either . Not one to take well to being outplayed, she merely scoffed out an "idiot."

"Hmm, that' s not a yes or a no, so well just toss that one to the side. Within arm's reach though, just in case."She placed the leather accessory on the top of her desk and hooked her thumbs at the top of her boxers, ready to pull them down. "Oh.um, I take really good care of my straps but like, how do you know that, right?W e barely know each other."Adora said it with a mocking cadence, despite the honest truth of the words. "So I have a condom with me, jeans pocket. I, ah, wanna be respectful about what goes in my partner..."

That was a new one on Catra as well. It made sense, but like hell any of her previous flings had ever shown that level of consideration or foresight. Catra really didn't know what to say , so she fell back on her favorite defense. "At least I won't get knocked up with your stupid kid then. Fate worse than death there. All that silicone had me real worried."

"Not your best comeback, but I'm gonna just blame it on how bad you want me right now."She resumed pulling down her boxers, amused to hell at how Catra was training her gaze anywhere but down. The woman's tail was lashing wildly behind her, looking like she wanted nothing more than to pounce but was far too proud to

give into such base desires. As Adora kicked away her underwear and tightened her harness just a smidge, she teased out, "You can peek, yknow."

Adora's flippancy was met with a hand in the middle of her chest giving her a sharp shove. Not for the first time she was glad that she hated chairs with wheels, at least when she toppled backwards the chair remained firmly in its place. She laughed in spite of the barely veiled aggression, clucking her tongue in mock admonishment. "Eager, are we?"

Catra faced the smug blonde, resisting every urge to knock her across the face at the way she had one hand crooked behind her head, watching Catra with a grin. Before she could make good on that urge, she got up and grabbed Adora's discarded jeans from the floor. Finding what she was looking for, she returned to the lounging idiot but kept her back towards the other woman. "Just shut up already and make this worth my time."Adora gave a noncommittal hum as Catra straddled herself over Adora's hips while turned away from her. To look down at that face as she was taking the woman's strap. That was way too close to real intimacy. Catra simply couldn't deal with that, not when all she was looking for was a good, hard pounding. She tore open the protection with her teeth before reaching a hand below her to roll it onto the strap. Adora gave a lusty sigh as her fingers slipped it down to the base. She hated that she sort of enjoyed the action, lashing out against the flood of heat that came from wrapping Adora's hard cock up before it would fuck her soundly. "Ugh, shouldn't you be doing this? It's all slippery and gross."

"Lubed, babe."Adora reached a hand around, fingers lightly dragging against the lacy thong that barely covered Catra's aching pussy. She snickered at the damp fabric. "Looks like we won't need it, though. Is all that for me?"She pressed a little more firmly, though fingers barely grazed Catra's clit. One small whine escaped her lips, before being savagely bitten off by the stubborn willfulness of someone wanting to hide how turned on she really was.

With great control, Catra muttered out. "Is gagging also part of your kinks? Because I'd really like to get you to shut up and I think physical restraint might be the only way."

"Aww, thanks for checking in! Mmmm, you can use those cute little panties if you really want." Adora snapped the waistband of Catra's thong, chuckling. It was a joke- mostly. Her mouth had already been all up on that beautiful cunt, lapping up the sweetness and driving Catra to the brink with her tongue. Gagging wasn't normally in her wheelhouse, but hey, what's life without a little variety?

"Not an option, because I'm not taking them off for you." With deft fingers, she pulled the thin fabric to the side, lowering herself down. The reversed position was a little odd for her to angle correctly, but when Adora's hand came in to try and assist the efforts, Catra swatted it away. "Christ, I can manage. Just, I dunno, play with my tits or something. Be *useful* for once."

"Oh, yes ma'am, can do!" The blonde reached up and around gleefully. At the same time as she began to massage Catra's chest, teasing the stiffening peak, Catra lined herself up and worked the shaft into herself. Adora tensed as she watched that tight pussy swallow the length of her, resisting every urge to pull on the other woman's hips to guide her the rest of the way but figuring the assistance would be met with more venom. Catra wasted no time before rolling herself against the strap, no delay for adjustment needed. She rocked herself without abandon, Adora mesmerized at how readily and eagerly she took the whole thing. "Can I take off your shirt?" She barely breathed out the request, wanting so badly to feel every part of Catra under her hands.

"Ff, *mmmm*, it'll get you to shut up. I'm trying to enjoy myself here." Catra held up her arms, vaguely annoyed that she'd had to slow down her pace to acquiesce to the blonde's request. But maybe it would get Adora to start being an active participant in this whole thing; Catra was all about taking what she wanted, but she could get this experience with her own dildo in the privacy of her apartment. If

the stupid woman wouldn't leave her mind, she could at least have the decency to fuck her properly.

Adora took in the expanse of skin that she was just greeted with, tracing it with her fingertips, once again captivated by the sight of Catra's body. The woman atop her shivered at her light touches, a small growl escaping her throat. Adora was just giving some serious thought to asking Catra to please switch positions to face her so she could take in all her beauty when her ruminations were interrupted.

"Jesus, I'm used to having to do all the work when it comes to you, but do you mind putting *some* effort in here?" Catra snapped, turning her head to give the blonde a glare over her shoulder. She had slowed herself down even more, thoroughly annoyed that she was having to give instructions for Adora to actually get around to fucking her. "I thought you were supposed to be good at this!"

"Oh! Right, right. Fuck." Adora shook her head clear, focusing on the task at hand finally, and bucked her hips up, feet flat on the floor to give herself some extra drive. She may have been hypnotized by how good Catra's ass looked as her hips churned around her cock, but her keening wail was more than enough to bring the blonde to action. She slotted both hands down around her partner's waist, guiding them into a relentless push-and-pull.

As the pace was set, Catra reached a hand behind her, fisting it into the front of Adora's shirt to give herself better leverage to grind down in time with Adora's thrusts up. "*Oh*, god damn that's good. So, so good. Fuck!" Her breath was ragged and torn; the strap filling her, riding Adora for all she was worth.

The blonde panted in time with her thrusts, hands gripped tightly around Catra's hips, pushing them down. Watching this gorgeous woman get stretched out over her, the strap hitting against her own clit in just the best way, she might even come before Catra did- a completely unacceptable event in Adora's eyes. She did her best to drive even more insistently, wanting to hit every spot just right. Catra leaned back into the motion, her hand moving to the back of Adora's

head to brace herself against the blonde's chest by sprawling out on the front of her. Adora was granted a full view of her body as they moved together. "Fuck. You're so beautiful, Catra."

It was the first time Adora had ever said her full name, at least when they were in person. Stilted, overly professional correspondence leading up to her stomping to the site certainly didn't count. Had she not been on another plane, she might admonish the woman for being so bold with her. Instead she just allowed herself this small moment of pretending this could be more than it was and let a full body whine escape, furrowing her brows together.

One of Adora's hands moved from her waist to her breast, pinching and playing marvelously at the stiff peak. Catra could not help the sounds that were pulled from her, especially as Adora continued to whisper sweet praise into her ear. The most beautiful woman she'd ever seen, drop dead gorgeous, so sinfully sexy... They were all hallmark compliments, completely lacking in originality, and showed, once and for all, that Adora didn't have one unique tumbleweed of a thought rolling around the barren wasteland that was her head.

But damn if Catra didn't drink up every syllable. She swallowed it with gluttonous rapture, tilting her head back for more, Adora only all too happy to oblige the request by filling in with sweet kisses against her neck and ears. She flinched into and away from the blonde's mouth, the succor of the woman's lips far too easy of an addiction. The covetous part of her still greedily took in everything that was offered, begging for it to quench her most sun-scorched parts. She welcomed every platitude, every trite phrase, as if it were part of a new language made in secret just for her. And in that moment, she almost believed it all too.

"C'mon, Cat," That name, that familiarity; who was this audacious person that so invaded her mind, giving her things she had taught herself how to survive without? "Come for me, I want to see that beautiful face as you break"…

Instead of complying, she stuttered out. "Harder." Adora was all too quick to listen, hips rising out of the chair to meet Catra's demands. When even that only prompted another choked repetition of the same command, Catra slammed her hands forward, gripping onto the desk in front of her as Adora bent her over. She was certain ten deep gouges had been worn into the top of the desk, but that was the furthest concern from her mind as Adora's calloused fingers began to rub circles on her clit in time with the pulses of her strap.

Catra broke first, so relentlessly driven to pleasure by Adora's strap sliding in and out of her and the woman's hand working against her. She gave a shuddering cry, churning her hips back to saturate herself in the pure pleasure that had been coaxed from her. She bit into her own arm to muffle the sound as Adora slowed her motions to work her through the final seconds of her release. Catra panted against her arm for a moment, feeling loose and limber as she beat against the walls she had created for herself. Feeling Adora shift to remove herself, Catra choked out, "Adora, wait."

The blonde froze, though whether it was from the name that rolled off the woman's lips or the directive she couldn't say. Catra's voice, thick with the effort it took to do so, became clearer as she slowly turned herself around. She couldn't look Adora in the eye as she meekly asked, "You too?"

"Oh. Oh, no that's okay." It had taken a moment for Adora to catch on but, no. That wasn't the point of all this, to barter back and forth with one another. "I'm fine really-..."

"Shut up, Grayson. I want you to. Just," Catra bit her lip, surprised at herself for what came out next. "Be gentle with me, okay?"

The enormity of the ask stood between them.

Catra spanned the gap, trying to undo some of what she had done. "Besides, just one isn't really worth *my* time." She pulled on the woman's collar, spreading her legs wide to entreat her re-entry, Adora all too happy to meet her.

They lay panting, Catra still sprawled over the top of Adora's desk and Adora draped above her. It hadn't taken long, a few thrusting glides and both women came undone within moments of one another. Catra's claws had threatened to dig into Adora's shoulders as the blonde finished working herself through, but it was a reflex she resisted. She had spent enough time digging at the woman above her. There were a million things Catra wanted to say in that moment, the foremost being *I thought about you all weekend too.'* But the longer she lay still, the afterglow slipping away from her, she couldn't persuade her lips to form the words, asphyxiating at the vibrations that wanted to rumble up her vocal chords. Instead she gently shook off the blonde and dressed in silence.

"Hey , come on. You don't have to go, not yet." Adora tried to stop her, but business was business and well, the deal was done.

As Catra reached the door, she mumbled out, "I'll get someone out here this afternoon for that pole stake."

A beat passed. "I have your number , you know. I'm gonna keep trying."

The voice behind Catra was quiet, but resolute. She should find it vaguely unsettling, that unwavering determination to sweep past the flimsy boundaries she erected as if they were no more than warning rumblestrips on the highway. Instead she just smiled as she opened the door to leave, because Catra almost believed that too.

Chapter End Notes

> Okay, I know y'all came for another dose of electrical work and utility pole talk, but I'm afraid all we got this time is smut. And some Feelings that I swear came out of nowhere! 🙈
> Maybe chapter three will just be Catra in her office, rendering 3D models and drawing blueprints. You know. The *good* stuff.
>
> I'm kidding about chapter 3, this story is done. Chapter 2 has a much different vibe than 1, but I like it. I did this piece to try and

reconnect with the words and feel certain parts I really tapped in well... If anything, always fun to have some desk sex/a nice ride.

Until next time, folks!

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

... What's that? In the distance... of f a ways... but creeping ever closer?

It couldn't be...

No...

Plot?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora (10:15pm) *I had a really nice time this morning.*

Adora (10:15pm) *Fck lol. That was lame as hell.*

Adora (10:19pm) *True tho*

Adora (10:41pm) *Maybe since you have tomorrow off too, you could drop by again?*

Adora (11:15pm) *Ill be in by 7..*

Truthfully, she hadn't expected it to be *that* easy. Maybe even a part of her exhilarated in the impending challenge, especially earlier in the day. Now though... Adora allowed herself one disheartened sigh as she turned out her light, but not before first checking to make sure her ringer was turned all the way up. She told herself it was to make sure she heard her alarm since she was going to bed so late, but as she took one last glance at the string of unanswered texts from earlier, just hoping for a read receipt, it was a lot harder to believe her own lies.

Adora (9:42pm) *Cup of coffee here with your name on it.*

Adora (9:43pm) *Or a different kind of wake up if you'd prefer…)*

Adora (9:45pm) *Fuck that was rude. I mean, I know we enjoyed ourselves last Friday and yesterday but I don't want you to think that's all I'm after from you.*

Adora (10:03pm) *At least I enjoyed myself. A lot.*

Adora (11:16pm) *Maybe we could grab a drink sometime?*

"Jesus, boss, would you watch it with that?" Lonnie complained, ducking low to narrowly avoid being smacked in the head with a hastings rod. "Fucking hell, who let you outta the office? You've been off all fucking week and I'm sick of putting up with it. Having to pick up your slack and shit."

Adora's hands wrapped around the instrument tightly, a flash of heat rising in her chest. She gave her crew a lot of leeway;she wanted to

create a space where people felt like real people when they came to work, but Lonnie had quite the pair to be coming at her like that. As she opened her mouth to inform her worker who exactly was in charge around here, Adora quickly realized the woman had a point. Sure a smack upside the head on accident probably wouldn't be cause for a formal incident report, but it was still sloppy. "Just take the damn measurements, make sure the midspan height's not in violation." She shoved the 40 foot measuring device in her worker's arms as she stomped back to her trailer.

Out of habit, she checked her phone as she settled in front of her desk, trying to ignore the ten small divets that had been driven into the once pristine wood. No new messages; it wasn't a surprise in the slightest, but damn if it all hadn't started to wear a bit.

Two weeks to the day since Catra had first let herself into her office, bent out of shape about a midspan pole. Jobs like this one really didn't usually take this long, but the late start at the beginning really had slowed things down. And though her crew was good and beyond competent, Catra had been correct in her identification of the primary size once they'd gotten someone up there to get the existing lines attached to the new pole. Which meant that Adora needed to order all new parts, delaying things even further.

She thought for sure that text would be the one to merit a response; who doesn't like to hear that they were right about something? But nothing, not a damn word, only that mocking note of *Delivered'*. Adora glanced at her other most recent attempts; one made early last week:

Adora (2:38pm) *Found that missing stake while we were planting the new pole lol oops think a lawn mower got it, it was pretty torn up.*

And then just this morning:

Adora (7:35am) *hey*

She told herself after this one, just a simple and stark greeting, that would be it. For a little while, at least, she wasn't kidding when she told Catra that she was going to keep trying. While Adora was one to believe that persistence paid off, she also had her limits. So *many* unanswered messages, job-related email correspondence that received the barest, most clipped of responses (the latest one to inform her that all future questions could be directed to Catra's supervisor), and one poorly-decided upon phone call that was sent immediately to voicemail was enough for Adora to agree with herself that new tactics would need to be implemented. What exactly that would entail she wasn't sure yet, hence the break to regroup and adjust accordingly.

The rest of Adora's work day passed by without incident; she kept herself busy inside her office with invoicing for the rest of the morning, glad when Kyle came to report that the job was finally finished. She helped her team clean up the site and released them for a long weekend, with a promise that by Monday evening they would have their next work location. She had a number of jobs lined up for them throughout the state, but would need the weekend and Monday to narrow down priority and assignment. For tonight, however, she would rest. And think. Definitely think.

Rest took the form of ordering takeout from her favorite bar and fixing herself a large whiskey and ginger. She did a few pitiful runs in Hades (Theseus could kiss her ass; Asterius deserved so much better than him) but not even the desire to reunite Patroclus and Achilles in the Underworld could really draw her attention in for long. The group text chat was blowing up, but Adora really wasn't in the mood for her friend's antics. Perfuma was gushing about something to do with her anniversary with her girlfriend, exactly what was happening she couldn't say for sure, the pair celebrated so many

random anniversaries that it was hard to follow, and Bow was trying to entice people into a game of Among Us. A riveting Friday night.

If Adora had any sense she would just call it for the day, try again with this thing called life in the morning. She really hadnt been to bed before midnight once this week (these past weeks, if she were to be honest with herself) and it was already pushing 11:00. Glancing at her empty glass on the coffee table surrounded by the boxes from her dinner, she waved off cleaning it up until Saturday chores. Adora did take the time to wash her face and brush her teeth before settling under the covers.

She almost didnt even bother to open her eyes to check her phone when the text came through. She just assumed that it was her friends going on about something or other in the group chat, until Adora recalled that she had muted it for the night. Even though it most likely Bow trying once again to convince her to play a game that she was truly terrible at, the fact he had chosen to text her directly at least deserved a '*Going to bed, leave me alone. <3*'

She immediately dropped her phone on her face when she saw who it actually was.

Catra (11:28pm) *hey adora.*

Adora (11:28pm) *OMG hi!!*

Adora cursed herself for the overzealous, not to mention mistyped, greeting. There was no saving this but at least she was astute enough to realize that sending a barrage of corrections and apologies would only make it all the more likely that Catra wouldnt give any follow up messages. She needed to tread lightly, be as cool and collected as her gay panic would allow.

Running her tongue over her now sore lip, Adora watched as the three bubbles appeared, then disappeared, then appeared again before:

Catra (12am) *wyd*

What was she doing? It was after midnight on a day she'd worked a job that required her to be on her feet, usually while doing heavy amounts of physical labor. Okay, fine, maybe today actually turned out to be a desk day with some light clean up at the end, but it was still late as hell for goodness' sake! Before Catra had entered the picture (if one could truly say she was "in" the picture, but Adora was trying, dammit), it was a good night if the blonde was still awake at 10pm. Sleep had been eluding her as of late and the reason for it was finally texting her back.

Adora (12am) *lol, nothing much. You?*

Catra (12am) *same*

Adora (12am) *Cool.*

Adora (12am) *So what's up?*

Adora couldn't believe her own redundancy. As if the captivating wyd conversation hadn't already broached the subject, that 'what's up' just slipped out, barely giving the other woman any time to add to the thread of her own accord.

Catra (2am) *drink 2moro nite at the crimson waste*

Adora (2am) *Is that a qestion or a statement?*

Catra (2am) 👆 *jst shut up n b ther*

Catra (2am) *p*

Adora's text had been an honest to goodness qestion;she really couldnt figure out the woman' s intent. But she supposed there was her answer.

Adora (2am) *K2ay! See you then! C2nt wait!*

Adora (2am) *And good night!)*

A date. Finally. Adora couldnt believe her luck;mere hours after she made the agreement with herself to step back and let the situation have time to breathe, things gained some traction. She was almost too excited to sleep, back to her days in high school jst hoping for a 3am text from some cutie. No more came from this particular beauty, but that really wasnt too surprising. Catra had finally responded *and* proposed meeting up!Things really couldnt get any better . Adora fell asleep with a huge grin on her face.

The following night couldnt arrive fast enough. Adora did her best to keep herself occupied through the day;Saturday mornings were for mundane things like cleaning and groceries and the afternoons she usually spent on the bench with a multitude of reps and curls. It was harder to focus on those tasks when she was staring down the clock, willing it to move faster, but after making dinner and zning out to some mindless TV, it was finally time to get ready. She dressed

herself in a simple white button down, forgoing the tie but making sure her chinos were freshly pressed. Cognac wingtips completed the outfit and she spent an embarrassing amount of time making sure her hair fell just right, looking suitably effortless and carefree despite all her attention to it. Adora wasn't familiar with The Crimson Waste, but with a name like that it wasn't really difficult to pinpoint on Google. It ended up being a bit of a hike away so she was glad that in her excitement that she had gotten dressed rather early. She would have plenty of time to get there, get a table, and wait for Catra to arrive.

Adora gave a cursory nod to the person checking IDs at the door, flashing her own but getting an immediate wave to go inside. Graffiti, random scrawling, and stickers from various bands lined the walls of the hallway that led her to the dimly lit bar area. Even though smoking had been banned in bars for ages, there just seemed to be a permanent stench of tar and nicotine in the air, so many cigarettes smoked in the past that it had seeped into the walls themselves. The floors were dingy, scuffed to hell by the heavy tread of barflys, and one tile was stained with something Adora really couldn't readily recognize but very well could have been blood. An unfriendly visage looked her over from behind the bar before going back to wiping a glass with a towel that maybe had been laundered once in the past year.

This was not what she had been anticipating. Maybe she should have read a review or two, looked at a single picture, because she stuck out like no other. She couldn't believe this is where Catra chose to spend her free time, let alone where she would invite Adora out to. Adora didn't like to think of herself as prissy, but she was glad she was up to date in her vaccinations, because one sip from a glass here was bound to carry a whole host of terrifying organisms.

"Hey, Adora." That raspy voice she had been craving for weeks cut through the din of the dive.

Intrinsically, Adora turned towards the source, the tips of ears burning. So much for her plan of scoring a table early;Catra was

already seated at the bar, beer bottle in hand (at least she had the sense to drink from something that had come sealed), looking roguishly beautiful in her dark, ripped leggings and tight maroon leather jacket. The sight made Adora a little weak at the knees, but she compensated for it by settling herself into a stool next to where Catra was perched. "Hey , yourself!"

The brunette rolled her eyes at the squeaky greeting, taking a long chug of her beer. It was hard to say whether it was the general vibe of the bar or just the weirdness of being in each other's presence again, but the few moments of silence that spanned their greeting seemed to stretch into perpetuem. Catra allowed herself one glance of Adora's neat form before speaking. "Wow, you are way too dressed up for this place." She scoffed into her bottle, arching a brow with a quirk of her lips. "You think this was a date or something?"

As if things didn't feel fucking awkward enough, that certainly settled it. It crossed her mind to lie, to try to save face in this situation where she felt like the butt of a very mean joke, but even the most smooth talker in the world would have trouble explaining why she was dressed smart at 10 o'clock on a Saturday night, knowing she was on her way to meet a person she'd hooked up with a couple times. It took much of her strength to do it, but Adora swallowed her pride, giving a small shrug to soften the blow to her ego. "I mean, kind of?"

Catra looked away from Adora's direction, taking the opportunity to glare at a nebby patron a few stools down who had been watching their exchange. Sure the blonde was just embarrassing herself, but that was Catra's delight to revel in, no one else's. After another moment's pause, Catra set her almost drained bottle down on the counter before lounging with her head held in her arm. Despite her relaxed pose, her words were precise and cutting. "Jayson, I was texting you after midnight on a Friday. I used 'wyd'. I invited you to the *Crimson Waste* for fuck's sake! What part of that doesn't scream 'booty-call' to you?"

"How about the part where you invited me out for a drink, instead of just to come over?" The blonde was sure she had her here. Netflix and Chill, Hulu and hang, Amazon Prime and Bedtime... They all had a theme and it did not involve getting a drink together beforehand.

"Idiot. Like I'd ever let you know where I live." The brunette scowled at the increasingly cutesy ways to say "Get over here and fuck me" which in retrospect is exactly what she should have said to prevent this embarrassment. Not that she was particularly bothered herself, but if all this went to the dummy's head and prevented her from being screwed properly. She drained the last of her beer in one long gulp. Though it might be sealing her fate, Catra still couldn't help but ask, "And what the fuck kind of date starts at 10pm?"

Adora sat with herself a moment, frowning slightly at the other woman. Yeah, she had to admit the signs were there. She mumbled out, "Lemme buy you a drink then, at least." Maybe it wasn't a date-date, but she could at least be courteous.

"Had one already . Not why I'm here."

"I know why you're here and you're gonna get what you want. But not before I do first." The blonde nodded her head towards the bartender, grabbing his attention. The steel glint to her eyes must have warned the staff member to not try and fuck with her by pretending he hadn't seen. He begrudgingly shuffled over to take their drink order. Adora stared straight ahead. "You'll have a drink with me." It wasn't a question. "Then I'll take you home."

Catra had choices, just as everyone did in life. She could cut her loses, tell Adora to shove it. Maybe find some other willing participant for her evening. But with that resolute tone and that promise. What other choice did she *truly* have?

Adora held true to her word. After one drink shared between the two, she gave a lazy smile. "You ready to get out of here?" She saw the woman's tail flick once behind her, two-toned eyes looking down at

the bottle she'd been sipping from for nearly the past hour and a half as if she were the first to be surprised to see that it was empty.

Catra got a hold of herself and nodded. "Finally , god. I just finished the stupid beer you made me get, so we can get on with this night already."

Adora placed a few bills on the counter to cover the damages. She considered pointing out that the other woman's bottle had been drained some time ago, but figured it was best to not push her luck too much. "Sure thing. Where to?"

She led the blonde around to the side of the bar, more pulling than guiding. Adora wasn't super familiar with the area, but figured the parking lot Catra must be in was down this way. It seemed like the woman had been warming up to her inside, so it was possible she wanted to get even closer in the relative privacy of her car. Suited Adora just fine;she could be aptly nimble when the situation called for it.

"Hope you were at least smart enough to come packing." Catra muttered, taking an abrupt turn between two buildings before stopping.

"I already told you, I'm almost always packing." Adora answered as she looked around at their surroundings. The pair stared at one another for a moment, before Adora was shaking her head in disbelief. "Seriously? Here?"

The brunette shrugged. "I told you I wasn't gonna let you know where I lived."

"So a dim alley is your top choice? Jesus Christ, woman. *I* have a bed! And I don't care if you know where I live." *Actually, if it kept us out of places like this and the Waste, I'd prefer it.* She continued to look around a little unhappily, consoled at least that there didn't seem to be trash cans or dumpsters nearby. That would have been

just too much for her. If she had to hazard a guess, she'd say that they looked to be by the back exit of an old theater.

"Didn't hear you offering that the last two times we got together." Catra would be lying if she said Adora's priggish discomfort over this whole scenario wasn't greatly amusing to her. The woman had lifted her onto her shoulders within minutes of them meeting face to face for the first time, but a late night tryst behind a building was suddenly too much for her? That wasn't her motivation for leading them back to this spot, but it was a nice bonus.

The blonde snorted. "That was different and you know it. I'm all for fucking you, but once again, how about we go back to mine?"

It was tempting, Catra had to admit. But her need for this to be as far away from how things had been the last time they'd gotten together was much more pressing. Wanting the other woman to finish, no less while *in* her, had been way too real, the ache it had left behind in these weeks too sharp. And then tonight, where despite her most barbed comments and clipped replies she still somehow found herself legitimately *laughing* over whatever dumb topic Adora had chosen to ramble about? She'd been out way longer than she anticipated and that was before they even had sex! Really, Catra had been driven to this point. It couldn't be nice. It wouldn't be sweet. She needed something quick and dirty and for the blonde to just go with it for however long it took. Catra leaned against a nearby wall, crossing her arms over her chest. "Wow. You too good for this, Grayson?"

"It's not a question of being too 'good' for this, I just…"

"Sorry this doesn't fit *your* idea of romance," Catra squashed down the tiny flutter of nerves at the word, gagging to cover herself for being stupid enough to let that slip through, "No desk to bend me over, I know, but it's what I'm offering for the night. Take it or leave it. I'm sure there's plenty of people willing to eat me out back at the bar... wherever I damn well say."

"You'd really let just anyone do that to you, huh?"

It wasn't true, not by a long shot. Catra kept to herself for the most part, but she couldn't let Adora think she was special or anything. She scoffed loudly as she answered. "Think I already proved that, didn't I? Considering I let some brainless meathead take me behind a shack. And she wasn't fucking whiny about it like you're being over this whole thing."

Adora growled- actually audibly *growled* , at the insult. Catra thought that she was being whiny; that it was unreasonable for her to suggest that they fuck in a bed or a car? It was beyond frustrating, all the more so that despite her growing vexation... All Adora wanted to do was feel Catra break around her once more. She'd spent these past weeks dreaming about kissing her lips again, feeling Catra's soft fur below her fingers as her hands traced her body, teasing, riling, and bringing out the most absolutely filthy noises from the woman as she was soundly fucked by her. And Adora knew that Catra wanted the exact same thing, but her stubborn pride loved to make things difficult. That much was so apparent even in the short time they'd spent together .

So if this is what it took to satisfy their mutual want, Adora would play ball. She would step up and show Catra what's what. Before she could take the time to really formulate her reply, Adora found herself already speaking, completely off the cuff. "You know what? Fine. Fine, well do it here, just like you want. If you wanna be no better than some back alley slut, then who am I to..." The blonde clamped her mouth shut tight, eyes going wide as she realized what she had said.

The feline woman stilled, regarding Adora sharply. With dangerous grace, she was suddenly squared up in front of the blonde, eyes narrowed into slits. Adora braced herself, knowing that a punch was coming- and completely deserved. Instead Catra continued to search her face, a flurry of reactions Adora couldn't readily recognize glinting in the back of her eye. When she finally spoke, Catra's tone

was low and gravely, with a definite challenging lilt. "Say that to me again."

"Catra, I'm sorry, I-" Adora scrambled to apologize, not believing such a derogatory word would leave her lips, especially towards the person she'd been so sprung over lately. Not that it would be any better if she wasn't crushing on Catra, that kind of language was just uncalled for. How did this happen? This was so far from how she wanted the night to go.

"Say it again *..."* Catra leaned forward, making the blonde want to do nothing else but step back. Adora stayed rooted though, ready to accept whatever retaliation the other woman had in store for her. Catra began by raising a hand, fisting it into the front of Adora's shirt. She held that tight grip as she spat out between clenched teeth, "Say it and I'll come *real* hard*."*

Adora was paralyzed at hearing her own words from weeks prior thrown back at her, particularly when they were delivered with a bite that only Catra could provide. As she stared, mute, the feline woman released the material of her shirt from her hand. She traced a single claw tip down Adora's chest, with one flick neatly paring off a button as she went. Adora swallowed thickly, trying to catch up to this turn of events. It was a slow realization, but potent; things were back on track, back to where it always led between them.

Catra did not give her an opportunity to ask questions. Her hands moved from the front of Adora's shirt to the small of her back, loosely roping around her torso. The woman leaned in close, tilting her head up so she could breath into the blonde's ear. "Mmmm, good job, Grayson. Looks like you uncovered one of *my* kinks." She bit down lightly on the shell of Adora's ear, moaning softly as Adora's hands slotted over her hips in reply. "I'll be your slut tonight. Do whatever you want."

"Catra." Adora groaned with a gasp as the woman's mouth worked its ways down her jawline, pricks of her sharp fangs mixed with fluttering laps of her tongue making it damn near impossible to

concentrate. She'd sampled a variety of likes over the years, but degradation through names? Before this moment Adora would have chalked that one up as 'only in pornos'. But at how obviously turned on the other woman was, how she was now frantically pressing hard kisses down her neck, claws digging into her back just hard enough to make her presence *very* well known... Adora closed her eyes as the woman's hands and mouth roved over her so incessantly, before pulling herself away. She stepped back, panting to regain her composure.

"Don't ruin this for me." The brunette pleaded, trying to hold on to the retreating body in front of her. Too much, she knew it would be too much, but plowed ahead anyway. She'd only ever admitted this particular like once before and was met with uneasy participation from that partner (coincidence that the arrangement had fizzled out shortly after, the woman ghosting her? Hard to say). Catra had thought with Adora's casual confession of enjoying being *choked* and *restrained* that the blonde wouldn't even blink at the request for power play and pejorative talk. Maybe that was part of it, Catra really hadn't played ball with anything Adora had suggested, never paid any mind when the blonde said loud and clear, "This is what I like." She didn't seem like the vindictive type, but who knew. "I know that we didn't do your stuff before but I want"…

"Of course you want." Adora's large hand grabbed Catra's chin, pulling it up so they were eye to eye. They stayed like that for several breaths, Catra's heart beginning to beat faster as those icy blue eyes regarded her. Just when she didn't think she would be able to take it anymore, Adora spoke again, entirely calm. "You're so desperate for me, aren't you? Just a needy little sl"…

With an almost unconscionable fervor, Catra surged forward even before Adora could finish her sentence, not wanting to give the blonde any opportunity to change her mind. She moaned readily into the open mouth around her, as hands cupped her waist, bringing her in tighter.

They indulged themselves for a while, Adora steadily taking charge with her lips, teeth, and tongue. She once again just barely stepped back, a soft whine falling from the brunette's mouth as any amount of space entered between them. The blonde quietly dragged a thumb down Catra's kiss bitten lips, watching with a crooked smile as her eyes shuddered close. The very tip of Catra's tongue ran across as it rested there. Adora suppressed a groan of delight, inspired by the motion. Her voice was thick as she instructed, "On your knees."

An embarrassing whine escaped her lips at the command. Catra could feel her flush everywhere, coiling low in her abdomen, every kiss and pull of the blonde's hands on her just making her wild. With no delay, she lowered herself down, pressing a few hasty kisses to the woman's stomach as she moved. The ground was cold as she kissed her knees to the pavement, making her shiver.

Adora caught the reaction, immediately moving to take off her button up;to hell if it was white. She had a million more just like it hanging in her closet. "Here, your knees, just". It wouldnt be much in the way of padding, but it had to be better than the concrete.

Before she could remove it fully, a hand shot up, grasping tight in hers. Catra's head was trained to the ground as she spoke. "No. I like it."

The blonde shrugged her shirt back on slowly, regarding the woman positioned below her. If that was truly her choice. "All right. I think you know that I want that pretty little mouth of yours on me. Head up when Im speaking to you." Catra obeyed, lifting her chin up. Her eyes immediately locked to the bulge in Adora's pants, drooling at what lay underneath the toy and at the prospect of finally getting to taste this woman. She nodded, letting go of the hand that had been laced in the blonde's to unbuckle the woman's belt. Adora sighed at the cogent action, breathing out a "Good girl" as she felt her zipper slide down.

The night air was a little chilly on Adora's bare legs as they dropped down around her ankles. She was glad that she had opted for the

boxer briefs with the sewn in O-ring rather than the traditional harness;the material clung to her thighs and warded of f the worst of the chill. The strap was tucked, but Adora made no move to reposition it, wanting to feel Catra take it out for her before sucking her off. She was anything but cold once she felt Catra's hands ghost across her thighs, the flickers of heat rising up deep in her abdomen. Fingers reached up towards her hips, trailing along the waistband of her underwear. Adora felt her breath catch in her throat. It was amazing to have the woman' s hands on her, exploring, even if she was anxious for Catra to stop the teasing and get to it already. She was just about to issue that direction when she felt fingers hook under the waistband of her boxers and begin to tug down. Adora panicked a little, not expecting Catra to try to remove her underwear. The other woman must not be familiar with this kind of harness. "Hey? Uh, that' s not really necessary this time. See..."Adora had wanted to demonstrate how easy this particular harness type was to work with, no annoying straps to wiggle through, just pull them on and you're good to go. She took a step back to allow Catra to see better, but nearly tripped over her own pants in the process. So much for being sexy and in charge.

Catra huffed in confusion, more than a little sick of seeing Adora step away from her every time they started to get somewhere good tonight. She couldn't even bring herself to laugh at the idiot' s inherent clumsiness. This hookup was really turning into a fuckton of time and effort. Here she was ready to do something *nice* for the woman even before Catra got any herself. Yeah, it was a little annoying to do the switch and have to shuffle out of the harness to get there, but that was just one of the few downsides of lesbianism. Catra would definitely make it all worth it in the end. "Not necessary? Jesus, Grayson. Hard to get my 'pretty little mouth' on that pussy if you're still wearing..."She trailed of f as she saw Adora shaking her head with wide eyes, embarrassment and dread landing sqarely in her stomach at the reaction her words had garnered.

"Ah, heh. I, uh, don't really let anyone do that."Adora scratched at the back of her head with supreme awkwardness. She witnessed

Catra hug herself a little, shifting on the ground to put some life back into her knees. Adora rushed to try to repair any damage that might have been inflicted from this unforeseen pause in activity. "It' s a me' thing, not a you or anyone else thing, I swear! It' s just, um, a lot for me." She winced as Catra started to rise, unwilling or unable to meet the blonde's eye. Adora gave a fortifying inhale and pressed on with her explanation, hoping to salvage this night. "I'm incredibly sensitive so even what I can feel through a strap is usually way more than enough for me. Weird that I'd even want anything there on a regular basis then, right?" She tried to shrug of f her discomfort, not really thinking this disastrous meet-up was the time to discuss the intricacies of gender expression, especially when she herself hadn't spent much time on the issue privately. Catra really didn't need her to get into all of that. "It just feels better . I dunno."

Catra nodded absently, her gaze intently focused on the ground. Her brows were furrowed together, and much to Adora's distress, she looked more than a little pissed off.

Adora grimaced at the expression, scratching at her arm, very aware of the fact her pants were still down around her ankles. She should probably change that in light of everything. "... Did I ruin the mood?"

"Pretty sure if you have to ask, you already know the answer ." The woman murmured, tail firmly wrapped around her own waist, arms drawn across her chest.

Adora groaned, wanting to smack her head repeatedly into any of the walls that surrounded them. Instead she hastily pulled up her pants, berating herself and the situation she found herself in. "Just great. Assume a casual meet up for sex is a date? Check. Insult said not-date with a pejorative term, but actually discover that she' s turned on by it? Done. When things start to get friendly from said discovery, freak her out with one of your own dumb hangups? A big, fat awful checkmark on that one too.

Catra seemed to argue with herself a moment before biting her lip and finally making eye contact with the blonde. She frowned slightly,

then muttered. "But you didn't ruin it, dummy. I made an assumption which, considering the last two times we banged, was actually kind of stupid of me."

"What? No, Cat, you aren't stupid-..."

"You've said multiple times that you're always packing. You about creamed into my hand the minute I jerked the strap through your jeans, and managed to come just by fucking me with it. It really shouldn't be that much of a surprise that you like to be sucked off too." The brunette finished with a shrug. Adora gaped, at a loss for a fitting reply. Fortunately she didn't need to give one as Catra continued speaking. "You're super into your strap, Grayson. It's fine. I haven't done that before but honestly? At least your shit's tame. Lots of sick fucks out there into weird ass stuff."

"Uhhhh, thanks?" The blonde blinked, again awkwardly running a hand along the back of her head.

"And I guess since you did my thing, I'm down to do yours. I did tell you I'd do whatever you wanted tonight." The corner of Catra's mouth ticked up, before she motioned back towards the way they came with a flick of her head. "But the ground is fucking cold and my knees are already killing me, so c'mon."

"Come on...where?" Adora was at a loss as to what was happening now, staring at Catra with wide eyes, just trying to buy a vowel. She had a hunch, but honestly things had been so all over the place here in the alley, Adora just wanted to be absolutely certain there were no further misunderstandings.

"Ughhh, can't believe I have to spell it out for you. Is it still road head if no one's driving?" The brunette pressed two fingers into the bridge of her nose, eyes scrunched tight. "Why the fuck am I even worried about that right now? Jesus Christ. Just fucking follow me to my car, moron."

"You need to *relax.*" Catra moved so she was straddled across Adora's lap. The blonde had been downright fidgety ever since they found themselves in the backseat of Adora's truck, which ended up being parked closer to them than Catra's car. Adora had fussed outside the vehicle, hesitating as she tried to decide if they should get into the front seat or the back, weighing the merits of each, and internally debating what would be most comfortable all around for them both. Catra put up with the delay for about twenty seconds, tapping her foot against the ground as she waited, before throwing open the door to the rear part of the cab with a heavy, aggrieved sigh. She growled to Adora that she was getting drier by the second and called for the idiot to just get her ass into the truck already.

What the hell happened to the stud who had so casually inquired whether they were "doing this" and so expertly railed her from behind in her office chair? It was a damn good thing Catra knew Adora was a good fuck, because there was no way she'd be putting up with this shit otherwise. She jabbed an accusing finger in the middle of the blonde's chest, eyes narrowed in suspicion. "What the fuck has you so nervous? I swear, if this actually is the first time you're getting head like this..."

"No! No, definitely not. Just, I dunno. Don't want you to feel like you *have* to do this for me." Adora answered meekly, heart rate speeding up ever so slightly. Though for the life of her, she couldn't tell if it was because she had a beautiful, sexy woman in her lap or if it was from the last remnants of their conversation in the alleyway.

"Jesus, Catra. Shut the fuck up. Just, here-..." Catra lifted one of Adora's large hands and placed it against her tit, encouraging the woman's fingers to move against her.

Adora immediately cracked a smile at the feel of Catra under her hand, especially when she was rewarded with a few breathy pants of appreciation for her work. It was probably silly, but she felt grounded by the action, having something tangible (and hot, don't forget very

hot) to focus on. She was still feeling a little embarrassed over everything, a bit guilty about the fact she wouldn't just let herself get eaten out. What kind of lesbian...

"Better?" Catra interrupted her thoughts, the blonde shifting her concentration back to the matter under hand and nodding vigorously at the question. "God, because this has been one weird night and I'm ready to finally get what the hell I came here for."

Adora gave a little chuckle of agreement, shoving aside her awkwardness for the time being, and pinching at the woman's nipple over her shirt. Catra squeaked at the sudden change in pressure, the sound quickly turning into an irritated huff. Adora couldn't help but grin at the noise. "Me? Yeah, I know that's what you've wanted all night."

"Not *you*." The magicat's tail wrapped around Adora's wrist, as she positioned herself over the blonde's thigh. *Guess fucking brings out the ego,* Catra thought bitterly, entirely unimpressed by the woman's lack of creativity in her motivations. Of course, it certainly beat the Adora that was paralyzed with anxiety and put way too much thought into every little damn detail. She'd just need to put the smug side of this woman in her place. "You're a convenience, nothing more. In fact, with the absolute pain in my ass you've been tonight, you're not even that." Catra rolled her hips down hard, the firmness of Adora's thigh pressing into her exquisitely, instantly reigniting her desire. She suppressed the urge to moan as she rocked herself down again. "You better give it to me good to make up for all the shit that's happened."

"Oh, gladly." Adora promised, raising her leg and spreading her fingers wide to encircle Catra's hips. "I know things got kinda weird-..."

"Nope! No talking." Catra slapped a hand over the blonde's mouth, surprised by, and yet not at all, the deep moan the action pulled out of the woman. She rolled her eyes; seriously was the name thing the only kink Adora didn't have? "I mean it, Grayson. You're not

permitted to speak unless it's directly related to the sex we're supposed to be having, and even then, *as sparingly as possible* . Im really not interested in any more conversation, got it?" Catra glared down at the owner of the leg she was riding, glad when she received a silent nod of agreement. As an afterthought she added, "Dont forget what we discussed about my likes in the alley. But you better be smart enough to know when the right time to use it is." Catra could feel Adora's smirk against her palm.

Satisfied that the blonde understood the conditions of their arrangement, Catra dropped her hand from where it had been covering Adora's mouth in favor of gripping her shoulders to give herself better purchase as she grinded down on her thigh. She wasnt looking to get of f this way, just wanted a little entertainment for herself before following through on her part of the deal. Catra closed her eyes and let the lower half of herself move, breathing heavy when the right pace was reached. Her hands continued to grasp onto the corded muscles of the blonde's shoulders, claws digging in a little as Adora gave a particularly fantastic thrust upwards of her thigh. The moan that ripped through her mouth was downright filthy, but it just felt so fucking good. Even with her own still clamped tightly shut, Catra could feel the other woman's eyes on her, watching her face with reckless wonder, but she really had no time for any of that nonsense.

She continued to ride against the firm leg, working herself up quite thoroughly. Adora's quickened breath matched the huf f of her own as they moved in tandem. While she still had the ability to do so, she abruptly stopped her roll, inhaling sharply at the loss of pressure as she moved from Adora's lap. The blonde tried to keep her in place, grasping on to her hips and pulling her back into position, but Catra swatted at her hands, twisting away. Adora released her at that point, trying to mask her hurt and confusion. She wanted to ask why the brunette had stopped grinding on her, but while it was related to sex, she had a strong feeling that would violate their no talking agreement. Before she could come up with a sultry way of checking in with the other woman, she felt hands near the fly of her pants. "

Oh… ”Adora breathed out, lips parting, and eyes widening at the sound of her zipper being lowered.

“What, did you think I forgot?” Catra snarked, nimble fingers deftly freeing the toy from the confines of the fabric harness. She noted that this strap was considerably larger than the one from weeks ago; a stirring prospect once it was buried in her cunt, but Adora had better let go of any fantasies of being deepthroated on this thing.

“Umm, no? Maybe? I mean, it would be fine if you haa *aa* ”Adora was stopped short by a hand once again covering her mouth, tips of Catra’s claws lightly pressing into her cheeks as she blocked the sound of the blonde’s voice from finishing her tumbling thought. The magicat gave her one hard stare, baring a single fang in a warning that clearly said Adora would not get another chance if she did not strictly adhere to the terms of their engagement.

Relatively assured that the idiot understood that she really meant *no talking* , Catra impassively regarded the length before her. She was super fucking gay, so obviously it was more than a little stirring to see a strap protruding from a handsome woman’s lap. It felt a little odd to be lowering her face down instead of her pussy, but she couldn't deny that the whimpers that came from the blonde were making her feel powerful as fuck. A bit surprising for what could be considered a subservient position, but it was Catra who would dictate exactly how much and for how long Adora would get to enjoy her. Fortified by just how much control she had in this situation, Catra placed her lips around the strap, her tongue tentatively dipping out to lick at the tip. It had no taste, not that she had really been expecting one. She mostly just felt the pressure of the item as she worked a little more of it into her mouth. It was neither good nor bad, which she could live with for now.

There was no question how Adora felt about the whole thing, gasping from the moment Catra’s mouth even approached the strap. It was flattering in a way; the magicat really doubted the woman could feel much of anything, the flicks of her tongue were far too delicate at this point, her mouth still as she adjusted to the new

activity. But no one would be able to tell from the enthusiastic groans her ginger ministrations were receiving. Catra chalked it up to a mental thing more than a physical one;the psychological side of sex really couldnt be discounted.

Of course, if Adora was enjoying this so much, what would the response be if Catra…

"Oh god, Catra!" Adora sighed out, watching the woman pick up some speed against her. She tentatively raised her hand, hesitating only for a second, before threading it through Catra's hair. She didnt dare attempt to guide Catra's head, the fiery magicat wouldnt likely take too kindly to that, but gently combed her fingers through it, mindful to not tug on the silky curls by accident. She watched, utterly captivated by the sheer eroticism of the scene. "You look so beautiful like this"…

The answering hum of approval at the words was quickly lost as Catra wrapped her hand around the base of the toy, tongue still licking in circles towards the tip. She heard Adora inhale sharply at the new pressure closest to her, a shuddering sigh was her exhale. If the blonde thought that was good... She slowly stroked her hand down as she sucked, making damn certain the action would be felt. Adora's hips stuttered upwards, fingers curling into Catra's hair as a reflex to the jolt of pleasure. The magicat internally crowed in delight at the thrust into her mouth and repeated her exaggerated strokes. She was a little surprised at the desire that was being kicked up in her as she performed the actions, emboldened enough by it all to take even more into her mouth.

Catra wasnt the only one feeling bolstered by her display. From the whine she knew Catra released when her hips had jerked up, Adora very carefully rolled into the other woman's mouth, back to running her fingers through her hair. She spoke quietly, low and spiced. "Such a good girl for me, sucking me off like that." She ran a hand down Catra's cheek as she watched the mouth continue to work around the length, the pulses from the base of the strap hitting her just right. The time also certainly felt right. "A slut hungry for my

cock"… *Oh*. That combination definitely did something for Catra. A new flood of heat rose in her core and in turn she found her hand moving even faster to pump against Adora, driving the base into the woman's clit. Pleasure was definitely building in Adora, and quickly, after being treated to such amazing display and response. Catra could so easily make her come like this, but more important was the desire for Adora to pull the brunette over the edge.

Her tone was ragged; it was so hard to speak when she was being worked so enthusiastically. "Cat. I need you." Thick fingers again curled into her hair, just shy of pulling. The brunette paid little mind, a small moan forming at the back of her throat as she continued to bob against the strap, the press of it in her mouth along with the scent of Adora's desire and deep moans more than enough to keep her enthralled. When Catra didn't seem to be *getting* it, Adora tugged more insistently, cupping a hand under the woman's chin to halt her ministrations. "No, I need to *feel* you."

Catra whined a little at being made to stop, not that she would ever admit to that, but it was quickly cut off when the blonde pulled her back into her lap. Adora pressed a line of hard kisses down her throat, sucking at her pulse point as Catra's claws dug into the back of her head, encouraging her along. Adora couldn't wait any longer, not even to let the woman she was intent on fucking shed any clothing. Her hand shot down the front of Catra's leggings, cupping the wet heat that resided there. The magicat gasped as her large fingers ghosted along the silky texture of her thong, breath coming in short pants as she tried to angle herself down on Adora's hand and relieve the pressure in her core. Every time she gained purchase, Adora would pull her hand away just enough, the brunette crying out in her frustration.

Adora continued to trace small circles with her middle finger against the soaked fabric, but made no move to alleviate Catra in any other way. She teased up and down the length of her pussy, eyes bright as she watched the near agonized expression on the magicat's face grow even more pronounced. Sure she wanted, and wanted badly,

but Adora wanted to see this woman absolutely wrecked for her more. "So desperate for me. You want me to fuck you, rub that needy clit until you come all over my hand?" A growl and aggressive thrust of her hips down was Catra's only reply. The blonde clucked her tongue, the hand not currently shoved down the magicat's leggings wrapping around her waist, easily holding the woman in place and preventing her from gaining any friction. "Hmmm. That's not very nice, growling at me like that. But your mouth felt so good, so I guess you deserve this..."

One dexterous twist of her fingers and Adora was moving along the folds of Catra's slickness, watching intently to hone in on what positions garnered the best responses. She settled into one finger flicking sideways against her clit, interspersed with hard, circular presses that had Catra rocking herself down without abandon, her broken cries filling the car. Adora's fingers traveled down towards her entrance, swirling to coat them before slipping one in with a gentle push. Catra *keened* at the sensation, arms wrapping around Adora's head and neck with a choked cry of "More."

Adora plunged in further at the command, her thumb raising to pad against her clit as she continued to pump into Catra's tight, silken heat. "You feel so fucking good, Catra." But the magicat only shook her head, repeating her cry for more. Another finger joined in Adora's motions, thumb still rubbing as she tried to crook just right in response to the breathy cries of the woman riding her hand. She considered for a moment pausing to pull Catra's leggings down to fuck her with the strap instead, Adora always felt a little more confident in her ability with that compared to her fingers, but almost as if the woman could read her mind, Catra cried out, "*Dont stop!*"

Any thought of doing so quickly disappeared with that insistent command. Instead Adora felt all the more driven to bring Catra to close, to feel the woman break at the touch of her fingers, experience the tightness of her walls clenching as pleasure overtook her. Each thrust was delivered with the purpose of making her feel as utterly good as possible, each swipe of her thumb issued only

with the thought of Catra's enjoyment in mind. Adora's forearm burned with the cramped position but she reveled in the feeling, knowing it came from her efforts of making Catra an absolutely fucked out mess above her. It was at that moment Adora realized she was enunciating her thoughts out loud, a train of filthy nothings spilling forth to let Catra know without question that she was doing this for her and her alone. That single-minded attention combined with Adora's fingers crooking just right was all Catra needed to let go, a silent rush overwhelming her body to the point that the word, the *name* , she wanted to scream as she came couldn't find its way out. As those large, beautifully callous fingers gently worked through the final pulses of her release, Catra knew in that moment... She was good and truly fucked.

After they had finished, Adora slid her hands out from Catra's leggings, absently wiping them on her own pants. She was surprised when Catra's legs didn't immediately untangle themselves from around her waist. Instead the woman clung for a moment longer, head bent into the crook of the blonde's shoulders as she breathed heavily. Adora's expression was soft as she traced her fingertips along her lightly furred back, letting the other woman take all the time she needed to come down from her high. When Catra's breathing had evened and her body was slack, quietly Adora asked, "Are you all done for tonight?"

Catra took a moment to respond, cursing her weakness for the warm, sturdy press of Adora's chest against her own. Drawing her eyes tight and biting her lip, she nodded weakly. She was spent, already dreading that she had a twenty-some minute drive home. Catra twisted so her face pointed away from Adora's neck, but still rested her head against the blonde's shoulder. "Yeah, I'm done. But you? I don't think you'…"

"Nah, I'm fine. No, really!" Adora was quick to assure the magicat after her head had lifted with some effort to regard her with a raised eyebrow. "What you did for me was more than enough. I, uh, don't often need to get there myself, so long as my partner does." It wasn't

a lie or any amount of selflessness on Adora’s part. She was just wired that way.

Catra continued to stare at her, shivering slightly at the word ‘partner’. She decided to give the woman a pass for that faux pas and not argue any further. If Adora wanted to leave here worked up and miserable, that was her own business. Now that she was no longer mind-numbingly turned on, Catra could admit her jaw ached and she really just wanted to crawl into bed for a few hours.

Adora insisted on walking her back to her car, the pair still adhering to the no talking outside of sex rule that had been established. Fortunately it was a short trip, shorter than they had realized in the heat of things earlier, and before long they were both standing awkwardly outside Catra’s vehicle. It was hard to know exactly what to do in this situation;they really had never given one another a proper goodbye. Adora felt some comfort that Catra wasnt immediately rushing off, peeling out of the lot in her haste to flee, but nothing she could think to say or do really felt appropriate for their circumstances. Maybe if it had been a date, she would have lost herself in two-toned eyes for a few breathless moments, while holding the woman’s small, soft hand and wishing that it wasnt time to part ways, not yet, dont go. Maybe she would have leaned in close, tilted the other woman’s chin up, and brushed her lips against Catra’s own with a promise to text as soon as she got home and as soon as she woke up and all throughout the day until they could see one another again. Maybe...

But it wasnt.

Instead Adora elected to give a small, friendly wave that would serve in place of the goodbye she might have given. She left the magicat after, determined to not turn her head back to peek, lest she be tempted by the maybes.

If she had looked, maybe she would have seen Catra still standing by her driver’s side door, eyebrows furrowed into a sharp crease, watching as she wordlessly departed from the scene. Maybe if she

watched a little longer, she might have seen Catra slump against the car for a moment, holding her head in her hands. Maybe she would have seen Catra take a few steps towards the direction Adora had left in before angrily turning on her heel to get in her car to leave, but that was a lot to hang on a maybe.

Four nights later, after sustained radio silence between the two, Adora sent one more text.

Adora (7:04pm) *wyd*

Chapter End Notes

Well, sure, if sex is plot, then yeah, plot's on its way!

You goobers asked for a full fic and while I make no promises on the longevity or quality ... I do aim to please, as always. Ahem.

This probably should have been split into two chapters as I almost doubled my entire word count with this but I wanted to give y'all the good (and some nice, "Ouch" to boot).

In theory will be taking a break from the smut for a bit to recharge and refocus so I can finish up The Sleepover, my first fic. (I say in theory because well... I'm me.) You'll probably also catch me updating Her, my music-based spring break shenanigans fic, as I lean into the softer, more humor based side of writing. Wildcat fans, I haven't forgotten, just need to figure a few things out for that poor dear.

Things might slow a bit in the coming months as I'll also be working on my fic for the Big Bang, in which I'll be collabing on the writing with Itcanprobablysmellfear. If you like beer with a

heap of yearning, you'll be happy little gays come May!If you like board games with a mess of pining, you'll be happy little gays come May!Actually , with all the talented people participating in the Big Bang WE'RE ALL GOING TO BE HAPPY LITTLE GAYS COME MAY AAAAY!

Until next time, folks!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When they had met up again, less than an hour after Adora sent that text, they didn't even make it into the bar . Just jumped into another round in the back of Adora's truck. It was quick, it was perfunctory , it was everything Catra had wanted it to be over the weekend. She got her rocks off and didn't have to sludge through any conversation beforehand. And except for that stupid little wave goodbye that Adora gave again (her head to tilted to one side, shoulder scrunched up and wiggling her wide spread fingers) as they parted ways for the night, it was perfect.

Just.perfect.

How could things not be? She had the start of a very good, no-strings-attached thing going, at least if she tried hard enough. Catra would manage. She always did.

At least she felt sated on that front for the time being, and the remainder of her week had the decency to flash by. Maybe the next Monday was a little blue, Tuesday grey and Wednesday too. But she shrugged it off and soldiered on. Life was a constant disappointment, so why would her mental health be any different? These things happened from time to time; Scorpia's professional Astrology guy girlfriend would probably tell her Mercury was in retrograde or some shit like that. That it was the perfect time for some powerful self-reflection and to sit with herself to determine what her emotions were really trying to communicate to her.

Fuck no.

By Thursday morning though, Catra didn't even want to start. She laid in bed far later than her normal, only drawn out by the fact she

had her fucking bi-weekly Zoom call with all the designers on her project. It was a chance for Netossa to use her best Disappointed Dad voice and for Scorpia, the head of Internal Review, to repeat the same shit as she had two weeks prior.

"Guys, I know our fielding team can, uh, miss some things out there." The large woman ran a hand across the back of her neck as she addressed them over the webcam. This new flock of fielders was greener than a head of lettuce and collectively had the brains of one. They neglected to get some of the most basic information necessary for Catra and her peers to do the real work and their inattention to detail was their only consistency. Scorpia continued on, a bright smile replacing her previous wince. "But hey , we can all benefit from a bit of coaching! Which is where the lovely , capable design team comes in. They can't get better if we don't talk with them, folks. Send 'em an email, toss them a kudos, but certainly don't be afraid to give them pointers and honest feedback. We've got a great team here, especially when we all work together!"

Catra snorted into her coffee, rolling her eyes. Literally the same message every call. When she first stepped into the design role, fresh from the field herself, she had been happy to share her new knowledge with the field staff. Designing was a completely different outlook than collecting measurements and scoping out potential tree trimming needs that might interfere with the lines. Not only did it take problem solving skills and a surprising amount of creativity (at least for a job that dealt with a depressing amount of *math*) but when Catra was assigned a job, it became her problem from start to finish. Whether she wanted it to be or not.

That being said, even though she was forced to relive the same "This could have been an email" meeting every two weeks, she hadn't looked back once. Designing sucked, but being forced out into the elements to collect measurements on a pole was a far, far worse fate. She stared at the wall above her laptop, zoning out as Scorpia repeated to the team some information on unique situations that

called for down guy installation. Nothing Catra didn't fucking know already, thanks Scorp.

Just when she was seconds from passing out from sheer boredom, her phone buzzed. She ignored the flash of excitement that zinged through her stomach at the sound.

Adora (9:27 AM) wyd

Catra (9:27 AM) r u fuckn kiddin me rite now

It was 9:30 in the morning on a Thursday and Adora was trying to hit her up? Sure, Catra *could* once this call was over. With as flexible as her work schedule was she could totally afford to get a little flexible herself. But if Grayson was under the impression that she could be summoned at any time with those three stupid letters, she had another thing coming to her. It worked last week, but that was then and this was now.

Adora (9:28 AM) Thought it might be the only way to get you to respond. 🙃

Adora (9:28 AM) Not even a full minute. Looks like I was right!

Like hell Catra was gonna answer again after that. Adora just thought she was *so* clever...

Adora (3:30 PM) Before you get all 😾 I haven't seen you in way too long. It's Thirsty Thursday! Drink tonight?

Catra returned her attention back to the call, which actually appeared to be wrapping up. She set her phone to the side and dove back into her current job. This one had a ton of tree trimming; a line of poles with many of them so covered with vines and branches that she was ready to let them be reclaimed by the forest. The wooded area was also smackdab in the middle of someone's property, so there would be rights to gather, the customers would need to be notified (fortunately it was the "Hey, we're fucking doing this because pretty sure you like having electricity."), and this territory's forester was absolutely infuriatingly chipper guy by the name of *Bow*. Not Beau or Bo- which, while both were dumb they at least usually were short for something. But as he "humorously" corrected in their first email correspondence, it was just Bow and he used the w. As in "Wow! I sure love arrows!"

Ugh. Just kill her now. How she wished she could just tell the communications company to shove it and try again in a different part of the area, really any part that Arrow Boy wasn't in charge of. But sadly, as Scorpia so cringingly liked to say in her absolutely abysmal impression, "Make it work, designers!" Only in the most extreme circumstances, after she had exhausted every possibility, utilized every tool in her designer belt, could Catra ever tell an attacher to "remove and reroute the line." She delighted in every chance she got to use it.

That simply wouldn't be happening in this case, because the work could be done, she would just need to contact the forester company to get a pretty in depth appraisal beforehand. Bow and his team would trim up what needed to be cut and make sure there would be no major environmental impact from it along the way. She would simply have to deal with his upbeat dumbassery as they got things sorted. The thought crossed her mind that if she ever had to

collaborate with Bow *and* Adora on the same job, she'd just give up right then and there. Maybe test some high voltage lines with her bare hands.

Pushing any thought of the dummy from her mind, Catra buckled back in to get a rough estimate of just how many trees she could see that were impacting the lines. If she got the report out today, she could chill with some pole modeling or other such brainless work. In the midst of her counting, Netossa emailed her with some all too rare good news. A super complicated job from months ago, where Catra had to plan the underground cabling for an entire subdivision (catering to bunch of rich fucks all building their dream homes out in the middle of nowhere;Catra hated each one of them as individuals and as a whole) got approved with little to no follow-up corrections. That motherfucker had been a *project* and she was glad to be one step closer to never having to think about the development again. Maybe she deserved to celebrate and what better way...

Catra (4:18PM) ugh, it's just thurs bcuz im not 21 ne more. but ya, idc

Adora (4:22PM) Wahoo! 👊

Catra (4:24PM) ur so annoying, let me work u idiot

Catra (4:29PM) 8p

Adora (4:32PM) Cant wait, Cat. A week without seeing you is way too long. Ill have a lot to make up for… 😉

Adora (4:39PM) And Im off tomorrow, so. 😉

The fact Catra spent the rest of her work day with a tiny bit of spring in her step was solely due to being closer to putting the bougie

subdivision behind her once and for all, no other reason.

Shut up.

"Whoa." Adora stared at Catra, slack-jawed. As if looking dumb wasn't the blonde's default expression, her current resemblance to a hooked fish really made it clear. "Y -your hair"…

Catra drew an arm over her chest, hunching her shoulders slightly as her tail wrapped around her waist reflexively. She had decided to close up shop early today in light of her victory over the bougie subdivision and as she read in her solarium, windows open, it was apparent that the weather was beginning to change. Her long curls were really so much easier to deal with in the warmth and Catra generally preferred to straighten her hair during the winter. She could wake up, run a brush through it, and call it good. Sure *getting* the curls to their non-springy state was a pain, but she had an afternoon to kill, so why not make her upcoming morning routine easier? She scowled out with an impatient lilt. "What about it?"

"It's *beautiful* ." Adora sputtered, eyes trailing down the length of the chestnut locks, amazed to see how far it fell down her back. The curls were gorgeous, of course, but she just had not been expecting to see Catra wearing a different style. "I.Y. ou". As the words failed her, the blonde settled into a mooney-eyed grin, one that Catra immediately wanted to slap off her face. Or memorize and never let go of. Shut up.

"Dont hurt yourself, dummy ." The magicat uncoiled her tail from around herself and turned away to head into the Waste. "And wipe that smirk off your face, this has nothing to do with you. Though," She paused in the doorway to the bar, hand resting on the doorknob, "it is much easier to pull on when it's like this..."

Catra pretended to not see the fist pump out of the corner of her eye as she entered the bar.

A quick nod hello past security and then the pair were at the bar, ready to order. Catra got herself a mixed drink, just a rum and Coke, and put up with about a minute and a half of indecision from the blonde before ordering her one of the same. Adora blanched for a second, before her mouth curled into a grin. "Ordering for me, huh? Cute."

"I am *not* cute and neither was your chorus of ummm's and uhhhh's," Catra mocked her hook-up's stupid facial expression as the blonde waffled about what to order. "I was about two seconds away from telling you to fuck off and stop wasting his time, so I made the call. I'm fucking used to having to make all the decisions when I'm around you."

"Yeah, sure, until you're in the back of my truck. Then that's the last thing you want." Adora smarmed under her breath, drumming her fingers on the bartop as they waited for their drinks to arrive.

The magicat gave a low growl, but did not comment further. She would neither confirm nor deny the accuracy of that statement at this time. As soon as it was placed in front of her, Catra snatched up her drink from the bar and stalked away towards a booth. She definitely overheard that last comment and she couldn't deal with that. Just so fucking clever, that Adora Grayson. Not.

Adora followed along after the brunette, definitely feeling like she'd won this round. She settled into the seat, not quite ready to touch her glass more than it took to transport it over here. After watching Catra raise her drink and sip several times, neither speaking, Adora glanced around their surroundings slowly appraising what she could make out in the low light. Not thinking much of it she commented, fingers toying with the condensation starting to build on her glass. "Can't believe you got me back in *here* a second time. And about to drink from a glass no less." Adora smiled at her own quip before shrugging and raising her cup in a mock toast, ready to fully

embrace the long-dead concept of YOLO. The liquid was bitter and sweet all at the same time;the alcohol content probably enough to knock out some of the weaker wee beasties partying on the glass. She consoled herself with the thought as she drank.

Catra watched, entirely devoid of expression, though her tail began to lash slowly behind her. Once Adora had set her drink down again and looked to be trying to make out some of the writing on the walls near their booth, the magicat asked in a very even tone, "What do you mean I'm *here*?"

The blonde blinked away from her examination. What she had been viewing was definitely words, but they were all clustered together and had so much other scrawling over top that she could not decipher anything definitive. Still distracted by the puzzle, she didn't think anything of her answer. "I mean. Look at this place. It's a little." Really, it wasn't nearly as bad as she remembered from her first visit. Maybe the other week some chainsmokers had just come in from the patio because there was no distinguishable scent in the air, beyond the rum in her glass. The drinkware itself was smudged, but Adora had been fiddling with it quite a bit once they first sat down. They were seated by that weird stain on the floor though. Something had definitely oozed on that tile once upon a time. "Like… that for instance." She gestured towards the floor and the stain. "What bodily fluid made that? Blood? I'm guessing blood." Adora cracked a smile, certain the rough woman would get a kick out of discussing how the knife fight that made that went down.

Catra did not even need to look at the tile in question to answer. She spoke lowly over the edge of her glass. "... Paint."

"Huh?" The blonde's eyes flicked up to her drinking partner for the evening, brows furrowing together, not sure if she'd actually heard anything or not.

"It's paint, dumbass." Catra took another sip, then opened her mouth to educate, memories of the grand reopening of the bar under DT's ownership coming to her mind. It had been a day of drinking from

sunup to sun down. Residents of the gayborhood, artists and musicians, and long term patrons were all welcomed to come and leave their mark on the bar, literally. Bands scrawled their best lyrics, individuals painted their names alongside a plethora of dicks (at least most were covered up by band stickers at this point;only the most impressive and detailed dongs got to stay) and even Catra had contributed to the mural that took up almost the entire back wall behind the bar. The Waste was such an institution in the gayborhood, and the relief that someone had purchased it when Peekablue decided to sell so salient, that the response to the event had been massive. But when you get that many drunk people in one area accidents happen. For whatever reason, that paint stain just wouldnt budge from the tile no matter what they did to clean it up.

It had been one of the best days of Catra's life, a sense of community unlike one she'd ever felt before. Sure it was all just a ploy, a chance for the new owner to play at heartstrings (not to mention rake in the substantial covers for a day of drinking and plenty extra to cover "event costs"), but it sure worked with her . Even when she moved, this was still her Spot. And Adora was turning her nose up at it? Fuck that. Her jaw snapped close as quickly as it opened.

"How do you know that?" The blonde asked, genuinely curious. Catra sounded so matter of fact;she definitely had some insider knowledge. It was kind of telling that they kept using this place to meet up. Maybe it was close to Catra's home?

Whether Adora saw that she was about to answer or not, or truly wanted to know, the window was up. Catra didnt have to tell this dummy anything she didnt want to. "... I just know , okay? Drop it."

"Fine, fine." Adora surrendered easily , sensing a nerve had been struck. She had probably been a little too harsh in her judgement of this place. Sure, it was a little dark, maybe hadnt seen a mop in a while, but truthfully it wasnt that bad. No worse than her regular watering hole. Dive bars should just get a pass on certain things; most people werent coming here to be wowed by the atmosphere

and decor, but just looking for a chance to unwind in a spot where they could just be as they were. And it was obviously important to Catra, for whatever reason.

Catra stared her down, unblinking. "The Waste is The Waste. You don't have to like it. Or meet me here if it's not *good* enough for you."

"How many more times are you going to accuse me of that?" Adora asked lightly, knowing she was no longer defusing the situation, but unable to stop herself. "Look, next time we do this," She gestured between them, "You can come to my neck of the woods. See my haunt in all its glory."

"Bold of you to think we're doing *this*," Catra repeated the gesture the blonde had made, "again, dummy."

Adora nodded a few times, considering. The ice in her drink hit her teeth as she downed the last of the cocktail. Back to examining the walls for their fascinating hieroglyphics, she murmured absently. "Pretty sure you'll just keep on coming to meet me." Before Catra could even so much as scowl, let alone protest against the measured assertion, the blonde continued with a smirk across her lips as she flicked her steel-blue eyes to watch for Catra's reaction. "Because I'll make sure that *you* keep on coming and keep on coming and keep on"…

"Ughhh! Shut up!" The magicat slammed her near-empty glass down on their table. "You are the absolute *worst*, most *annoying*, positively. Dorky person I've ever met in my life!" She was about ready to tear her hair out, wondering if her masochistic proclivities were beginning to leak out of the bedroom into her everyday life. It was the only explanation of why she willingly put herself into Adora's company tonight. She could have so easily said no to the drink offer, but let's meet up for another quickie. She could have. She *should* have. "How. How is it that you can be so good in bed when you're the way that you are? It's a fucking nightmare, I swear." Catra buried her head in her hands.

"Darling, I'm a nightmare, dressed like a daydream."…

Slowly, the magicat's hands slid from where they were covering her face. She blinked twice, her heterochromatic stare otherwise not breaking away from Adora's face once. With a raspy whisper she panned out, "Y ou. Did. Not."

"Quote T aylor Swift at you?" The blonde beamed, not having the decency to look even remotely ashamed for her gross transgressions. "Y up! Sure did. I wonder if they have it on the jukebox." She regarded the player mounted on the wall thoughtfully.

"If you want to have *any* chance of getting into these pants tonight, you will stay exactly where you are." Catra hissed, ready to bolt if the blonde even inched towards the music machine. There were many things the magicat would tolerate for a good fuck; Swiftie was not one. Needing her hands to do something other than throttle the woman seated across from her, Catra picked up her glass again, staring mournfully at the last pitiful drops available to her. "I need another fucking drink."…

"A www! Why' s that?" Adora clucked her tongue consolingly , tilting her head in concern. "Rough day at work, princess?"

The magicat sucked in a breath, ear flicking once. Was it really worth the time and energy to be able to ride this handsome butch again? Of course as she pondered, Adora chose to shrug off her jacket, rolling up her sleeves to expose her sculpted forearms. Her arms flexed as she ran a hand through the short crop of her blonde hair, managing to make the muss somehow even more sexy and inviting. A single lock fell over one bright blue eye, the woman smiling at it before tossing it away with a far too practiced head flick. It was such an *act* , but damn if the magicat's mouth didn't dry instantly , the miniscule bite of rum she had remaining was not sufficient enough to quench her thirst in the slightest. It was like every motion Adora made beckoned to Catra, pulling her into the other woman's orbit no

matter how irritating or embarrassing. She drained what little she had left in her cup before muttering, "I hate you."

"And yet, you're still here. So can't help but wonder if you do or not. Are you *really* giving it your all, Cat?" The blonde said seriously, though internally was trying to hold back her laughter. Adora could climb any wall Catra threw at her, match her in any game she set, and would even adopt the brunette's pace as her own. Exactly why their hook-up last week had been so matter of fact; Adora just knew it was what Catra would need after the intensity of their time before. She wasn't really patient by nature, but anything worth having... "Why don't I run and get you another drink and then you can tell me all about it, your bad day at work." It was a risk, Catra could very well vanish into the night while Adora's back was turned. But she just had a feeling that the magicat wouldn't. For all her bluster and snarling, they were vibing; Adora always knew when a girl was into her or not. She slid out of the booth not waiting for a confirmation.

Minutes later, Adora returned to the table, precariously balancing several drinks in her hand. "Got you a repeat, along with a water. I'm not that kind of gal." She made a face as she said it, taking a long gulp of her own ice water.

Catra had considered leaving while Adora was at the bar. Really, she had, but on a closer inspection of her situation she actually did kind of want to tell someone about her victory over the subdivision. Sure Scorpia knew all about it, a job of that caliber meant that the department head had been the one who gave it the first review before they sent it off to a senior engineer who would really break it down. Her friend had been ecstatic when they got the green light this afternoon. But no one else in Catra's life would actually get it (like she really had that many people to tell in the first place). Utility poles, electrical work, it was stuff that just faded into the landscape. People took it for granted, which was fine, not like Catra really wanted to be in the limelight. It certainly wasn't anything anyone would want to like, *read* about for fun. But this was an achievement and supposedly Adora was a professional in their field so she might understand the

magnitude of that job. Of course, she was also a complete idiot so Catra wasn't really expecting much.

"Uh, thanks. Yeah. That's perfect." The magicat gratefully accepted both glasses; the water was an unanticipated, but welcomed bonus. It was so cool on her tongue; how had Adora known. She cleared her throat, suddenly a little uncomfortable.

"No problem at all!" Was the bright reply, the woman happily sipping on her own beverage. Adora seemed to have switched over to beer. Mixing. She really was a dummy.

Catra hesitated, not really knowing if the blonde had been joking about hearing about her work day or not. Well, obviously since the woman was an *asshole* she had been kidding, but she hadn't given much indication of being a total jerk and would probably listen. Catra decided to at least skirt the edges of the topic taking a swallow of her cocktail. "It actually wasn't a bad day at work. I, uh, got a big job approved." The blonde immediately honed in, all two seconds of her attention span solely on Catra in an instant. The magicat flinched, feeling so suddenly *perceived* , but with a bit of coaxing from her drinking partner she slowly relaxed enough to explain the scope of the project. She talked about the frustrations with having to design for individual needs of each house, along with making sure there would be enough power to supply the area as a whole. Adora nodded as she went, sometimes coming in with a few clarifying questions that actually weren't completely inane. The blonde didn't do much underground work, but sometimes cables were just cables whether they got installed above or below the earth. And Adora seemed to be genuinely interested in everything Catra had to say, a highly nauseating and refreshing prospect. Not much unlike Adora herself.

As the magicat finished, the blonde sat back positively beaming. "Well, look at you, Madame Designer! I knew you were good, but sheesh. That's pretty amazing. What were you doing slumming it out in the boonies with me if that's the level of skill you have?"

"Every once in a while they cut me some slack. Or more likely they knew just how fucking irritating you are and gave it to me as some form of twisted punishment." Catra was glad for the subdued overhead lighting that would cover the slight flush to her cheeks. It was all from the rum, of course, particularly since somewhere in the midst of her rant Adora had managed to flag down Glimmer's attention and silently convince the sullen bartender to refill their drinks *and* deliver them, but she wouldn't want the dummy to get the wrong impression. With a small tilt of the glass in her hand, Catra could see that once again she was in need of a top off. She set it aside, disappointed, but returned her attention to the blonde across from her. "Slumming it with you is about right. Jesus, I really don't know how you managed to fuck up the primary even after I *told you* multiple times what the right size was."

Adora blinked once, but quickly recovered with a smile. "Eh, I'm stubborn. Just part of my boundless charm."

The magicat ignored the boast. "Do you know how much shit I went through with scheduling to keep postponing the project end date on that midspan pole?" Maybe it was a slight turn in conversation, but Adora was just going to have to keep up. Rum always made her a bit more loose-lipped, but more than anything she looked for any opportunity to tear into her "supporting" departments. "I hate those fuckers. Constantly on my case about things I can't control, namely whether you bozos can find your own asses that day or not."

"I'll just have to make it up to you, won't I?" The blonde leaned back in the booth, arm draped over the back of the seat. She was all for shop talk, but she couldn't let the magicat go that long without a compliment or come on. "All that extra work. You must be so *tense*."

Catra rolled her eyes, not even dignifying that lame attempt with a response. She did make a mental note to explore that offer thoroughly, albeit later. For now, Catra was on a roll and ready to deal out some astoundingly basic education for their chosen career paths. "It's not that difficult, Grayson. If it's greenish, it's copper,

because god knows with our poor ass electrical grid upkeep, the weatherproofing is long gone. Otherwise just count the fucking wires in the bundle. Two strands wrapped around a neutral? Triplex, go figure, since there's *three wires*. Any guesses on how many quadraplex has?"

Adora huffed, taking a long quaff from her glass of water. Catra wanted to stay focused on work? Fine by her. The magicat was good, that much was obvious, but their roles weren't apples to apples. "Pfft. Try counting wires when they're 25-35 feet above you, suspended in the air. Especially if it's raining or snowing or whatever. It's really not that easy for those of us that don't just get to sit back and putter around on a computer all day."

"I look at the poles from cameras in *space* for fuck's sake. Or rely on the few pictures the fielders take for me. If I can figure it out correctly from Google Earth, you can figure it out when it's right in front of you." Catra purposely ignored the comment about the height; like she was going to secede an inch on an issue she was right about. Also there were a variety of tools the crews had at their disposal to get a closer look. Catra was just trying to make excuses for her own incompetence. "You know what? Just call me the next time you're out on a job. I'll figure it out for you so you don't fuck shit up again. Save some other designer the perpetual headache that comes from working with you."

Adora raised an eyebrow, a smug grin flying to her face. *This* was more like it, definitely the direction she wanted things to go. "... Did you just tell me to call you?"

"No! Shut up, ughhh." The woman's tail lashed behind her back wildly, tipping back the remainder of her drink. That one went down way too easily. She pointed one clawed finger at the smirking butch on the other side of the table. "You're buying me another drink for that."

"Wooow. Way to make it even more obvious, Cat." The blonde teased, standing up from the booth to happily follow the woman's

command for another potent potable. "Keeping to the same thing? I'll be right back."

The magicat's eyes narrowed for a moment, before she relaxed and grinned. "Nah, I wanna switch it up. I'll go up with you." Catra rose with surprising grace given the speed at which she'd been drinking this evening and led the way, tail brushing against Adora's arm as she passed.

She ended up with a drink in a short glass that Adora didn't recognize in the slightest, some sort of house special called The Portal. It was a disconcerting inky black, though as Catra held it up to her mouth the blonde saw in the light that it was actually a deep purple. The magicat smacked her lips at the taste, wincing and shaking her head all the while.

Adora held her curiosity in check until Catra waved her glass to indicate she wanted another. The blonde returned with the requested beverage and as they made idle chatter, watched as the woman imbibed two more sips. With every drop Catra seemed to give into the biting liquor more and more; her ears relaxed and her laughs just grew a touch more squeaky. It was adorable to behold, but Adora made sure to keep her water glass full, nudging it towards her as they talked. The gesture was ignored. Unable to resist any longer, the blonde held out her hand. "All right, lemme get some of that."

Catra snorted. "No. Get yer own."

"No? *Really*? After all the places my mouth's been on you, sharing a drink is where you draw the line. Okay, Catra."

"God, here! Just shud up already." She slid the drink over in front of the blonde, the back of her mind fully focused on just all the places Adora's mouth had been and would be later tonight. A purr wanted to escape at the thought, but she held back. Catra couldn't appear too eager. Adora couldn't *know*. Sure she knew, but she couldn't *know*, ya know?

Adora braced herself. The scent of alcohol was pungent as she raised the cup to her lips. Her reaction to the contents in the glass was immediate and sharp. With a sputtering cough she choked out, "Jez", the closest she could get to Jesus with her scorched vocal chords. That exclamation did not seem sufficient enough to capture the distress that she was in. Her brain mashed together two phrases, "Mary on a cross!" and "That's wrong!" The ending result came out suspiciously like "Matron!" as a coughing fit overtook her.

Catra cackled with delight. Sure, Portals had definitely taken her to another reality once or twice, but not after a single *sip*. She grinned viciously, making no attempt to ease the blonde in her time of need. Once that lever was flipped, one simply had to ride it out all their own. "Wow, such a big, strong butch you are. Real sexy, babe. Take me now!" It had started as a joke, but actually…

"What the *hell* is in that glass?" The blonde managed to sputter out after several long pulls from her glass of water. "It's unholy!"

"Ah, laddie- lassie, whatever you be. This be gentler than mother's milk!" The magicat winked, giggling as she affected the brogue. She didn't really know where it came from, but very quickly decided that she did not care in the slightest. "Mibbe a wee bit sharp, but no worse than yours truly." Catra let just the hint of an incisor peek out as she smirked. "Thin' my bite's worse, but I'll make it feel *real* good."

Adora placed an elbow on the table, leaning her head to rest in her hand. She watched as the brunette happily lapped at the petrol in her glass, apparently numb to the bite at this point. Not a great sign. Carefully, Adora reached a hand over, placing it across Catra's wrist. "Hey, we've got all night. There goes your stomach lining if you drink that stuff quick enough."

"Don't tell me what to do!" Catra hissed, recoiling away from the blonde's touch. Her eyes narrowed as the hand dropped to the table. Satisfied, she paused for a second then tipped the drink back, trying to down it in one go. Of course, inhaling liquid fire was not an

advisabled course of action, even as an attempt to assert one's autonomy, so within seconds Catra was coughing and choking.

Adora moved swiftly, dragging the glass away from the sputtering magicat, on high enough alert that she couldn't even take a moment to appreciate the feeble grabby hands the woman tried to make at the cup in between her fit of coughing. The blonde was seated next to Catra a moment later, rubbing small circles against her back to try and even her breathing. "You're okay, it's all good." She repeated as the magicat slowly regained her composure.

With one last wheeze, Catra swatted at Adora's arm, claws retracted, but wiggling away from the other woman. "Get off, dummy. No touching!"

Adora immediately threw up her hands, halting as to not make any sudden movements. Her instinct was telling her to very slowly exit from the booth and find a way to convince the woman that a switch to water would make her Friday morning so much better.

Before she could, Catra crashed down on her shoulder, the blonde just managing to catch her. She muttered out one quiet "idiot" before her multi-colored eyes shut. After positioning her arm against the back of the booth, trying to touch as little of the dozing woman as the current situation allowed, Adora did not dare to move again. Glimmer had been quietly, but attentively, watching the scene from behind the bar. As Adora made eye contact with the man, he gave one single nod before filling up a pitcher of water. She smiled gratefully, in the need of non-alcoholic liquid for herself, but knowing when Catra woke up from her nap that she'd need to pour at least three glasses into the woman before calling her an Uber.

She smiled to herself as Catra readjusted deeper into her shoulder, long hair acting as a curtain to partially cover her face from Adora's view. She had to resist every urge to tuck the long locks behind one ear. Glimmer appeared then, filling both their glasses. Adora nodded her thanks as the haggard man shrugged. She glanced at her watch;

barely eleven o'clock. They had plenty of time for Catra to sleep it off a bit before the bar announced its last call for the night.

Catra awoke a short while later, Adora just browsing on her phone. The first thing the magicat registered was how she was latched onto the blonde's arm, the very close second was just how warm the other woman was. She shifted slightly, tail wrapping Adora's wrist.

At the fuzz brush, Adora looked away from her phone, smiling down at the two-toned eyes that had been watching her. "Hey there. Welcome back." The magicat made a curious little trilling noise, but otherwise didn't answer. Adora's heart seized at the sound, biting her lip to keep from absolutely cooing at how cute it had been. She refrained only because she recalled how varied Catra's responses had been this evening. Fortunately she seemed docile enough currently, though still a bit blurry. "How about you sit up and drink some water with me?"

The brunette made no move to change her position, entirely content to stay in the warmth. A part of her knew this was highly embarrassing, but she was still far too deep in the Portal to really care. Adora poured some more water, scooting the glass closer to her. "Just a sip?" Catra growled lightly at the offer, but her tongue was feeling a little thick. The water had felt good earlier in the night...

Relieved to see Catra raise up and begin to drink something that was actually hydrating, Adora waited until the woman had gotten her fill. She rolled out her shoulder and stretched the arm that Catra had claimed for herself shortly after laying down. Her clawed hand had groped around for it, searching along the back of the seat before tucking it under her chin. Adora was pretty sure the no touching rule was no longer in play if the magicat herself had been the one to seek it out so just rolled with it. Then again, were there actually any hard and fast rules when it came to Catra? "That's my girl. Just keep drinking, okay? I'll get you back home here soon, but take your time."

"Taking me home, Dora?" Catra grinned, nails slightly scratching the glass as they curled in anticipation. Exactly why she'd come out here

tonight; to celebrate and get pounded. She'd had her fill of booze and was more than ready to get filled by the butch.

Adora chuckled slightly, shaking her head. "Not tonight, babe. I'll help call you a car in a bit to take you home, after you sober up some more."

"What if I... wen' home with you." Catra hedged. At the moment that certainly sounded like a pretty fantastic idea. Her tail came to tickle behind Adora's calf and reflexively the blonde shied away. The magicat was a little put out by the flinch, but it only made her teasing all the more bold. With far more finesse than someone who had been downing drinks all night should possess (not to mention whilst in a booth), Catra stretched up and firmly placed herself in Adora's lap, facing the blonde head on. She wrapped her arms around her shoulder, staring at the woman's strong jaw, following it down the curve of her neck. In a saturated, calculating tone, she rasped out, "Hey, Adora."

Adora had to hold back a groan at the position change. Catra was just so suddenly *there*. She couldn't take the woman up on her offer, it wouldn't be right, but *fuck.*

Before the blonde could react, the magicat grabbed onto one of Adora's big hands, bringing the longest of her fingers up towards her lips. It hovered there, not quite brushing against them, only teasing with her warm breath. Catra smirked as she felt Adora give a little start, eyes alight at the possibilities. "We could hav' *a lotta* fun."

Summoning a fortitude that bordered on godlike, Adora cleared her throat and gently moved their hands away from Catra's mouth. "Thoroughly tempting. If you weren't drunk." Her voice only wavered slightly, which also was an accomplishment in and of itself.

"Pf ft. I'm fine! Jus' need like two, three glasses of water..." The brunette reached back behind her, searching for a glass. Weakly Adora provided for her, Catra giving her a pointed grin of thanks. She chugged heartily from the cup, a single drop escaping from the

corner of her mouth. Her tongue quickly lapped it up, before running over the length of her lips and settling on the point of her fang, mouth parted slightly. Catra's eyes never swayed from Adora's reverent gaze, luxuriating in the agonizing want coming off the other woman in waves. "See? Better already..."

Adora pushed away the fog in her brain and the chant of "I'm so gay, so gay, so gay." Maybe Catra *was* better, but it was also just not a place she wanted to even get close to, a risk she would not take no matter the vast appeal of the situation. She managed to choke out, having to clear her throat several times to get through the four simple words. "Glad you're feeling better."

Catra gave a small roll of her hips down, hand resting on Adora's collarbone, curling her fingers so her claws rested ever so suggestively against the woman's chest. In a low purr, "Just imagine how much better I'll feel with your hard-"…

With a fluid motion Adora firmly placed her hands on Catra's waist, the magicat's eyes widening at the unforeseen contact. She bit her lip eagerly, but it quickly turned into a discontented pout as Adora lifted her off of her lap, settling her on the table. Catra growled faintly when Adora then scooted herself down the bench, not even having the decency to remain in between her legs. Spoilsport.

The blonde took a few moments to breathe and clear her head, before saying in a shaky voice, "I-I'm gonna call you an Uber. Your phone, please?" She held out her hand, not the least bit surprised when Catra's tail settled in the palm before hooking around her wrist. The magicat gave a slight tug, inviting Adora back to her original seat. She groaned and inhaled, drawing the breath between her teeth. "Catra. Phone?"

"Don't see why you just don't *take* me." The brunette giggled, just short of fluttering her eyelashes, "... home."

Breathing steadily, Adora stared at the tabletop. Would it be that bad, really? Neither one of them was really under any illusion of how the

night would end, it was pretty well implied. "No, no. It wasn't right." She raised her head, gaze piercing as she regarded the insistent magicat, wanting to stop things before they went any further. "Not tonight. Now, give me your phone right now so I can call you a damn Uber."

Catra crossed her arms, sorely discontented by the blonde's stubbornness. But fine, if Adora wasn't gonna play ball tonight, she wanted to get home as soon as possible and take care of matters herself. Her Satisfyer would satisfy where the blonde would not. "No fucking Uber. Scorpia." Even a little toasted, Catra was able to recall the pact she had with her best friend. It had been drilled into her mind so many times over the years that it was just instinctual. Scorp would come for her and not charge her an arm and leg (maybe just breakfast the next day or at the cost of some light ribbing). She tossed her phone over, making sure to unlock it. Sure she was perfectly capable of calling herself, but maybe once Adora realized what she'd be giving up for the night as she dialed...

The blonde blinked, not recognizing that particular ride share company. Man, there really were new services out all the time. "All right then, Ill call you a Scorpia." The magicat snif fed, finding a partially undrunk beer on the table and helping herself. Adora was far too engaged with swiping through Catra's home screen, looking for any apps by that name. Her brows furrowed together as nothing really stuck out at her, the situation only coming to make sense after using the search function on the phone. "Ah, Scorpia' s a person. Got it."

"Duh, she' s a dummy. Like you, but also not. You're a *dummy* ." Catra explained, biting the lip of the bottle as her eyes roved over the handsome blonde. "Just a fuckable dummy"…

"Another time. I promise, Cat." Adora replied, more focused on the phone ringing in her ear. It was late, hopefully this person would answer…

"Heeey , Wildcat." A voice yawned. *"Wha' s up?"*

"Uh, hi," Adora began, already feeling like a heel for obviously waking this person up. Maybe she should just hang up, take the magicat home herself. The problem was, with as persuasive as Catra could be, Adora simply didn't trust herself. Especially in light of their past vehicular activities. "I'm sorry to wake you, but my name is Adora and"…

"Where's Catra? Is she okay? Is she hurt? Does she require medical attention? I swear, say the word and I'll have an ambulance on the way in seconds *!"*

The woman on the other end seemed on the edge of a breakdown, but Adora couldn't get a word in edgewise to try and prevent the spiral. It was only when this Scorpia drew a small breath that Adora broke through. "Catra's fine, she's fine! No ambulance needed! She's right here- Cat, can you say hi to Scorpia?" She held out the phone in Catra's direction. The woman just proudly displayed her middle finger as she drained the last of the room temperature beer. "... Or flip me the bird, that's fine too."

The woman on the other end of the line heaved a sigh of relief, chuckling. *"Y up, that sounds like my Wildcat. She's okay?"*

"Y eah." Adora began, frowning slightly as Catra set the empty bottle back down on the table. The magicat stuck out her tongue and eased down from where she had been seated on the table. Adora watched, still speaking to Scorpia as Catra made herself comfortable in the booth properly. "She had a little too much to drink though. We're here at The Crimson W aste? If that means anything to you." The blonde was heartened to hear the woman on the other end call out, *"O, boy does it! Good times, good times!"* before falling into a fit of giggles.

Waiting patiently for the lifeline to gain some control of herself, Adora looked over towards Catra, who had moved close enough to reach over and begin to trail the tips of her fingers over the outside of Adora's thigh under the table. The blonde swallowed and grabbed the wandering hand, lacing their fingers together and giving it a

fluttering squeeze. The magicat startled, staring down at their interlocked hands and blinking in Adora's direction. The corner of her mouth ticked up for a second before looking away.

Before Adora could decipher any of that, Scorpia seemed well enough recovered for her to continue. "Great, because I was wondering if you might be able to come get her. Well, actually, she asked for you specifically"…

"That's my girl!" Adora bit the inside of her cheek on that one;it was an innocuous enough phrase, certainly not one the blonde had any claim to at this time, but... *"Yeah, of course I can! Only thing is, the Waste isn't really in the neighborhood for me anymore, so might take me a minute… You seem more or less in control of all your facilities. Minding staying with her until I can get there?"*

"Wouldn't dream of leaving."The woman was back to resting her head on Adora's shoulder, still holding on to her hand. Adora began to run circles over the top of Catra's thumb, swearing for a moment that she heard a faint purr from her left side, but it was overshadowed by the woman on the phone.

"Whew, boy. That's a load off! What'd you say your name was-Adora?"

"Yeah, that's me."

"Thanks for taking care of her, Adora, seriously. Should be less than an hour. If Grizz wants to close up, just explain the situation to him and he'll get it. Probably let you stay inside so long as you don't mind helping to clear tables!" Scorpia laughed. *"Not the first time I've ever rescued Catra from the bar and she's carted my drunk butt home enough times too. He's all too familiar with Super Pal Duo shenanigans."*

Catra growled out of nowhere, tail flicking behind her. Adora glanced at her, puzzled, but shook it off. The bout passed, whatever its source was, and the magicat was back to happily claiming Adora's

arm as her own, a fact that truly did not bother the blonde in the slightest. "That's such great news. Thank you, Scorpia. I really appreciate this. Drive safe. If anything comes up, Cat will have her phone on. Give us a buzz."

"Roger that! Over and out!"

True to what Scorpia had indicated, once Adora had explained the situation to Glimmer, the barkeep barked that they could stay. Amazingly he did not even invoke the stipulation that they work for the right. Which was all the better as Catra seemed to have dozed off once more, her head resting in Adora's lap. Adora looked down at her sleeping beauty, not envious of the headache she was bound to wake up with. But even from that short conversation with Scorpia, the blonde knew Cat would at least be in good hands. And at least she herself would get to sleep in;the vacation day had been a little impulsive but-...

Oh. Tomorrow was a work day. Fuck. Suddenly Thirsty Thursday seemed even more ill-advised for a couple of almost 30 year olds. She sighed, but as Catra turned over to lay on her side, head resting against the blonde's stomach, Adora couldnt help but smile. Their night had taken a few twists and turns, but the fact that Catra lay sleeping against her was truly the best outcome. She didnt even mind that they hadnt had sex tonight or even kissed once. Adora wasnt brave enough to call this outing a date, no, she wanted the pleasure of asking the woman out with intention and treating her like royalty for an evening. But it was a start, a start that Adora could definitely work with.

Not even forty-five minutes later, Catra's phone buzzed. Scorpia was outside, but the doors were locked for the night. Glimmer would probably let her in, but would Adora mind just coming out? They'd already put him through enough. Adora smiled at the long message, agreeing it was high time the barkeep got to go home to his bed. She nudged at Catra's shoulder, the woman giving a little whine of protest and shaking off her hand. Adora grinned, changing tactics. She tucked the loose strands of Catra's long, chestnut colored locks behind her

ear, hearting swelling as the woman gave an unconscious little smile and her golden eye flickered open slightly. She said softly, loathe to disturb the woman in any way. "Hey , Scorpia is here."

Catra groaned and buried her face in Adora's thigh, digging into her place for the night. Adora considered for a moment before lifting the woman up with great care, cradling her arms behind the magicat's knees and neck. Catra's claws dug in a little as she felt herself being moved, but relaxed when she realized what was happening, all too happy to pretend to be asleep. Adora walked carefully, beyond grateful when Glimmer came over with the jacket she almost left behind. He awkwardly balanced it on the blonde's shoulder, shaking his head with a low growl of, "Least she didn't puke this time"…

There was a story for another time, but for now Adora just wanted to safely get Catra home. She moved down the hallway mindfully, glad that the door at the end could be pushed open with a knee. As the night air hit them, Catra shivered, turning to clutch into Adora's chest before sighing in relief at the blonde's body heat.

"Well, that alone was worth the drive, getting to see this cuteness first hand!" A tall woman, more jacked than most of the professional builders Adora saw at the gym, wandered over with a wide grin. "Not sure when Wildcat went and got herself a girlfriend, but I guess I know what we're talking about over breakfast!"

"Oh- we're not, she's *not* -..." Adora fumbled, bemused. She had no idea who this person was to Catra, so it was hard to say how much of their situation the magicat would want aired. "We're just friends." She finished lamely , frowning as she said it. It wasn't right, but there wasn't an easier , less revealing explanation that came to mind.

The woman ignored Adora, waving the words away. "Nah, don't spoil it for me! Wanna hear every detail for myself, at least once Wildcat is able to drag herself out of bed." Scorpia giggled, waggling her eyebrows at the blonde. "Speaking of, mind telling me how bad it got for our girl tonight so I know what to expect tomorrow?"

"Ah, well, haven't really seen her drunk before so hard to say. She was pretty good until she started on that one drink, the weird black one? Then it sort of"…

"Portals? Oh goodness, Cat. Adora." Scorpia's face was now entirely serious, a slight frown on her lips. "Tell me honestly, how many did she have? And did she speak with an accent tonight? Even for a second?"

"Uhhh. Two. And yeah, a bit." The blonde blinked, not expecting that question in the slightest.

"Was it country twang, English, or something else?"

"... Vaguely Scottish?" Adora offered, now intent on hearing the entire *novella's* worth of stories from Catra's best drunk moments someday.

"Huh, that's a new one... Guess you brought it out in her, ya bonnie lass! Best get your lady tucked into bed, I'm parked right over here." Scorpia led the way, opening the door for Adora to lay Catra across the back seat. As she left her arms, the brunette shivered again, curling up tightly. Adora didn't even hesitate for a moment to wrap Catra up in her jacket before shutting the door.

"Hey, Adora. Thanks again for calling me." Scorpia clapped a hand on her shoulder, looking about two seconds from pulling Adora into a rough bro hug. "Seriously, it means a lot and shows me how much you care for her. I like that. I like you!"

Adora chuckled nervously, entirely unprepared for the overwhelming amount of sincerity from this perfect stranger. She awkwardly patted the woman's hand before stepping away, happy to get some distance. Scorpia was obviously very sweet but… "Uh, uh, thanks for coming to get her." She considered for a moment, making up her mind rather quickly. "Would you let me know when you get her home? Just like a quick text, nothing major"…

"Oh, yeah, of course! Lemme just give you my number!" Scorpia dug around in her pocket, fishing out her phone.

"Oh, no, you really don't have to- I mean, just text me from Catra's phone?"..

"Nonsense, I'm sure we'll be seeing a lot of you so it just makes sense to do the exchange now. Or do you want to give me yours? Either way is totally fine with me, end result is all the same! Six to one, half a dozen to the other in my book!" The woman grinned happily at her, fingers ready to punch in her number.

Adora blinked, but shrugged. It was a little strange, given the circumstances, but she really didn't care if this woman had her telephone number, especially if it meant she would get confirmation that Catra had made it home safely tonight. After swapping digits, Scorpia gave an enthusiastic wave, thanking Adora again and promising she'd text the minute they parked at Catra's apartment.

The blonde watched as the SUV disappeared into the night, equal parts relieved and disappointed. Catra didn't need a guardian, someone to babysit her, or keep her in line. That wasn't the role she wanted to play in the woman's life in the slightest. But maybe if Adora had been a little more insistent about her drinking water, a little less free with the refills. She sighed and frowned, the question of whether she'd played tonight correctly weighing heavily on her mind as she made her way home all by herself.

Scorpia had just made the turn off the street The Waste was located on when Catra sat up in the back seat. The driver looked at her soused passenger in the rearview mirror, raising an eyebrow. "Hey, Wildcat. Good time tonight?" Catra did not meet her gaze or give any acknowledgement. Scorpia continued on, entirely nonplussed by the snub. "I'll let you get some rest, but you're definitely telling me all

about your new girlfriend over pancakes. And sausage, maybe bacon? Ah, well see what the mood is tomorrow."…

Catra looked out the window at the sleepy buildings they passed, claws digging into her arms as she coiled into herself. Without preamble, she pressed the button to roll down the window. She ripped Adora's jacket off of her and flung it out the window, the red material flailing as it left her hands. Before Scorpia could say a word, Catra's mismatched orbs met hers again in the rear view window, glinting dangerously under the streetlights. She spoke plainly, though venom dripped from every word. "She is *not* my girlfriend."

Chapter End Notes

This Intermission from SMUT and SIN brought to you by: Relationship Building and Development, Amitola12 Style.

"If you dont want it as a one and done...
Prepare to *suffer*... through puns and fun!"

Except, hmm, our magicat didn't seem to be having much fun towards the end there, did she? Even Adora seemed a bit subdued. Hmm hm hm...

If anyone is curious, The Portal is my name for a Black Sunday:
1 oz Wild Turkey 101 Proof Bourbon
1 oz Everclear
Black Cherry soda
Not a chugging drink!

If you follow me on Twitter (which you totally can, @amitola121).and saw my "and Puppetmaster" tweet, it was completely about Catra's drunk accent. None of you can stop me! (And as some Discord patrons have learned, I get an obnoxious drawl with the right level of indulgence of alcohol. Hehe.)

Take care, all!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Oh, fun!" Scorpia said brightly as she turned the wheel. "We're *that* kind of drunk tonight. Just my favorite, let me tell you."

Catra growled as the car began to head in the direction that they had been traveling previously. With her teeth partially bared, she snarled at the rearview mirror. "The fuck you think yer doin'?"

"Going back for someone else's property that you tossed out the window for some reason, Wildcat." The driver sighed, eyes trained forward as she tried to recall exactly where the jacket had been jettisoned. "That was not exactly a nice thing to do, drunk or not. I'm sure it all had great meaning in your head though- you ready to talk about this now?"

"... Nothin' to talk bout." Catra sulked from the backseat, biting at every word. She should have known Scorpia was never going to *let it go* .

"Uhuh, yup, hear you loud and clear ." Scorpia pulled up against a curb, fishing out her phone and tossing her hazard lights on. She turned to face her passenger. "I'm gonna run and see if I can find Adora's jacket- oh, don't *hiss* at her name for Pete's sake! Really convincing me there's nothing to talk about, by the way." Scorpia climbed out of the drivers side, leaning her head back to fix Catra with a friendly, but steady gaze. "Just stay here. Please don't make this night into a repeat of the Hide-N-Seek championship, 2017. You climb *way* too well and I just don't have it in me to scale anything tonight. And I'll always find you, Wildcat." The wink that accompanied the words gave it a cheerful level of threat.

The magicat gave another small hiss as she tucked up onto the seat and refused to meet her friend's eye. She heard Scorpia release one short breath before tottering out into the night, the flashlight on her phone trained to the ground. What an absolute fucking waste of time; Catra just wanted to be *home*. She was tired, cold, and still uncomfortably drunk. Fucking Portals. Fucking Crimson Waste. And absolutely the biggest fuck you to Ad-...

Scorpia's return to the car interrupted Catra's discordant rampage of thoughts. Of course she didn't drink enough to blackout; that would have been too much to ask. "Oh, boy. I found it, but man do you have good aim. Straight into the only mud puddle in the whole dang lot." She held the dripping fabric away from her, making a face and wrinkling her nose. "Ah, jeez. This thing stinks; there was definitely more than just mud and water in that puddle. Hope I still got a few plastic bags in my trunk."…

"Serves her right." Catra asserted, tail twitching slightly. It was a satisfying sight to see. The owner probably had a million like it in their closet, but just the fact something of theirs had been sullied was good enough for her.

"... I really can't wait to hear what she did." From towards the trunk, Catra heard her friend mutter. "*Or what you think she did, at least.*" The magicat only flicked an ear, giving some serious thought to how much ground she could cover on all fours in her current state.

Within minutes Scorpia was settled back into the driver's seat, the filthy garment double bagged in the front on the floor with a towel underneath for good measure. The buff woman lived by the Scout's motto: Always be Prepared. She had a whole arsenal of "Oops, life happened, take this" in her trunk to cover nearly every situation. She also held out an impossibly soft, fuzzy blanket to her friend in the backseat. "Here you go, Wildcat. I know you're cold. Just cuddle up and I'll getcha home."

Catra stared at the offering before snatching it, her head giving a particularly voracious whirl at the sudden jab of movement. So much

for the idea of running. She gave a rather pitiful moan, holding her head to stop the spinning. Scorpia clucked her tongue and hurried around to the passenger side door near Catra's feet, intent on tucking her bestie in. Satisfied at the burrito she'd created for Catra to nestle into for what remained of the drive, she motioned to the plastic bag for trash that was hanging on the back of the driver's seat. "There we are. If you need to hurl, try to aim for the bag. It'll all be okay in the morning, Wildcat."

The magicat blinked at her friend impassively, tracking Scorpia as she walked around the front of the car and came to sit back in the driver's seat. Once again the large woman fished out her phone, obviously shooting off a text to someone. Catra lay her head back against the door with a growl, narrowing her eyes as they continued to not be driving towards her much more comfortable bed. "Whatta ya doin', Scorp? W an'be home."

"T exting Adora to let her know well be a couple minutes behind our original ETA."The woman replied, ridiculously engrossed in spelling out her message to notice how her passenger had wrested herself from her cocoon and was sitting up, glowering at her. Still not looking back, Scorpia assured, "Don't worry! I won't tell her why . Just be our little soused secret, Wildcat. I'm sure with some dry cleaning we can get her jacket back to..."

Catra tried to snatch Scorpia's phone out of her hand, fully prepared to chuck it out the window as well. Shatter the damn thing before whatever novel Scorpia was crafting could be finished. But the woman must not have been quite as distracted as Catra thought, Scorpia holding it up out of her reach and using a single beefy elbow to keep the scrambling magicat more or less in the backseat. She typed a few more characters, then lowered both her arms. "Aaand sent! There."

"What the *fuck* , Scorpia?" Catra demanded, slamming herself back in the seat and fully ignoring how her perception swayed at being jostled so. If her legs didn't feel so goddamned heavy , she'd bolt. She was *never* drinking again (at least that much, that quickly). "The

fuck you texting *her* for?" She spat the words out with her eyes closed tight, wishing so fervently that they would just start to fucking drive again. Home. Catra just wanted to be *home* .

"Just don't want her to worry! I don't know how long you two have been seeing each other," The savage growl from the backseat convinced Scorpia to not inquire about it either , "but I'm sure she'll want to know."

So much wrong in this situation. So many boundaries being crossed; Scorpia texting a perfect fucking stranger about her commute home, just assuming the blonde would care. Speaking of assuming, how *dare* she continue to imply that anything more were going on between her and that person she refused to name, even in her head. The asshole had said it herself, so plainly. They were *friends* . The word brought up a fresh wave of acid in Catra's stomach, the potent mix of Everclear and black cherry roiling like a maelstrom within her. She swallowed it down; the only thing spewing from her mouth tonight would be the feral shriek as she dug her claws into the plush upholstery of the SUV's seats. She wanted to rip it to shreds in light of the fact that this woman, her supposed best friend, was so flagrantly flouting her limits. Even without knowing the background, Catra was making it pretty fucking clear she didn't want anything to do with the subject. But as Scorpia's phone chimed, the short-haired woman cooing at how sweet Adora was for thanking her for the update, Catra surrendered to the weight of it all, slumping against the backseat. Her rage imploded in on itself, drying up instantly until she was left an empty husk of exhaustion and lingering alcohol. Catra just didn't have it in her to fight it. Her voice quivered as she stared up at the roof of the car, unblinking. "Don't matter . She's never gonna wan'see me again after tonight"…

Scorpia looked at her bedraggled bestie in the rearview mirror, frowning at the sight of how drawn, spent, and small she appeared. The driver's normally warm brown eyes were pained in the mirror's reflection. Scorpia spoke gently as she turned the engine over. "I'm

sorry you feel that way right now, Catra. I don't think it's true, but I also don't think you're ready to hear that. Let's just get you home."

Catra continued to stare aimlessly above her for the remainder of the drive, a fuzzy, incoherent retelling of the night playing in her head on a loop.

"*We're not, she's* **not**"…

Fuck you, Adora.

For the second time that night, Catra was lifted up and carried somewhere. She tried to protest this time around, twisting and flailing against the solid press of Scorpia's ironbound arms, but her best friend could not be thwarted so easily. "C'mon, Wildcat. Just relax, all right? Then more steps up and we'll be in the door. Just don't wanna see you miss a step and splatter."

Catra didn't necessarily passively resign herself to being carted around like a ragdoll, but upon a second survey of her situation, climbing the stairs to her door really didn't seem all that pleasant. Scorp fumbled with the keys for a second, cursing with a vexed "Oh, sassafras!" as they nearly slipped from her fingers. She caught them against the outside of her leg, struggling to not drop the precious cargo of her bestie or make her life any more difficult by letting the keys fall to the floor.

"Put me the fuck down *now.*" The bundled magicat commanded, sick of standing *outside* her apartment. The drive and depression had done wonders to sober her, but Catra was certain that even after a pitcher of Portals, she would possess more coordination than Scorpia on a good day.

"All right, Wildcat. Just don't run, please. Two more seconds and we'll be inside. Apartment good, run bad." Two minutes after her feet

hit the ground, Catra was able to face plant into her bed. She didn't bother to shuck her clothes off and hissed when Scorpia tried to coax her to sit upright to drink some water. She was done. Just so fucking done. Sleep beckoned to her the moment her head hit the mattress.

Maybe by some miracle she wouldn't wake.

The universe was not nearly that benevolent; Catra really didn't sleep all that well but nor was she truly awake by the time the first few furtive rays of dawn began to stream in between the shutters of her blinds. Her head was concrete, though whether it was the effects of the alcohol passing through her system or the disjointed fifteen minutes of rest she got, who knew. Her throat burned with thirst, but she steadfastly ignored the three bottles of water Scorpia had left for her, not to mention the little stack of painkillers. It was a rebellion in which she was the only casualty, but she was complacent in her role as victim. Catra just laid in bed, blinking up at the ceiling, wondering exactly where the fuck her life had gone so wrong.

Well. Not truly wondering because it was pretty fucking obvious. She could pinpoint the exact day it went sideways, not to mention all the events that led up to the fork in her life's path. What she couldn't figure is when she got so fucking *stupid* to let it happen to her. When did she become the type of woman to let a handsome face addle her wits so? A handsome face with a strong jaw, an infectious laugh, arms that could squeeze coal into diamonds… *Motherfucker*. She thrust a pillow over her face, screaming and willing the repeating torrent of thoughts to please let her slip into unconsciousness for a few hours.

She couldn't be that lucky. Instead she was treated to a repeat of all the ways she had screwed up tonight, an indepth play-by-play of just how Catra had made an utter ass of herself at every turn. It was supposed to have been one quick, celebratory drink followed by a backseat romp. Fun, painless, and drama-free. Why she had ever thought *Entrals* would end well for her. She ground her teeth down

hard, forcing the prick of tears to fuck off from whence it came as she buried herself deeper into the covers.

She was a goddamn joke.

Sometime midmorning, Scorpia came to check on her bedridden bestie. She tapped on the door lightly, but entered without being invited in. She at least had the sense to hang back by the door, lest the cougar be provoked. "Heeey Wildcat, how you feeling?"

By that point, Catra had curled herself into a ball on the bed, piling every blanket and pillow she could reach (without exacerbating the dizzy feeling) over top of her, just wishing for suffocation. No response came from the mess of bedding and regret. Drinking was so fun until you got drunk. Catra's self-control liked to mix things up somewhere around drink two or three. "No more" became "One more" and she was left to suffer the consequences.

"I made you some tea! And also broke your kettle. Guess it's a good thing your birthday's coming up in a couple weeks, huh?" The woman said brightly as she continued to stand in the doorway, weighing her options. Catra did not stir or make a single sound to acknowledge her presence.

"I called us off from work today," Scorpia explained, finally deciding it was safe to enter Catra's den. She set the cup of tea down on the end table next to her bed, its minty fragrance wafting through the room. "But, uhh, Nettie wants you to give her a call whenever you feel up to it. Preferably today. Yeah."

Catra shuffled deeper into the bedding, screwing her eyes tight. Great.

After she tossed and turned for a while longer, Catra fumbled around for her cell phone. The only thing she managed to do was knock over the stone-cold cup of tea that Scorpia left her, cursing up a

storm as the herbal blend doused her floor. The stench of mint would linger for weeks, she was sure.

Scorpia came to investigate at the clatter and typhoon of swearing. "Oopsie daisy! Ill grab a towel. Second drawer linen closet still?"

Catra ignored the question, her voice cracked and rusted, "The fuck's my phone?"

"Ah, Ill grab it. I, uh, thought it might be best if you weren't left unsupervised with it last night." Her friend shrugged, looking a little embarrassed. "I know you probably won't be happy with that but"…

"Phone. Now ."

Adora (2:24 AM) Hope you made it home safe. Drink lots of water , Catra.

Catra glared at the insufferably smug message on her phone. Of course the sanctimonious idiot would try to dole out completely obvious advice, make it seem as if she cared. Perfect Adora never overindulged, always knew when to quit. She gripped her phone, the heavy duty, drop-proof, claw-proof case the only thing saving it from splintering in her grasp. She swiped the message away, trying to refocus on the far more important matter at hand: calling her boss.

"Catra," The telephone call began, *"Appreciate you calling. I know you're not feeling well today ."*

"Yeah, sure," The magicat croaked, realizing that she should have inquired about what sort of illness Scorpia reported her as having. Stomach bug? Cough? Should she try to sneeze once or twice to really sell it? Fortunately her boss wasn't the type to pry , and she

actually did feel like shit, so Catra's acting skills probably wouldn't be put to the test. "What's up?"

"Need you to log on and transfer all your files on that subdivision to the general drive. You can put in the time for it, as well for this call. Just subtract it from your paid time off for today. I know I'm asking you to work on a sick day, which isn't great, but we just want to get this closed up, ASAP." The woman on the other end said brusquely. *"Lash and his team will finish it."*

Catra blinked at the information. Her head felt fuzzy and thick, not fully comprehending. She had no idea of what to expect from this call, but this definitely hadn't been it. Surely their panties weren't in such a bunch that this couldn't wait until Monday? Hell, even tomorrow. Catra had worked plenty of Saturdays before. She gulped down some water, ignoring the sloshing it made in her stomach. Her insides heaved to and fro in protest at the sudden appearance of a new substance, but like hell that she would bested by a fucking *hangover*. "No, I can do it, just give me like twenty to pull it together-..."

"Nah, kid. Rest up. This is standard; the high volt group has to run diagnostics to make sure everything runs smooth start to finish, from substation to home. It's outta our hands now and they're just anxious to get this to scheduling because of all the moving parts."

Catra didn't buy it for a second. No one ever *took* work from the designers, they only assigned more, made it so she was handling every last detail. But once Netossa had made up her mind, fat chance of changing it. What a fucking loser she was to stumble right before the finish line.

"Next, hold off on that new line job of yours for now. I need you to work on a string of streetlight replacements next week instead. Corporate's barking at us. Ill email you the details."

Streetlight jobs? What was Netossa *shitting* her right now? That was the first job type trainees did all on their own. Bullshit that corporate was

on her ass to get them done;obviously her boss didnt think she was cut out for the good stuff anymore. "I-I dont understand"…

"Not sure what' s to understand here. Swap the old sodium lights for LEDs. Repeat down the street and the next. Get it done quickly to make the suits happy." The tone was flat, though Catra was familiar enough to know her boss was trying for humor. *"Next week when you're better , of course."*

The magicat grunted, squeezing the empty water bottle in her hand, her claws digging into the far too flimsy plastic. Of course. It was such a rush that it needed to be reassigned to her but *naturally* it could wait until next week. Because that fucking made sense.

The voice at the other end paused. *"Last thing then Ill let you go about the rest of your day. It's good to see you using PTO for once, but let's try to keep it scheduled, yeah? You can still take your week off at the end of October as previously requested."*

A sucker punch from the sidelines. Catra should have known that this many call offs in a few short weeks wouldnt escape the eagle-eyed attention of her boss. She didnt take days of f, save for the week of her birthday. It was out of her norm and Netossa was paid the big bucks to make sure her team continued to be profitable to the company. Catra wasnt right now . She was useless, inefficient, unproductive."I dont really *need* that week off. It's fine."

"It' s already approved. Take it, Catra. Consider Monday off as approved if you need as well, but try to work some extra next week if you do. Dont want to see your numbers drop because of... a bug."

A bug. An irritating, disruptive blonde bug. Catra clamped her jaw shut to keep from screaming or even worse, crying.

" *Transfer those files as soon as you can and be well."* The other end disconnected, Catra left to stare at the wall of her bedroom.

Eventually she wandered out of her bedroom in a daze, making her way towards her office. Scorpia followed her, making sure to keep at a reasonable follow distance. Catra solidly ignored her presence. She logged on, every press of her fingers into the keyboard sharper than strictly necessary. Her body felt as though it had been flung from a 500' cliff- bruised, battered, and half-dead. But like Catra would be so lucky as to just fully give up the ghost. No, she had to *work* .

The bottle of water she'd choked down was uncomfortable as it churned in her stomach and did little to slake her relentless thirst. She set the files to transfer, gripping her mouse so hard she swore she heard a faint crack. She pulled up her email, confirming that yes, Netossa really did want her to take care of some baby designer jobs by replacing several streets worth of lights. Pathetic.

These fucking files always took forever to transfer, but she'd learned the hard way that sometimes a file replacement request would pop up, delaying the whole process if she wasn't right there to accept it. So Catra had to just wait it out until it was finished. She mindlessly scrolled through her inbox, sorting, archiving, and deleting. There was a whole string of *particularly irritating* emails that needed to be trashed. "*Catra"* the first few began, then several *"Hello, Catra,"* followed by far too many *"Hi Catra,"* .... delete, delete, delete. Be gone, get out of her life.

She stumbled in her purge on the last one, bookmarked on either end with *Glya, at* and the signature of *Adora Grayson, Grayskull Construction- Crew Leader & Co-Owner* . Her eye twitched as she read over the note again and again, sinking lower at every pass over each letter.

How pathetic to be mocked so viciously by mere words on a screen.

Even more so when it reduced her to a lifeless pile on the couch.

"I'm thinking of getting a burger for lunch. How's your tummy, Wildcat? Wanna try anything?" Scorpia went about her day as if her best friend wasn't curled up in the fetal position in her living room. She'd tried to engage when Catra emerged from her office in a numb procession, but was met with dead eyes and a forward stare, the corpse shuffling to lay herself in the gravesite on the couch.

"Yeah, double cheeseburger with a shake. That's a great meal for a Friday!" The large woman stretched her arms over her head with a yawn. "Maybe after a nap though, hoo, the ol' back isn't used to couch surfing much anymore. I'm just glad that you kept my toothbrush, even after all this time. You remember how annoying it was when I had Invisalign? Having to brush after every gosh darn meal. Suppose it paid off!" Her smile glistened in the afternoon sunlight.

Catra stared at her coffee table, unblinking.

"Little out of left field, but I've been brainstorming ideas for your birthday bash all morning. Can't believe we don't have anything down on the books yet! What kind of friend am I?" Scorpia shook her head at herself. "I was thinking that maybe we could have our Lord of the Rings marathon a little early this year? I think even with the time difference, Entrapta could join us via Zoom." Catra shifted slightly, the move would have been imperceptible to anyone not watching her with the laserfocus that Scorpia had been. "Yeah, you're right, we really should just wait until she's back for the holidays. It'll be so much better when we're all in person! Can't believe we're coming up on our tenth year of doing it. Maybe I'll make Lembas to celebrate! My honey would probably even be able to point me to where I could buy some banana leaves, make it look really authentic. Doesn't help the birthday sitch, but I'll think of something!"

Scorpia's chatter finally faltered in the wake of the continued nothingness from her auditory captive. The buff woman took a deep breath in, rubbing a hand on the back of her neck before nodding resolutely. She spoke softly, her hesitance clear from the tone. "Catra, can we talk?"

Silence.

"I know you're not going to be super happy to do this, but I promise you. I would never do anything to intentionally hurt you. But something happened. And I just really, really think you'd feel better if we talked it through."

No response, though her tail twitched, only the very tip giving a small shudder to show life. It was more movement than Catra had done since stumbling out of her office, who knows how long ago. Time was meaningless even on a good day and today was *not* a good day.

Her friend sighed, rising from the couch. "I'll make you some toast. Maybe after you eat..."

Scorpia returned with the small meal for Catra to force down, only to find that her charge had fallen asleep. Likely the best thing for her right now. She covered the magicat with a blanket, with a soft assurance that when Catra woke up they'd talk it all out. "I know you'll feel better after, Wildcat. Trust me, okay?"

Catra ended up sleeping right up until dinnertime. The unanticipated, extended nap brought on some serious brain fog, but after she'd gulped two glasses of water and sat with herself for a while, she found that she was at least processing with the wattage of a potato-powered light bulb. It was a start.

"Thanks." Her voice creaked, acknowledging her friend setting a plate with something to eat down in front of her. Catra hadn't risen from the couch in hours, but from the way Scorpia's eyes were shining with pride, one would think she had just run a marathon.

"You're most welcome! Once we see how that goes down, we can look into ordering something with a little more oomph to it. Never did get my burger this afternoon. Ah, well. If not tonight, then tomorrow."

Catra blinked, a little glassy-eyed. Tomorrow? "You don't have to stay again."

"Hm? Of course I do. Gotta make sure you're okay, Wildcat." Before Catra could mumble an "I'm fine, go home" Scorpia continued speaking. "And as much as I hate using this kind of tone," her voice was just as sweet and comforting as normal, "I know you're not gonna be okay until we chat. So now that you're up and hydrated, let's do this."

Ambushed after a nap. Surprisingly low for Scorpia.

The woman pursed her lips, looking for the best way to begin. "You know the lengths I'd go for you- you say the word and I'll storm the ramparts, guard the pass, anything to make you just as successful as can be! So I really don't *mind* that I came to pick you up last night. Honestly, I'm proud any time you let yourself be helped!"

Catra wished she was still comatose.

Scorpia's smile faded as she saw her friend sink lower into the couch again. But now that she had started, she wasn't going to stop. "It's just, I don't really understand what happened last night. And Adora seems really... concerned about you." She fiddled with her phone, flipping it between her fingers.

"She's not *concerned*." The magicat felt some heat enter her tone, the most life she'd shown all afternoon. She woodenly rose from her prone position, body protesting at the new position. "And Adora resurrected her? Funny since she did this to Catra in the first place.

"Could have fooled me. Gosh, with just the couple of texts she's sent me since last night. Guess the good news is that "concern for well-being" is a top trait for a girlfriend to have. If, yknow-..."

Catra's back teeth grinded together at that word, that truly disgusting word once again. She cut her friend off before the idiot could utter

any more slander against her. "I don't know how to say this any fucking clearer, Scorpia. She is *not* and never *will be* my girlfriend."

"Okay ." Scorpia flicked an eye towards her seething friend, the relief visible on her face when she saw that Catra was finally upright. She looked like she was attempting to remain quiet in the face of the succinct burst, but the feat was too much for her. "I was just gonna say, if that was something you wanted..."

"It' s not." Catra swallowed thickly , ignoring the swish of stomach acid that tried to ascend. Ugh, maybe Scorp was right about food. She grudgingly bit into the toast her friend had made for her. Jesus. Not even any fucking butter; inmates got better treatment.

"Ah. Soooo.. you were out with her as friends."

Catra seized at the word, eyes narrowing slightly . She was way too fucking hungover for this bullshit. Scorpia thought she was so clever, trying to trick her into revealing more than she would otherwise. Catra knew exactly what game was being played here, but also should have realized her friend held onto things with a vice grip. Maybe if she just relented a little, gave her a small something to explain why Scorpia had been summoned after midnight to pick her up from the bar, Catra'd get some fucking peace and quiet. The magicat shrugged. "She' s basically a stranger. Last night just sort of... happened." She squashed down the annoying voice that told her it happened because she *allowed* it to happen. Catra had no patience to hear that, least of all from herself.

Like a vague explanation would deter Scorpia. The short haired woman nodded, appearing to agree with what was being said. It sure as hell didn't stop her from asking, "Right, right. Just ran into one another at the Waste, maybe?"

Catra chewed on her dry crust of bread, not confirming a damn thing.

"She wasn't bothering you, was she?" Brown eyes narrowed suspiciously. "Doesn't seem like it... but know that Adora and I would have some *serious* issues if that was the case."

Catra nearly choked on her starchy styrofoam on that one. Guilt buzzed in her chest; no, if anyone was getting harassment charges from last night, it'd be her drunk ass. She threw the half-eaten meal back onto her plate, only resisting the urge to chuck it at the wall at the last second. How many fucking times did she throw herself at that other person? And how easy was it for them to rebuke her each time. But who wanted to take the sloppy drunk girl who spent the whole night prattling about *work* home? Maybe her pussy would have excused her for being an absolute bore (despite her vast interest in Catra's oral skills, her hookup wasn't in it for her ability to *converse*), but once she started acting like a drunk fool. No wonder Catra hadn't even gotten a pity fuck at the end of the night.

Even though her chest was aching from her embarrassment, Catra couldn't let Scorpia think that anything that untoward had happened. Her friend would never let her out of her sight again. "No, nothing like that." Catra's voice was tight; they were edging towards dangerous topics. She struggled to find a way to back away slowly. "Maybe she seemed a little... interested at first, but I was absolutely going to shut that shit down. Prissy bitch beat me to it, though." Perhaps if she said it enough times, the delusion would become reality.

Before her friend could reply, Catra licked her lips, left ear flicking twice in rapid succession. "Can you not... use her name?" She prayed that Scorpia wouldn't latch on to that one. She couldn't summon the vitriol to make it a cutting, edged request. Instead it just came out needy and weak. Just kill her now .

"Well, of course she'd be interested in you! You're Wildcat; a total catch!" Scorpia beamed, putting even the drunkest girl in the bathroom at the club to shame with her level of support and how easy the compliments flowed from her. The woman paused for a few moments, pouring over the information she'd received and trying to

play Sherlock. "So, you went out last night, met Ad- *ahem,* that someone, and things got a little flirty?"...

Catra shrugged. Scorpia didn't need to know exactly *how* flirty they'd been, nor did she really need a time frame. Technically nothing here was a lie, not that she was necessarily above saving her own fur by any means necessary, and it should be enough to satisfy her friend.

It wasn't. "You shared a drink or two, jumped right into that Portal together, but you both knew at the end of the night it was best if you went your separate ways. She called me, I come get you, badda-bing, badda-boom, here we are." "Sure, Scorp. "Wow, okay. That's not too bad! I'm still not sure if I understand why you chucked her jacket, but hey, who hasn't done weird stuff while drunk before?"

Catra breathed out, fiddling with the fringe of the stupid throw pillows that Scorpia had insisted she needed to make her place more "homey." She lived here. Wasn't that homey enough? But it also gave her fingers something to do while her brain teeter-tottered with how to proceed.

As much as it needled at her, Catra hated herself for whining about something so juvenile even privately. But it was all about the *way* the asshole had said it, as if it were the most putrid, reviling concept on the planet to be connected to her. She swallowed down the stupid dry toast Scorpia made her choke down as it tried to rise back in her stomach before mumbling out, "I was mad at her."...

Scorpia blinked, eyes wide. She padded forward lightly, not wanting to frighten her friend if Catra was finally ready to get at the meat of things. "Why were you mad at her?"

After a long, measured silence, Catra gave up. She just couldn't. She could feel her hackles rise, as her self-preservation instinct kicked in. "It doesn't fucking matter."

The short-haired woman frowned, still so cautious with every step she took. "Of course it matters, Catra. Every feeling's valid, but that

doesn't mean they're always rational. Or that we have to like them!" She quoted the sage wisdom that she'd probably picked up in some motivational YouTube video. "And that's okay. Feelings are there to tell us something's wrong, right?"

Feelings. *Ugh.* Catra proudly had three feelings- hungry, horny, and angry. She sure as fuck wasn't hungry or horny, so that only left the third option. "*They're* what the fuck's wrong here! She's a distraction. Wanna know what Netossa and I talked about earlier? She basically reassigned all my work. I'm stuck doing those dumbass streetlight jobs we *train* people on, Scorp. And it's all fucking Adora's fault!" She flinched at the name leaving her own mouth, claws pressing into the pillow she'd been clutching.

Scorpia was unperturbed in the light of her friend's temper tantrum. She spoke evenly, not even thrown off by the switch to discussing work. Despite her grumpiness towards it most days, Scorpia knew how seriously the magicat took her profession. She was one of their best- for good reason. "I'm sure Nettie has her reasons for the redistribution of work. And we really are in a crunch to get those streetlights swapped out. The engineer, Micah, is a delight but man is he particular! Your attention to detail on these things is superb, Wildcat. I think Netossa's just trying to put one of her strongest forward so we can get the job done on time."…

"It's punishment because I keep calling off. She more or less said so herself." Well, she had at least brought up the topic adjacent to the work redistribution discussion. Catra could read between the lines.

Scorpia's brow furrowed. "Uh, that doesn't really sound like her."…

"I'm letting my shit get in the way of work. That's fucking ridiculous and pathetic. I'm better than that. I don't *do* this!"

"Adjusting to a new relationship of any kind can be rough, Wildcat. I know that when Fuma and I first started."…

The magicat couldnt take it anymore. "There' s no new *relationship* ! It was sex, Scorpia. ust sex. Nothing more!" Catra finally exploded, close to shredding the throw pillow she'd been hugging against her chest. "Y ou wanna know what happened? Fine! She' s a fucking contractor. A too hot for her own goddamned good contractor that ate me out against a wall when I went to the job site. And *yes* , Scorp, I was on the clock. Real fucking romantic. Super ethical too."

Her friend frowned, but made no comment. That only infuriated Catra all the more; like she really needed any Im-holding-it-in-because-you're-my-friend judgment right now . The silence persuaded her to continue to illustrate just what a piece of shit she was. Maybe Scorpia would wise up and leave her to her own misery and self-destruction. "Then I went back to see her and she pounded me in her office. But hey! At least I called of f for that. Yup, a personal day to go get railed."

"What you do in your spare time with another consenting adult"…

"Shut it, Scorp. Dont you *dare* fucking placate me." Catra pointed a shaking finger at her friend, before shooting up from the couch. Tears were pricking at the corner of her eyes, she couldnt let anyone else see. "I nearly fucked her in an alley and sucked her of f in a car. Then I got smashed and made an ass out of myself and..and"… Her arms folded over her chest as she hugged herself close. Her chest was so tight, it hurt to breathe, and Catra sure as fuck hadnt meant to unload *any* of this. All this sludge belonged locked up tight in the vaults of her mind. It didnt matter . None of this mattered. "It was just sex. That' s all I am to her. All s-she is to me."

Scorpia sat with herself a minute, quietly absorbing. "She likes you, Catra."

"... Y eah. I know." The magicat' s tail lowered, dropping until it hit the ground. Her head was trained downwards, examining the scuf fed hardwood floors of her crummy apartment. She realized after her arms had been thrashing about wildly during her venomous monologue that she had a distinctive odor about her- probably

because Catra had been in the same clothes for well over twenty four hours. Her friend handled her snit with grace, but just looked tired. Drawn out of her bed on a weeknight to play babysitter for a barely functional adult.

Catra made her way out of the living room, though whether it was to shower or collapse back into her bed for the night, she had no idea. She'd figure it out along the way. Before retreating, she took one last look at Scorpia, a sickly half-smile on her face. "I just don't get why."

Catra awoke the next morning feeling superbly calm. It had taken a lot of convincing, more than a few empty threats, not to mention drinking a gallon of water and splitting half of a deep dish for Scorpia to finally leave, with a promise to check in first thing in the morning. The silence was deafening without her chattering presence, but all told, Catra was too tired to really care. The past day had been a lot, but now that her homeostasis was back to level, she found herself operational again.

She got up, made coffee, chewed on some bacon, and then went to work. Netossa may have given her absolute *bullshit* to do, but Catra was a professional, goddamn it. She'd have the jobs done before Sunday night. It bruised at first to be doing such mundane, effortless tasks but once she put on her favorite work playlist, Catra found it was actually nice to zone out for a while. Model the poles in the software, does it still need guyed to pass metrics, enter the units to requisition the parts that the crews would need (privately bitch to herself about why she should be the one to order parts if the idiots were just going to supercede her), lather, rinse, repeat until the streets were all done. Then draw it out;lay out the map so the crew could find the exact pole to work on, what direction was the source of power for all these poles just in case things went sideways and they needed to make a mad dash to cut the electrical flow.

Work, bop to music, work.and allow herself a few terse moments of reflection.

Catra had let herself get swept up yesterday. It was embarrassing, but not the end of the world. Recovering from a night of heavy drinking always fucked with her head, threw off her balance of brain chemicals the next day. Scorp would get it and honestly, it could have been *way* worse.

Whether.the other person would be so understanding, Catra simply didnt care. That individual had no bearing on her life whatsoever. Their opinion of her was entirely inconseqential. Once she finished with this print, shed toss them a qick, "yup, doing fine thx"in response to yesterday' s message and move on to the next task. She was a little surprised that was the only outstanding message from that particular individual, but maybe theyd drawn a similar conclusion. She didnt have time to think about that right now; Catra had work to do. At least permitting wouldnt be an issue since all streetlight poles existed in the road right of way. Plus, the counties *asked* for the work to be done. Everything was fine. Boring, but fine.

"Scorpia, I swear to god, you *need* to calm down."Catra exhaled as she drew out the map, finally getting around to contacting her best friend. Okay, maybe it hadnt been first thing in the morning, but the woman was getting an actual honest to goodness *phone call* . That had to count for something.

"All morning, W ildcat! Ive been texting you all morning!"

"Oh, qit the dramatics, Scorp, it' s not even noon. I told you, I was trying to get caught up from yesterday and was brain dead from the tedium of fixing lights."She scowled at her print, annoyed by the limited space shed have to draw out all the electrical lines. W orking at road intersections was the worst. "I made it through the night just fine. It's not like I was in any danger anyway."

"I know that, W ildcat. I just worry . You know Im a worrier ."

"Yeah. Yeah. I know. Listen," Catra looked out her office window. It was a view of their parking lot, but a few trees were scattered about. The splashes of red, yellow, and orange leaves were easier to focus on. "I'm sorry about Thursday and definitely for Friday. I fucked with your sleep, not to mention made you take a day off of work. Then yesterday's outburst. Just. Sorry."

"Nothing to be sorry about, Catra. You know I'm there for you always. And I'm so happy that you shared everything that you did." The magicat braced herself, waiting for her friend to start up the peer-to-peer therapy session again. She was calm now, but wasn't going to let that get too far. Catra said enough yesterday; it was out into the universe and now they could move on from it. *"Sometimes I really miss just having you down the hall, y'know? It was just so easy then to know everything that was going on with the both of us."*

"Yeah. I get it." She had lived with Scorpia for years, starting from freshman year of college and even after graduation into real life. She didn't begrudge her friend for wanting to experience living alone, but sometimes... "Miss it too. But now that you know that I'm alive, I gotta get back to work. Maybe call you later." She didn't wait for a response, not able to handle any touchy-feely reminiscences.

Catra was surprised to see that it was nearing 5 PM already. She rose from her desk and stretched, not sure if the queasy feeling in her stomach was from not eating or remnants of yesterday's brown bottle flu. She hadn't *meant* to skip lunch; it just sort of happened. After playing her music for so long, her phone definitely needed some juice, AirPods too. She plugged both in, wandering out to see what she could rustle up for dinner.

Adora (4:47 PM): Just thought I'd make sure you were still alive.

The text came in right as she was about to jump in the shower; she'd respond as soon as she was finished cleaning herself up for the night. Speaking of clean up, the apartment could really use a once over. Scorpia's woman was all about "flow" in rooms and as Catra had discovered while cooking dinner, her best friend had taken it upon herself to rearrange shit. It was extra irritating when Catra realized the new set up made far more sense than how she had it before. Goddamn it, Scorp.

By the time she ate, got showered, and into nightclothes (as opposed to her daytime attire which could be mistaken for pjs by the simpletons of the world), it was nearing 9:30. Catra had worked hard today, catching up from her day off yesterday, so an early light's out was called for. It was a little difficult to fall asleep given the weird combination of stale mint tea and puddle water from the jacket bagged up in the corner of her room, but the thought of getting out of her bed again was abhorrent. She'd take care of both of fending odors in the morning. Somehow.

Catra ended up not addressing any of her messes the following morning- the tea stain, the jacket, or the outstanding texts. She was able to email Netossa a request for more work by Sunday in the late afternoon, certain her boss would have more waiting for her by Monday morning. Maybe she could complete the whole backlog of streetlights by Thanksgiving, make her time in exile fruitful.

After working most of the day, she curled up with a dumb movie and big bowl of pasta, glad to see life was still moving on even in light of her many, many procrastinations. Catra would get to all it all.

Eventually.

"All right, Wildcat. Are you ready?" Scorpia's voice toned out from the other end of the line. *"Because I have got the best idea for your*

birthday!"

Catra sighed with a fair amount of affection. Scorpia made this proclamation every year, even though she knew that Catra only went along with shit like birthday parties solely to make her exuberant friend happy. She went back to chopping peppers for her dinner, careful to pay more mind to that task than the party planning. She'd made it to Wednesday night without calling off, certainly didn't need Netossa up her ass for missing more time at work for losing a finger. "Lay it on me, Scorp."

"Okay, so, I know you didn't attend the latest team building social event-..." The magicat rolled her eyes;maybe it wouldn't be seen, but she was certain her friend felt it over the phone, *"Yeah, I know how you feel about that. It really does foster better communication between the field and design staff. It's so much easier to talk to the people on the other side if you've palled around with them before."*

"So you've told us eighteen billion times."

"Because it's true! Anyway, so the last time the team got together it was at Top Golf!"

Catra waited for her friend to continue her prattle. The silence from the other end indicated that Scorpia was waiting on her too. "Okay, and?"

"That's it! Well go to Top Golf for your birthday. Ill rent a bay or two, maybe on the Tuesday before when it's half price. I hope you don't think I'm a cheapskate with that but it means we can play for longer and the crowds won't be as bad. I know you'll appreciate that one, Wildcat. The food is excellent, the drinks are cold, and it's just really a great, great time."

"Uhhh, it's almost the end of October. I don't think the drinks are the only ones that will be cold."She began dicing an onion, nose not even detecting the stench. Her olfactory nerve was used to unpleasant aromas, since she still hadn't gotten around to taking that

filthy jacket to the cleaners. She should just throw the damn thing away.

"The bays are half indoor and there's heaters and fireplaces. I really, really think you'd like it, Wildcat. Almost like our times at the driving range during college, blowing off steam once our finals were done. Or if one of us was having a really bad day!"

Her friend sounded so earnest, so proud of herself for coming up with this idea and tying it to dumb memories from their past that Catra found herself agreeing. She barely understood what one actually did at Top Golf, but it couldn't be that fucking complicated. Or maybe she wouldn't even need to participate. "Okay, whatever. Sounds fun, I guess."

"Weee! So, you won't regret this. Okay, okay. Man, I'm so stoked. Well invite everyone and just turn it into an afternoon to remember. I know some people won't be able to swing a Tuesday, but hah, we could be there so long that they might just swing by after work!"
Catra snorted at her friend's optimism. Like she really had that many people in her life to begin with. "*Speaking of, you want me to handle the guest list?"*

"Obviously. You do every year." Catra had met so many random people at her own birthday celebrations, Scorpia just searching for people to pad the numbers. It was a little exhausting and part of why Catra took her birthday week off every year, simply to recover. But it made Scorpia so happy. And could have its moments of being fun. "Invite anyone you want to, Scorp."

"Excellent, excellent! The more people we have, the cheaper it'll be."
The other line paused, then asked hesitantly. "*Anyone?"*

Catra chewed on her bottom lip, then breathed out steadily through her nose. "Um, yeah. *Anyone*."

Chapter End Notes

This chapter only happened by the grace of three things. The first being n7punk's A/N on chapter 3 of I Hear the Wind Call Your Name in which they remind that Catra is an unreliable narrator... Because yeah. Okay. I can work with that. I get it now.

The second being RaptorRed's patience, friendship, and angst expertise. Thank you for beta-ing, RR! And listening. And advising. I hate (writing) the angst train, but it's a lovelier ride when it's with a friend.

The third being my cotton Candy fic It's the Journey where I left them just be happy and sweet and in love. Every time I wanted to scream at Catra here, I channeled it into more sugary goodness there. (For anyone interested, it's next on my schedule to update/finish, just about all done, maybe weekend?)

The jacket is saved!... Maybe? We shall see. I know many, many of you were crushed at last chapter's ending.

Until next time at the Top Of, folks!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora gave up trying to comprehend what the voice assistant through her car speakers was reading out to her halfway through the rambling message. She was pretty sure that Scorpia was telling her that they would get to Catra's apartment later than anticipated which, um, great? Adora didn't even realize there had been a set ETA to begin with.

Nevertheless, after the voice feature had finished reading off the verbose text she replied with, "Thank you so much for the update. Really appreciate it." It didn't hurt to be gracious.

As she rumbled down the road, mindful of her speed (there was a zero percent chance that she'd fail a sobriety check, but also, why invite the headache?), she repeated to herself that she had done nothing wrong tonight. Catra was an adult who could make her own decisions. It wasn't up to Adora to monitor her, just the same as she wouldn't try to limit Glimmer or Bow if they wanted to knock back a few. It happened from time to time; Adora was no stranger to suddenly surpassing the tipping point. Maybe she could have encouraged a little more-...

No. None of that. No one had gotten hurt, no bodily fluids of any kind made an appearance tonight, and everyone was safe. It was fine. Completely fine.

As Adora was approaching her cul-de-sac, another message came through.

Scorpia (1:18 AM) Wildcat has successfully made it home she is in bed i couldnt get her to any drink water but thats okay i left three bottles on her nightstand as well as some Advil she'll be ok

Scorpia (2:22 AM) ill make sure to text u as soon as she wakes up and just let u know how shes feeling as she recovers dont worry shes in good hands 🙏

Adora did not respond. Of course she *wanted* the updates, but how would Catra feel about her receiving them? She had a feeling that wouldnt go over well, even if things were looking up between them. Maybe.

What *was* tonight? Originally, Adora was just playing by the rules that had been unofficially set for their whatever-this-was. She texted first, making it decently clear that it was another hook up opportunity. She gave Catra the space and time to respond, not wanting to overwhelm her, and most pleasantly the "well have a drink together first" part came at no fight from Catra. Amazingly it wasnt even a *question*. Maybe the drinks had gotten a little overboard, but… nothing dire had happened.

A fairly normal Thirsty Thursday, even if it hadnt ended up quite like Adora was picturing. Except there was also cuddling and hand holding and little smiles that were imprinted on Adora's field of vision whenever she shut her eyes. Catra had really let loose tonight, let Adora see her sillier side (it might have been fueled by the Portals, but the blonde was still calling it a win- drunk Catra was adorable, plain and simple). They'd talked, Catra had even volunteered a whole darn story about things at her work. It felt sort of like…

She'd been careful to avoid the subject of dates, between them or even very often to herself, ever since her faux pas during their first meet up outside of work. That had been embarrassing enough, not anything she was looking to repeat. She certainly didnt need another scathing reminder to never assume (because when you

assume, you make an "ass of u and me"). Adora was not unfamiliar with flings, but she supposed they all worked a little differently depending on who was involved. She was definitely still figuring out exactly how this one did. It could be a little tiring to play the guessing game of what would fly and what wouldn't, but all of that was a problem for future Adora (and maybe Catra, if she was lucky). For tonight, at least Catra was home, safe and sound, and under the supervision of a friend. Adora was mere minutes from her own home, more than ready to crawl into bed for a few hours.

As Adora parked her truck in her drive, she pressed her fingers into the bridge of her nose. She *knew* that Catra would be fine, Scorpia had been so attentive over the phone that Adora couldn't even imagine what the woman was like as a caretaker in person, but she couldn't not say anything. However, with the awful hangover Catra was sure to wake up with, have to *work* with, she certainly didn't want to add to the magicat's morning distress.

After a number of tries, typing and erasing and retyping, Adora finally settled on one single text.

Adora (2AM) Hope you made it home safe. Drink lots of water, Catra.

She knew she had made it home safely, but that was just the kind of thing that people said, right? Nothing there that the magicat could possibly take offense at; not overly friendly while not completely aloof. Until they had a chance to talk, maybe see if some things had shifted between them, it was a good middle ground. Hopefully Catra would respond in the morning and Adora could push her luck with a few follow ups to this simple message.

It could happen. After all, she doubted that Catra purred for just anyone.

Adora (10:12 AM) Good morning, I just wanted to see how you were feeling, as well as thank you again for coming to get Catra last night.

Adora (10:15 AM) And how is she doing? I could run out to the store and get her anything she might need- Gatorade, saltines, or lunch maybe?

Adora cursed herself out loud the minute she pressed send. It was amazing how quickly her earlier assertion of 'Catra might not like this' was forgotten. But if she could help make things better ... even if it was just with a bottle of sugary sports drink "medicine"...

Scorpia (10:17 AM) morning! im good but hooboy not used to sleep on couches anymore lol but all good wildcat and i havent had a sleepover in a long time shes not up yet but tysm for checking! no store needed dont think unless u wanna pick up my groceries LOL! nah kiddn ur so sweet & im sure she will txt u as soon as shes awake lol i have her phone right now so hope u havent been worried!

Adora sent back a thumbs up to the message and went about the rest of her morning as best she could. She'd just narrowly avoided an awkward as fuck situation there. *"Hey, Catra. I know where you live now because I've been texting with that friend of yours that picked you up last night from the bar and we decided you needed a grocery trek. Hope you like the blue Gatorade. Also here's a BLT and some fries, have a happy hangover!"* The path to disaster was paved with good intentions and even stupider suggestions.

Adora (6:47PM) Just thought I'd make sure you were still alive.

Not getting a response from Catra was nothing new;it's not as if they'd set up an easy back and forth rapport with regular communication. The magicat responded when and if she wanted. That still didn't stop Adora from trying again come Saturday night.

She would always *try.*

Adora (7:13PM) I don't know. I've never been golfing before.

Scorpia (7:21PM) lol it's so much fun really more like a driving range than actual golf there's all these targets ranging from 25 to 200 yds out each target has rings like a dartboard you get points depending on where it lands it's just all for fun!there will be drinks

and food and we have two bays for at least three hrs but can look into more time if we want i promise you it is so much fun!

Scorpia (7:42PM) it would mean so much to me and catra if you came

Almost a week to the day since she'd last heard a word from Catra, but yeah. Of course Adora's presence would mean *so much* to her.

"Mara Skullen speaking, infinitely better looking co-owner of Grayskull Construction. How may I help you on this fine Thursday evening?"

"Real cute, Mar."Adora drawled into the phone, rolling her eyes. She sincerely hoped that the gesture was felt through the line.

"Pretty much what I just said, Mar's real *cute. But as much as I love the free compliments, what can I do ya for, Dor?"*

Adora took a deep breath in. Her cousin wasn't a disagreeable sort by any means, but when Mara decided to strike out on her own as a contractor and invited the aimless barely 20-something looking for a job in her life to come work for her (who would think that punk would turn out to be good enough to eventually become her business partner, the pair even going so far as to rebrand the company to reflect the dual ownership) they had a clear agreement on how things would go. Mara had a family life with hope and especially right now, given her wife's condition, she couldn't be away for long stretches of time. Adora loved to travel and couldn't abide the thought of being chained to a desk day in and day out, so their arrangement normally worked well for the both of them. But special circumstances called for special favors, right? I know we both

agreed that I would do all the traveling needed for jobs and that you would handle like…everything else."

"Uh-huh." Mara's response was measured, though vaguely amused. *"That's exactly how it reads in our formal job descriptions. Adora, roving construction lesbian. Mara, everything else lesbian."*

Adora bit the inside of her cheek, ignoring her cousin's sass. "And I realize that Hope is"…

"… *Barely two months away from giving birth to our son?* Your *godson?"*

"Y up, yup. That's it." She could see the cocked dark eyebrow raised high on her cousin's face, Adora's cheeks turning faintly red. "That would be the case."

A few beats of silence as the blonde wrestled with herself. It wasn't a big deal, right? The job was only about 3 and a half hours away and she would still be here in town if anything happened. Sure the pregnancy hadn't been the smoothest at first, but Hope wasn't on bedrest any longer…

Adora's internal debate was cut short. *"Adora, I need you to spit out whatever it is that you need from me, all right? You know I love our chats, but I'm about to be wrist deep in raw chicken for* mojo criollo *tacos. I fear what my wife will do to me if I delay her dinner."*

"Probably put another spider or two on your pillow while you sleep." They were cheap plastic and obviously fake, but the fact the prank came from the naturally reserved Hope made it all the better. "All right, I'll cut to the chase. Any chance you can cover for me next week on that pole replacement job? I sort of…need to be closer to town on Tuesday." She worried at her lip for just a moment before steadying herself. Adora had never asked for something like this before and wouldn't do it again. Well. At least not *habitually*.

Silence, this time from Mara's end. *"The one on the other side of the state, nearly five hours away-..."*

"Three and a half." Adora offered weakly, cringing as she contradicted her fellow co-owner (and frankly, brains of the whole operation).

"I'm not a speed demon like you; I learned my lesson on that years ago. Tickets add up." The voice on the other end sighed, then grew crisp, almost business-like. *"This is the job slated to take at least 5 working days, assuming nothing goes wrong while on site?"*

"Yes"…

"And you're giving me a whole walloping… three days notice."

"Guess so." Wow. If she wasn't feeling like enough of a heel, that really put it into perspective.

"... Fine, but only because Hope's next appointment is the week after next." Adora heaved a sigh of relief, though whether it was from Mara agreeing to head up the job or that she hadn't been subjected to a super long guilt trip, she wasn't sure. *"But know that I'll be sending you to the middle of bumfuck nowhere for at* least *two weeks at the first opportunity. Your upcoming Tuesday escapades still worth that punishment?"*

Adora thought for a moment, before the hint of a smile rose to her lips. Who knew what was actually going to be worth it, but at the end of her life, she didn't want to be left wondering "What if". Also, like she wouldn't be headed to the boonies if a job called for it anyway. Nice try there, cuz. "I *think* so. All right, Mar, I agree to those terms and thank you, really. But keep in mind that Raz will kick your ass if I miss Thanksgiving or Christmas, so time my exile in the boonies well, please."

"...Ehh." She could see her cousin weighing her odds over the phone. *"I might be able to take her. Is she armed with the broom,*

though?"

"Obviously ."

"Showdown of the century over turkey and potatoes, then. Prime family entertainment." Mara chuckled, then started to wrap up the call. *"All right, hot shot, Ill be the roving construction lesbian next week, but seriously, youll be around if anything comes up with bbe?"*

The tinge of worry in the back of Mara's voice cracked the jovial comfort they'd just reestablished. Adora pushed her anxiety to the side, knowing that without question she'd be able to assure Mara that her wife wouldnt truly be alone for a week. "Of course! Im really only busy on that Tuesday, actually, maybe you could just cover that day for me- Ill drive out Sunday , work all of Monday, you come in Tuesday, and"…

Mara cut her off. *"I am not finagling hotel accommodations like that. Plus the crew deserves to have the* best *as their leader every once in a while. Itll be good to stretch;havent been on site for a few months. Show these young whippersnappers what's for."*

"You're not even eight years older than me, Mar ."Adora pointed out, rolling her eyes. Yes, Mara was very good, taught Adora everything she knew, but she wasnt exactly in the role of grizzled, "seen it all before" foreman. The job shouldnt even be difficult, it just happened to be further away than Adora needed it to be. Maybe bending over backwards to be free for Top Of, whatever the hell that was, would prove to be a mistake, but...

"Yeah, but almost old enough to be a MILF . Just in time too. Noice!"

"Woooooooow."Adora shook her head clear of that particular comment, decently scarred. "And on that note, Im done talking to you. Thank you again for switching, totally owe you, but seriously. Dont talk to me again before the holidays."

She pretended to not hear the chant of *"MIE , MIE , MIE"* as she hung up the phone.

Adora cautiously made her way towards the building, a little overwhelmed at the size of the parking lot. There was a main lot, consisting of at least four long double rows, and an even larger side lot for players and employees to park. Apparently TopGolf could draw a crowd. Fortunately 2 PM on a Tuesday at the tail end of October, not even half of the area directly outside the facility was speckled with cars.

The building itself was *huge* too. Three floors from what she could tell from the outside, wrapping around in a crescent moon shape. It was easy to see the flurry of activities happening inside given that the side facing her was glass for the most part. Adora saw people swinging their golf clubs, heard the steady *thwack!* as 9 irons and drivers sent dimpled balls sailing, but registered that it all seemed to only be taking place on floor one and two. She guessed that this low crowd didn't really call for the whole place to be set up. Adora really couldn't tell from her current vantage point what the golfers were all aiming for, but Scorpia had mentioned something about targets. She supposed she really didn't care either . Adora wasn't here for *that* game.

As she entered the lobby area, looking around wildly for some clue on what to do next, she got a better idea of the layout of the place. Each floor seemed to be sectioned off into smaller areas, likely the bays that Scorpia had mentioned in her explanation, so that groups could have some privacy from one another. It was just transparent dividers coming down from the ceiling, some of the ones at the ends also fitted with blinds, and each bay had a number hanging above it, almost like an airport or movie theater. Great. What the fuck number was this party happening in? Probably information the hosts should have relayed to the guests…

"How can I help you?" Adora almost didn't catch the exceedingly friendly voice over the Top 100 pop song that was blaring inside the lobby. A worker behind the counter waved her over. "Need a bay? It's half price right now!"

"Actually I'm supposed to be meeting some people. For a party ."

"Oh, excellent! And what name is the party under?"

"Uhhh." Adora faltered, not knowing if it was under Scorpia or the birthday girl. At least they both had really uncommon names, so even if she had no idea of a last name for one of them. "Could be Scorpia? Or maybe Catra W eaver?"

The worker checked her list for a moment, scanning far quicker than any person ought to be able to. "Perfect, perfect. Got you right here; bay 66 and 67! Up the stairs and to the right. There are 50 bays per floor, so you'll be fairly close to the end. I'm sure you'll see some of your friends once you get up there!"

Sure, if she had any up there. Scorpia was an acquaintance at best and Catra. W ell. That was a whole thing in and of itself, wasn't it? Adora nodded her thanks and made her way up the stairs, already sporting a delightful headache from the music. Beer. She needed a beer to make it through this.

On the second floor, Adora noted with some relief the large bar to her left, and glanced up to see what number she was nearest to. 76. As much as she wanted something to fortify her, she figured it would be rude to approach with a drink in hand. She made her way down the walkway, weaving around patrons and employees alike. It wasn't terribly busy, but people were here and having a good time. The crack of the clubs against the golfballs was already getting on her nerves. 70. 69...

"Adora! Oh, so good to see you, it has been *far* too long! My sweetie mentioned that you'd been invited, but I didn't want to pressure..."

"Perfuma?" Adora blinked, wildly confused as slender arms and the aroma of crushed petals enveloped her just as she approached bay 67. She hadn't even gotten a chance to see where Catra was yet, the whole reason for her rearranging her work schedule to be here. She awkwardly patted her friend's back as the other woman held on just past what felt normal. "What are you doing here?"

"Hey, hey! It's Adora. Glad you found us okay. Welcome to Top Off!" Scorpia bounded over, linking her arm around Perfuma's waist and beaming. "We got drinks a-plenty, just a random assortment of beer buckets, or hit up the bar on your own dime. In a bit, I was thinking we'll order a few appetizers. The food here is *seriously* amazing!"

"The harvest hummus is rather delectable, I have to agree. Carrots and chickpeas, who'd of thought?"

"All about the mac'n'cheese bites for me, definitely gonna get at least one order of those"…

"How do you two know each other?" Adora had to cut in, certain that the two would continue to rattle off their opinions on every menu item if she let them. Her eyes flicked back and forth between the cuddled pair, already knowing the answer before she asked, but still needing to hear the greater explanation of what exactly the fuck was going on here.

Perfuma cocked her head, eyebrows coming together in a delicate point. "Adora? Scorpia's my girlfriend. I've *definitely* mentioned her before."

Her friend's mouth formed a thin line, obviously holding back her disapproval and hurt at Adora not knowing such a pivotal fact of her life. Adora had no patience for it. "Never by name! It's always been my honeybear, my sweetie pea, baby, sugar, dewdrop, dearest, angel...my sweet baboo!" The blonde butch exclaimed, racking her brain and coming up blank. Sure, she was *more than* aware that Perfuma had a girlfriend; the besotted blonde regularly going on about celebrating the oddest anniversaries at the most ridiculous

frequencies (was it really necessary to celebrate eating mochi together for the first time each month, even if Scorpia had never heard of the frozen treat three months prior?). But also her friend liked to date. Adora gave up trying to memorize the particulars of the string of men and women Perfuma took a liking to before this latest one that stuck, largely ignoring the subject when it had come up in the group chat over the years. "Scorpia. Scorpia is who you've been dating?!"

"For almost a year now ." The buff woman beamed at their timeline, pulling Perfuma in tighter. "I tell you what, I was pretty shocked myself! Totally floored when I mentioned your name to Fuma and she said you two went back *years* . What a small, queer world it is, eh, Adora? We both kinda gaffed at the bar the other night."

"... Yeah. Yeah. Guess so." Adora didn't know whether to be annoyed or relieved that she would know another guest at this party. Why hadn't Perfuma dropped her a text? Sure they weren't ride or die, closer to a friend of a friend if she were being honest. But it still felt incredibly odd. Or given her penchant for long, informational texts, why hadn't Scorpia gushed to her about their mutual? Just fucking weird. Something about the whole thing set Adora's teeth on edge.

"Well all have plenty of time to catch up and get to know one another better this afternoon, but," Scorpia winked, stepping to the side to allow Adora into the bay. "I know you're not here for *our* company."

Perfuma giggled, following her girlfriend's lead by stepping back as well. "Together two birthdays in a row, very interesting, no?"

Before Adora had the chance to follow up on whatever the hell *that* meant, the pair ushered her into bay 66. It had an L shaped couch and a coffee table some distance away from the area with the putting tee. A few people were milling about, chatting, but Adora paid them no mind. Almost as if she had been just waiting for the blonde to show up, Catra was poised on the couch, languidly sipping at a dark

drink through a straw, though her attention was focused on the target-specked green below them. She hadn't turned her head even for a second in Adora's direction, but nevertheless, the blonde in this instant knew exactly why she'd gone to all the lengths she had to be here. Her annoyance slipped away steadily as she stood awkwardly in the middle of the bay, transfixed.

"Why don't you go sit down, Adora?" Scorpia said gently, giving her a slight nudge. The blonde flinched at the contact, but nodded. She sat down woodenly, some distance away from the only other person on the couch.

Adora didn't *do* this. She didn't falter in front of a pretty woman, she dove in, smile blazing, and charm cranked to 11. She knew what she had to offer and wasn't afraid to show it. But their whole thing had just been so... And they were just so...

"Hello, Adora." The person of honor turned her head slightly, barely nodding in her head in greeting before returning to steadily watch whomever was at the tee.

"Catra." Adora breathed out, stomach jolting. At least she'd gotten some acknowledgement. She did not take that one for granted.

"Thanks for coming." Catra blinked once, slowly, her attention still focused on the game. Her voice was clipped and scratchy, as if she were forcing herself to speak after years of vowed silence. "Go get a beer or something. Have a good time." It was clear from how the woman positioned herself after that she was done speaking for the time being.

Adora hesitated, a little unwilling to leave quite yet even if it would be just for a moment. Still, affecting some amount of chill by trying to get into the party spirit would likely behoove her in the long run. Catra had told her to grab a beer so…

She knew she had yet to really scratch the surface of everything the feline woman intrinsically was, but this was still so perplexing. After a

pretty fun night out together, they hadnt interacted in nearly two weeks and it seemed like Catra could barely stand to look at her today. And yet, she couldnt help but notice the way the woman' s tail was fluttering behind her, peacefully, not held rigid. Her body was facing away, but as Adora rose from the couch, her entire ear swiveled back to follow the sound. Huh.

After shed armed herself with a beverage, she returned to the couch, sipping far quicker than she normally would just to give herself something to do. Catra had disappeared somewhere in the two seconds shed been gone. Disappointing, but she did have other party guests to mingle with. Adora couldnt demand all her attention, even if she was craving just a sliver of it.

Adora wasnt in the mood for Perfuma or Scorpia (or as shed just discovered was worse, the both of them together). The music was too loud, the crack of the clubs was just plain obnoxious, and despite being almost winter, the heater was turned up too high for her comfort. Shed had to start wearing a much heavier jacket these past weeks, given that Catra hadnt quite yet returned that one shed lent to her. Some part of her hoped that the magicat would have it for her today, but…

"Dont you look gloomy ."A cheery voice tried to pierce the rain cloud that was hanging over Adora's head. "T ee's free. Wanna smack the shit out of some golf balls?Might make you feel better ."

The blonde honed in on the source of the voice, noticing an exceedingly cute curly-haired woman with a sunny smile standing near where the golf clubs were housed. A bright red headband just barely managed to hold back a cascade of golden ringlets and a long, cream colored sweater with a red and white owl over black leggings completed her look. Adora slugged back more of her PBR Tallboy and barely flicked her attention towards the open tee. "Uhhh.I .dunno."

"Have you played before?It' s stupid fun, and you look like you could hit the back netting with those arms."The woman rocked back on

her heels, eyelashes just sort of fluttering. Before Adora could register anything about that, her new friend nodded her head towards the clubs. "C'mon. Just give it a shot!"

The driver was awkward in her hands. She didn't know which side to choose from- was it truly necessary to gender *golf clubs*? At least if there had to be a men's and women's side, the women's wasn't named like... Flower Power or something. The Big Dog worked fine for her. Starla, as Adora learned the woman's name was, gave her a brief overview. "Just wave the club over the sensor down there and it'll spit out a ball. Give it a smack and try to aim for the targets!" She gestured out towards the colored rings. "Land it in the nets out there and you'll get points."

After placing the ball on the tee (really the flexible PVC pipe just sticking out of a hole in the ground), Adora squared up. Bringing her arms back, elbow cocked out at an awkward angle, she drove the club down in an arc... and completely missed the ball.

Amazingly, no one laughed at her whiff, though that did not stop the red flush from piling over her cheeks. Starla called out to try again and grudgingly Adora lined up once more. She channeled all those times in her past spent at mini golf, this time bending her knees slightly and sticking her butt out (god, that felt weird; nope, nope don't like that much) and gave a much less wild swing, making certain to not position her elbow in that weird way again. She at least made contact, even if it barely made it past the first red ring. Shrugging, she turned to go back to the couch, at least earning herself a participation ribbon for the day. Woo. Top Golf.

"Aww, nah, get back over there! You usually hit three to five balls at a time, then move on to the next person. Actually, don't know what was I thinking; you need a profile." Starla wandered over to the computer, waving for Adora to join her. She tapped at the screen, following Adora's prompts for the correct spelling of Grayson. "All right, Adora Grayson with an A not an E, what's your phone number?" The woman's smile was particularly stunning in the afternoon sun.

Adora rattled it off to her, the goblin in the back of her queer brain quietly chanting for her to say that the woman could also memorize it for later. It was a total reflex that Adora had no problem swallowing down. She didn't *have* to ignore it, but she still did.

"All right, all set up! Not to step on any toes, but maybe try bending a little less? Actually, you'd probably be better off with a longer club overall." Starla plucked out The Lumber, the driver from the "men's" side, and handed it over to the blonde.

It felt heavier and definitely was longer. Adora found her hands fit it around it better. Okay, so this was an improvement, but really, how was one supposed to stand? Starla said to stop bending so much but. "Uh, how should I stand? Never been golfing before."

"Really now? Could have fooled me." One amber eye winked before coming to stand by her with her own club in hand. "A lot like you were before, just loosen up a little. This *is* supposed to be fun, ya know." Starla demonstrated the best way to grip the club, and did her best to explain where to center one's weight in the swing, lightly positioning Adora's arm so it would stop sticking out so much. Her fingertips were soft, but there was no buzz. Not like with...

A cool voice cut her explanation short. "Pretty sure the first rule of this idiotic game is not to have more than one golfer behind the red line at one time. At least if the eight times the server repeated herself is any clue."

Adora's smile fell when she saw Catra, eyes narrowed, observing them from behind the couch. Her tail was lashing slowly behind her, a snake ready to strike at any moment. Adora felt incredibly guilty for a flash, almost as if she'd been caught at something, which quickly tumbled into the thought of how unfair that impulse was. She didn't know what she was doing here so if someone wanted to actually give her a clue...

Starla, to her credit, merely laughed, taking care to step behind the red line that marked the safety zone for swings. "Right you are! And

rules are meant to be followed, now aren't they?"

The magicat scoffed, fingers gripping her glass more snugly for just a moment before relaxing. "Whatever."

"Happy birthday, as well! We really need to get together more than once a year. Can't believe I haven't seen you since the bar last year."

"Yeah, sure." Catra replied, only just managing to not roll her eyes.

"Oooh, are we talking about last year's party? Man, what a trip that was!" Scorpia trotted over, slinging an arm around her scowling friend, with Perfuma just a step behind. "Remember the shotski?" The tall woman mimicked holding something long in her arms, tipping it back towards her face. "I should make one of those"…

Adora tentatively removed herself for the putting area, drawn in by the reminiscing that was happening around her. Despite her chilly demeanor before, Catra seemed to be thawing. Adora swore she even saw the hint of a smile at the memories that were being bandied about. The blonde still hung around the edges, not wanting to completely intrude on a conversation that had nothing to do with her. But if the subject changed from Catra's previous parties and she was able to engage with the woman some...

"Dumbass, we don't need a shotski at our age. We just pitched that stupid door we used as a beer pong table from your garage last summer. And you wanna fill it up again with more useless crap?"

The large woman hung her head, smiling sadly. "So many memories with that table. Hollow doors really have the *best* bounce."

"Get that shit printed on a motivational poster for your home office, because that's the closest you're getting any more." Catra joked, taking a long pull from her drink. She seemed to be looking at any direction other than Adora's way, not the least bit surprising, but the closer Adora sidled into the little circle that was forming, the more

obvious it became. The magicat glanced down at her drink for a moment and then mumbled, "W as a cool party though, gotta admit."

"What did you think of it, Adora?" Perfuma turned to her quiet friend, obviously trying to pull her into the conversation. She gave an encouraging smile as Adora furrowed her brow, mouth opening and closing like a fish. What?

"Oh, is that how you and Catra know each other?" Starla cut in, snapping her fingers as if she'd just solved a great mystery . "Another "W e should totally hang out again!" friend and then boom, a year 's gone by"?

Adora ignored the question from her amateur T opGf instructor , eyes drilling into Perfuma as her mind attempted to reconcile the question. This was the *second* time a comment indicating that she and Catra had been at the same gathering last year had been made this afternoon. She wasn't going to let this one slip by , but she started slowly to let herself adjust to what could be a shock of information. "I'm not sure what you mean."

"The party last year at The Grotto? I invited you, Bow , and Glimmer ." The willowy blonde answered, trailing off when she saw how Adora's face had shifted. "Only you were able to join us"…

Catra's ear flicked several times in rapid succession, but she was doing a much better job at keeping her face blank than Adora was. The blonde's face was cycling between degrees of confusion, trying to recall details from 12 months ago. Yes, Perfuma had invited her out last year. But to a *Halloween* party. A decidedly lame one at that, since almost no one had been in costume. Adora's might have been pretty sucky, but-...

Oh.

No.

"Heeeey, who's ready to order some food? Hey, you wanna look over the menu with me? Star?" Scorpia did her best to pull the others away from the stockstill magicat and tall butch who's eye wouldn't stop twitching. "Y up, yup, let's just go over here and yeah"…

The three fled from the all around weird vibes that had infiltrated the bay.

It didn't matter, really. It wasn't much more than a weird, gay coincidence, but that certainly didn't stop Adora from asking, "What are the fucking odds? That we'd yknow, know some of the same people?" Scorpia had been spot on with her "It's a Queer World Afterall" comment earlier.

Catra gave a non-committal huff, crossing her arms over her chest. She'd been doing okay there for a minute, even in spite of all that fucking *flirting*, but Jesus Christ, Scorpia, way to fucking bail on her. So much for all the, "Got your back, Wildcat! I'm here to make sure you have a *good* time, no matter what!" that had been the main topic of conversation on the commute to this fucking party. No matter how much Catra growled during the car ride, the woman just kept *talking* at her. Okay, maybe in *some* ways she'd invited this awkwardness on herself, but like, leave her the fuck alone about it. She'd handle everything on her own damn timetable and sure as hell didn't need any pep talks along the way.

Wasn't it enough that Catra actually allowed the dummy to be here? Maybe, sort of, just a little. Encouraged it? Hinted, really, if that. Catra wasn't *desperate.*

Adora was a little put off by the cold shoulder she was getting, but since the magicat hadn't fled yet, she figured it was safe. The blonde rubbed at her arm a little, now regretting shedding her coat earlier, the heater not quite doing much against the strong autumn gust that had just blown in. She saw Catra shiver and casually stepped forward, now just happening to block the worst of the breeze from entering. Catra made no comment of her new position, head trained to the ground, tail wrapped around her waist. Adora ached to move

even closer in, but instead softly asked, "Maybe we could go somewhere and talk?"

"No." The magicat replied simply, drawn out of her trance by the question. Nuh-uh. Not happening. This wasn't the time for any of that kind of nonsense. They were in the middle of her fucking *birthday party* for fuck's sake. Something in Adora's eye told Catra that that blonde wanted to Talk and Jesus Christ, spare her from that, especially at the goddamned Top Golf.

She wouldn't, couldn't deal with this right now. Catra had thought that maybe she would be able to handle Adora being here, since they'd be in a group setting together so there was less pressure… She had told Scorpia to invite anyone, knew her friend would be able to read in between the lines. But part of her also wished Scorpia was actually dense and hadn't been able to connect the dots. Because now that Adora *was* here and they had the chance to be doing something normal together, something that had no chance of leading to a sweaty, bend her over and take her hookup, well…

Thank god they were at a driving range, even if it was a hokey facsimile of one, because Catra needed to hit something. Hard. She pushed her way past some awkward, uncertain-looking guests and grabbed a hybrid from the club selection. Catra did not give a flying fuck who's profile she was hitting the balls under, she just needed to send something flying.

How many other times had she and the dummy almost run into one another? Goddamn, the universe was the laziest piece of shit out there with this particular "plot twist."

Mutual friends! A chance meeting that could have happened *months* before! If only the stars had aligned a little differently on that night... her birthday! Ugh. *Gross*. Just let her choke to death from her own vomit on that one. Maybe she was overreacting to this rather nonconsequential happenstance, but it was Catra's party and she could rage if she wanted to.

But here was the sickest part of the whole damn thing. The idea *excited* her. This thought that maybe they had some greater connection to one another or deeper history than, " *So, we doing this?* "Maybe they had danced together before at some bar , unknowingly, even if in the queasiest part of her heart Catra would *never* forget if it was Adora holding her close on the dance floor, under the strobing lights, their bodies moving together to the pulses of the music, the blonde's strong arms enveloping her, guiding her as Catra grinded her hips back, Adora smiling devilishly at the barely concealed suggestion in her partner's motions.Where was she? Oh, right. Cosmic laziness.

Or if either of their moronic mutuals had been just a little less *all over one another* this time last year, taken the two seconds to do a quick introduction, maybe they'd be on the other side of this ridiculous limbo they found themselves in.

Sure. *Found* themselves in.

Catra drowned out the rest of her thoughts with a chain of resounding cracks, not even checking to see where the ball landed before calling another one down. Fun. She was here to have fun. Swing, *Twack!* Swing, *Twack!* Swing, *Twack!*

How irritating when she reached the twentieth and last ball of this account and had to stomp over to the computer to change it. Worse when Adora was there too, leaning against the machine, looking tired.

"Why am I here, Catra?" Adora's face was a practiced mask of neutrality as she posed the question to the person of honor for the day, but her eyes betrayed her. Catra had to look away. Those eyes.Damn those eyes.

The magicat chewed on her lip for a moment, flinching at the simple, but entirely valid question. There was no easy answer or maybe it was the ease that made it so impossible to answer. Instead of the

truth, she relied on an old favorite. "How the fuck am I supposed to know?"

Adora closed her eyes, breathing steadily, her nostrils flaring with every exhale. Catra paled at the sight. Why was she like this?

The magicat turned to leave, certain that this time she'd need more than just ten minutes to tame the panic attack that was clawing at her chest. Catra had slipped away almost as soon as Adora had arrived at the party, seconds after she managed to speak with the woman. She had just needed a moment to her fucking self. The third floor was at least a little quieter, even if nowhere in this goddamned place could one escape the awful music. It had been long enough for Catra to get a hold of herself, formulate a half plan of talking to the blonde at least once more before their time here was up. She had wanted Adora here, but that didn't mean she had any fucking clue of what came after that!

Then when she did get back from her little meltdown and the first thing she was greeted with was the sight of Starla sniffing around, with her easy smile, her playfulness, inherent *kindness*. Everything that Catra would never be, never *wanted* to be, even if that was what Adora deserved to have in her life…

She could have easily chucked the curly-haired sunshine woman to at least the green ring. What a satisfying six points that would have been. But who was Catra to interfere? Starla was nice. Catra was not. She just needed to fuck off, let things align for the the two of them. What a much better start to things. "*Yeah, we met at a party years back … Nah, don't remember who's it was!*"

The sight of the brunette turning on her heel to leave sparked something alive within Adora. She had no memory of telling her legs to move, but suddenly had positioned herself in front of Catra, barring her way. "No. Not good enough." Adora knew they were causing quite the spectacle at what was supposed to be a good time, but she was beyond the point of caring. Catra did not get to invite her here, almost completely ignore her, snipe at her relentlessly and

then not even have the decency to admit that she *wanted* Adora to be here. She did not just get to leave.

Catra's eyes widened at the broad chest suddenly blocking her escape route, tail whipping wildly behind her, but Adora did not back down or give her the chance for another acidic comment. She was done with that bullshit for now and made that clear with her tone. "Upstairs. Five minutes." Empty floor, plenty of space to talk. And they *would* finally talk.

"Or what?" The magicat spat out as a reflex. Like hell she was going to let herself be intimidated by *anyone.* She saw Scorpia out of the corner of her vision, but one tiny, blistering flick of her eyes in her friend's direction convinced her to stay right where she was. Catra could fight her own battles, thank you very much. She was also trying to save this dummy from herself, even if her heart leapt at the fact *Adora didnt let her go.* It would have been so easy...

Adora's mouth formed a thin line, a makeshift dam holding back any number of replies. She let her actions demonstrate exactly what would happen if Catra didnt follow her directions.

She left.

Chapter End Notes

> You know, for claiming to have only three feelings last chapter, Catra suuuuuure has a lot of them.
>
> Three chapters with no smut, things not immediately mended between Catradora... are we sure Amitola12 wrote this? (Though I'm expecting more than a few YES ADORA, YOU TELL HER on this one.)
>
> Oh! Some amazing fanart by candycornsnake1 was added to chapter one (at the end). Y'all should go peek, it's a very fun picture. You can find the artist's other fantastic work on Twitter @candycornsnake1

Until next time!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra stood in the middle of the bay, just daring *anyone* to look her way. At three minutes, forty seven seconds, she stomped out of the lounge area, and out of her own party. Maybe their conversation hadnt been *loud* , but despite Scorpia's best distraction efforts, the tension was pretty fucking obvious to anyone within a 12 foot radius. People had been watching-not watching the entire time, but fuck it. She had bigger things to worry about. Adora's expression had been so... resolute. God, she was such an idiot. Why couldnt she just…

"Catra?" She had no idea which onlooker said her name, but it didnt change her answer in the slightest.

"Dont." She stormed past her friends, unable to deal with the pity that existed in their eyes. It was a blanket command that covered everything- dont speak, dont ask, dont look, dont help. Just *dont.*

"... Good luck." Scorpia said softly , the corner of her mouth twinging. Her brown eyes followed her friend's departure from the bays, Perfuma giving her hand a little squeeze. She smiled at her girlfriend, the arc small and uncertain, but drawing in the strength needed to keep things on track. Catra would figure this out- eventually. Scorpia had faith in her friend, even when Catra didnt. She clapped her hands together and nodded. "All right, folks! How many orders of mac'n'cheese bites? I'm thinking at least two other kinds of food, so gather 'round and let's figure this out!" The party would go on, while the guest of honor did what she needed to.

Climbing the stairs two at a time with a chorus of *please be up here, please be up here* echoing through her mind, Catra reached the third floor a scarce twenty seconds later. It was quieter up here, but still the general ambient noises from the floors below carried. She

swallowed as she pressed the glass doors leading to the bays open, tail twitching behind her. She looked left, she looked right, heart seizing and stomach flopping wildly as a glint of blonde down the line of empty bays came into view. Catra marched on silent feet towards. Fuck all if she knew what she was walking into.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora was seated on one of the couches, head in her hands, her eyes trained to the ground. She did not acknowledge Catra's greeting or presence, not even when Catra settled herself on the couch opposite her.

As they sat there, not speaking, a weariness crept into Catra's entire being. What was she doing? Seeing Adora leave. Well. Maybe she didn't know how to process having the blonde stay, but Adora leaving shook her. These fears battled each other out in her mind and Catra was surprised at the victor. But perhaps not so surprised. She had come up here, after all.

She cleared her throat and directed her voice out towards the back netting of the greens. "I know why you're here. At my party." The words were a quiet creep, tentative strings that could be swept away with the smallest breeze. But they'd been said aloud. That was something, however, there was another matter that needed to be addressed. It was dumb, but Catra was curious. Also if things went south at any point going forward, at least her curiosity would be sated. It was a far less dangerous topic while she worked up to… other things. "What I don't know is why you were there last year too."

Adora continued to stare at the play area, eyes following the balls sailing towards the targets. She wasn't mad anymore. Tired? Sure. Frustrated? Yeah, maybe. But she tended to burn hot for a flash and then it usually tapered off. Adora wasn't quite ready to let the magicat off the hook entirely, but she found her anger had coiled into a tight ball in the center of her chest, one that she was sure she

could flick away- later. For now, it could stay. It might even be encouraged to bloom again depending on how this went.

She clamped her jaw for a half-second at that thought, then with eyes still trained on the various games of the merry folk below, Adora spoke. "Didn't know I was; that much is obvious. Perfuma invited me, and our other friends, to some party this new girl she'd been seeing was throwing. A costume party for Halloween, or at least I figured." She smiled, though there was scant humor to it. "I didn't know I'd be going until two days before. I'd been down with a cold for the past week, so figured I was out for any holiday celebrations that year." Catra remained quiet, her face placid, even though with every word she spoke, Adora stirred into life a little more. "Dunno why I decided I wanted to go, just one of those "Why the hell not?" decisions people make. Even weirder since the only person I'd know there would be Perfuma. Maybe just... didn't wanna be alone right then."

Catra's tail flicked at the admittance, even if she couldn't look Adora's way. The things people do to stave off loneliness. Y... eah.

"It was a pretty big shindig, and I mostly just stuck to the edges, kinda more my deal at those things. Course wasn't helping much since I stuck out like a sore thumb. By the time I had hit T... arget to find something to dress up as," The tips of Adora's ears were starting to burn. G... od, maybe it was the lingering ef... fects of being sick, but why she ever thought it was *that* important to wear a damn costume in the first place. "... My choices were pretty slim."

Frilly princess was a hell no, the nun was slightly better (a robe wasn't *really* a dress, but it was just close enough to make Adora's skin crawl), and everything else was made for someone a third of her si... ze. Maybe she could have cobbled something else up at home, but Adora had just figured that she'd blend in with the rest of the dressed-up idiots. G... et enough beer in her and she could laugh at herself all night long. Plus, if she could sweet-talk a cutie while dressed up in that, well, would anyone ever be able to doubt Adora's apeel?

A sick feeling began to creep into Catra's stomach as she scanned her memory. The few people who either didn't get the memo or blatantly ignored Catra's "I fucking hate Halloween so don't *dare* dress up while at my party" stuck out in her mind. Even if they weren't attendees of her party, just happened to be there at the Grotto that night. Maybe she didn't know them, but Catra didn't *forget*.

Look, her birthday wasn't actually on the dumb holiday, so the fuckers could just wait the three days and then be whatever idiotic thing they wanted. Let Catra just have her night, not that she really cared all that much. Her crusade against The High Holy Day Holiday was a stupid hold-over from childhood. The few friends she had always were more interested in Trick-or-Treating than celebrating with her; the times they lined up as being on the same night, everyone was just in a rush to get out the door. Sure it was cool to get candy, but everyone else got to really celebrate and be the main focus on their birthdays. Maybe it was pathetic, but resentment grew over the years. Plus it was just dumb. Why waste time and money on a costume for a single night? She felt the sigh rise up from the marrow of her bones as she realized Adora was exactly the type of person that would. Sick curiosity got the better of her. "Please tell me you were either the Exotic or Wonder Woman." The words came out as a haunted whisper. Please. *Please*.

"Nope." Adora popped the p, as in potassium, her ill-advised disguise for the night.

Of course. Of-fucking-course. Damn you, Adora Grayson. "So. I've been screwing the banana girl." Catra said the words flatly. Her life really was a cruel mockery.

She hadn't gotten a good look at the idiot lounging against the bar, in the obnoxiously yellow costume. Scorpia had managed to pull herself away from Perfuma long enough to assess the situation once she saw how Catra was seething. To come dressed up was bad enough, but it felt like blatant disrespect that this person would come in such a big, dopey costume.

Scorpia had shouldered up next to her, eyes hard, smacking her fist in the palm of her hand and promising that with just a single word she'd bounce this joker out of the bar *so fast* ...

Fortunately at that point the offender downed the last of their beer and chose to split, so no violence had to occur that evening. Catra gave the retreating form a hard glare before waving it off, content to continue about her night, free of any weirdly shaped berries.

Adora's expression was just as neutral as she confirmed Catra' s worst suspicions. "Y up. That's me. Fruity and delicious."Neither one cracked a smile at the poor attempt at levity.

The pair sat without talking for a few moments longer, mulling over this moment of their lives. Maybe if Adora had hit up a second store, tried for a sexier costume (something with sunglasses that just screamed "badass") she might not have felt so out of place amongst the crowd. Then instead of hugging the bar, trying to be inconspicuous as she gulped down a beer that simply wasnt Strong Enough, maybe she would have locked eyes with a certain magicat woman that night. Adora frowned as she slumped against the back of that couch. Then that night could just be a funny story of their past rather than part of the catalyst of whatever it was that happened downstairs. It still could have been if Catra had just been a *little* willing to talk. She didnt think any good would come of passing the blame entirely, so she at least wanted to own up to her share. "I know...my timing downstairs wasnt great. I know this was supposed to be a party, and that we're supposed to be having fun. But all I wanted was a couple minutes to laugh about the stupid coincidence last year. And instead we"…

Catra's ears were flat, mouth in a thin line. Guess their little detour was at an end. She *could* probably deflect more, but Adora might notice and the end results of that were bound to be less than forgiving. Catra had made a decision by coming up here and it was time to see it through. She stared at her hands, twisting them in her lap, struggling to approach the topic she wanted nothing more than to flee from. "It..didnt seem that way . Sort of seemed like you

wanted to talk about,” She swallowed, the sound getting stuck in the back of her throat before she was just barely able to squeak out one last syllable. “... us.”

Adora wavered for a moment, then shrugged. No sense in denying it; she wasn't a great actor. “Eh, yeah okay. I can see that. And maybe I did...”

The silence returned, or at least as silent as this dumb place could get, encompassing them both. Adora continued to watch the game, running over everything in her mind. Yeah, that was the truth of it. She had wanted to talk to Catra about them, or the possibility of there ever being a them, somewhere way down the line. She wasn't trying to rush things entirely, but it just made sense to her. They were *obviously* attracted to one another, usually had a great time talking and joking, at least the few times they'd gotten a chance to outside the very fun activities that showed just how attracted to one another they truly were. And now it was revealed that they even had friends in common! It seemed right to Adora to at least explore. Maybe some part of her subconscious brain *had* registered the magicat woman a year ago, which is why when Catra showed up at her trailer in a tizzy all those weeks ago. Could be the explanation of why she had put the moves on as quickly as she did. It was as good an answer as any, at least.

She regarded Catra, perched at the edge of her seat, looking like in about two more breaths she'd bolt, and their eyes met for a second before Catra's gaze darted away, tail lashing steadily behind her. The woman gave a shallow inhale and tried to relax her posture, only managing to scoot back from the edge of the couch maybe two inches, but a trickle of warmth entered Adora's stomach as she witnessed it. Catra listened. She came up here and was the one to broach the subject of them' in the first place. The ball in her chest unfurled ever so slightly, though did not release. The magicat had a few things to answer for still.

“It sucks when you ignore me.” Adora frowned for a half-second, almost adding how it hurt her too, but held off on that. She wasn't in

the mood to get into a shouting match and well, that was probably well enough implied.

Catra's ear flicked, before she gave a tiny nod. "Yeah." The pause was palpable, Adora's anger was beginning to contract again, but then the magicat whispered, "I'm sorry."

The word felt foreign on her tongue, but she was sorry. Adora shouldn't have to put up with this kind of crap. Just more evidence on why Catra should hightail it out of this woman's life. But she didn't want to. Despite everything, every anxious voice telling her to leave this uncomfortable situation, she stayed on that couch. It was almost worse that Adora wasn't screaming, because then Catra could retaliate with anger of her own. But this person who just looked so tired, was speaking evenly, calmly stating how Catra's choices affected her. She had even shared a dumb story about their almost-meeting when Catra couldn't manage to talk about anything of substance right at first. Adora was just... something else.

Adora continued to watch the magicat, her thoughts a steady stream building into a flowing river. Perhaps these things simply had no answers, no easy explanations, and weren't based in rationality or logic. Adora had flirted with Catra right at the start because she did and that was that. And Catra had reciprocated and shied away and reciprocated. Perhaps it was all a process, trial and error, of fucking up and apologizing later. Maybe the beginning of things getting better, of their time together stabilizing, was showing some consideration for the wounds that remained invisible, the bruises that stayed tender long after the marks had faded. Catra was scared. But she had chosen to be up here and what's more, Adora didn't doubt for a moment that if the magicat hadn't wanted her here at this ridiculous party in the first place... Adora could work with all this. She *wanted* to work with wherever the woman was, but also for her own well-being at the end of the day, she needed to lay all her cards out on the table.

"I just like you so much, Catra." The words were a soft caress, a knuckle ran down a cheek, a gentle kiss on the back of the neck in

the early morning hours before the rest of the world awoke and it was just the two of them together ... All the things that Adora wanted, everything she was willing to work for. Had she ever actually so said aloud? Would it be too much if she did now?

To anyone without Catra's extraordinary hearing, the words might have been lost over the din of this most idiotic pastime. But Catra heard loud and clear, even if she didn't understand. How could Adora confess such a thing, when Catra couldn't even respond to a few texts? Or when the blonde had asked her to talk, how could she still admit to *liking* the peevish, temperamental seasons of her time and affection? It made no sense. Maybe Catra had a tendency to put herself down on occasion, but in this case, in the face of absolute absurdity, she had to know. "Why?"

Adora had been bracing herself for a number of reactions, but that was not one of them. "What do you mean?"

"Why are you so interested in me? You know nothing about me." Catra bristled at the oversimplification. That wasn't what she meant, even if there was truth to the heart of it. A few messy hook-ups, an aggregated couple hours of conversation, and one drunk, hazy cuddle session just couldn't possibly be enough to get so invested in another person. But this was the closest she could get to the real question on her mind; *why would you ever like* me?

Most unhelpfully, the qualities she found attractive in the woman fluttered from Adora's mind. Perhaps if she were being truthful, the main instigator was just how alluring and sexy she found Catra to be. Something told her not to provide that as an answer, however, no matter how honest it was. It wasn't that she couldn't think of anything with substance (driven, intelligent, a biting wit that seared so good...), but this also felt like a chance to drive home a larger point. "I'm *trying* to. If you'd just let me in a little bit." The blonde trailed off as she noticed the woman's tail halting in the air. That didn't seem like the best sign. Adora adopted her softest voice, their gaze meeting once more. Time to pull out the big guns, go for broke. Maybe she would come to regret asking for this level of vulnerability

with the other woman, but something had to give. "Look, Cat, I don't know who hurt you before, but I promise you that I'm not like that. I-..."

A squeaky laugh interrupted the blonde's train before it truly left the station. Of course. Of course Adora would try to make promises no one could ever hope to keep fulfilled. "Think you got me all figured out, huh? Pretty bold for someone who's also proclaiming to be let in." The magicat crossed her arms over her chest. How many times had she heard that one over the years from a whole array of people across a variety of situations? She wasn't easy, she wasn't open, and so many people had taken their best shots at figuring out why. "Let's see. Maybe mommy was too mean to me growing up, maybe some *great love* broke my heart, or whatever other ridiculous trauma you've concocted in your head for me to suffer from." Adora began to protest, but Catra held up one finger, clucking her tongue. "Life isn't that fucking simple, Grayson. Duh! Of course I've been hurt before, got my fair share of scars and baggage. I'm *alive,* aren't I? That doesn't mean I'm some damsel in distress, begging for you to come change me or save me. I don't need that. I don't *want* that. My life is fine exactly as it is- with or without you in it." Maybe Catra had come up here, but there were things that she simply wouldn't tolerate. A hero complex was one of them. Catra's battles were her own.

The blonde furrowed her brow, thinking quickly. She went quiet for several seconds before asking what she perceived as the root of what Catra was really trying to say. "So... there's a chance for me to be in your life?"

Catra stilled, not believing her ears. What was this woman? That was her take away? Maybe she didn't need Adora to save her, but Catra sure as fuck needed to save Adora from herself. Summoning up the last dregs of her courage, she rose from her spot on the couch, stepping lightly around the coffee table that separated them. Catra crossed to where Adora was seated, with her wide, blue eyes, anxiously awaiting for Catra's reply to her question. Adora looked so hopeful, so proud of the conclusion that she'd drawn. No matter

Catra's own feelings, this idiot deserved a sweetness and sunshine to match her own. She could fall apart about this whole thing later. For now, she just needed to…

Kneeling in front of this big, dumb oaf, looking at her through her long lashes, Catra gave a curious half-smile before ever so gently placing her lips to one pink cheek. The skin beneath her lips was chilly from the autumn breeze, but Catra knew that wasn't what was so scorching. Maybe one last act of softness would dull some of the sharper, more disappointing memories over time. "... I'm just a bitch, Adora." Catra's eyes were closed tightly as she savored this last bit of contact. She would leave now, be the sensible one, not continue to drag Adora down into the muck and mire of her life. It was the truth, but god knows that didn't make it any less shitty of her.

Before Catra could fully rise back to her feet, rough fingers grabbed her chin, pulling her down so they were nose to nose. Adora's eyes were hard, flicking back and forth to study her, but they softened as Catra's own two-toned gaze flickered open at the contact, then went wide with apprehension as she registered the closeness of their position. After searching for several long seconds, almost daring the magicat to react, Adora's voice came out low and succinct. "Okay."

"W-what. What do you mean okay?" Catra did not try to remove herself from that firm grasp; she was caught in the headlights of that accepting stare. Okay. Okay, what? Adora couldn't possibly mean...

"Okay. You're a bitch. I get it, loud and clear." Adora released her jaw, but found Catra hadn't moved. The blonde ran two fingers across her cheek, trying to soothe any soreness she may have caused. Catra sucked in a breath at the action, Adora crooking a smile at the sound. "I still like you, but that's also not blanket permission to treat me like dirt, you got it?" No, Catra most certainly did *not* get it. But she was given no chance to state that before Adora added. "I mean it Catra, I'm pretty darn patient, but I also need you to understand that I'm in your corner. Or at least I'd like to be. So maybe don't shove me away at every chance?"

The corner of Catra's mouth twitched as she witnessed a flash of genuine hurt in the other woman's eyes, but she couldn't bring herself to speak or soothe before it disappeared just as quickly. In her corner? Catra had to agree that the shoving away thing was getting pretty old, even from her side of things. A stupid, stupid form of self-sabotage and a hard pattern to break. But maybe... Catra could work on it? At her own pace and simply for herself, because it was so damn tiring to do to herself time after time. "Okay."

The blonde nodded, pleased at how easily that one had gone. "Finally, I like you for a lot of different reasons, but also, can you just accept that I do for now? At least while we get to know one another better. If you want." Adora was trying her best to leave it a little vague and let Catra draw her own conclusions. Now that they were talking and it sort of seemed to be going well, she certainly wasn't going to muck the whole thing up by bringing up the subject of dating right now. In Adora's head, they'd spend time together, probably keep doing what they'd been doing, and well... Did labels make it taste better? Not really. Nothing they couldn't approach at a later time. Just let Adora stay a part of this woman's life and for her to give it all a chance. "For the record, I like steak too, but I don't have a big long list of reasons why. I just do."

"... Did you just put me on the same level as a piece of meat?" There was objectification and then there was... whatever the fuck Adora was saying here. Maybe the blonde was going for some humor to break their weird-ass situation, but really? *Steak*? Like she really should expect anything less from the banana girl.

Adora chuckled, pleased to see that she had shocked some life back into the other woman. There was some of that fire that Adora wanted to warm herself by at the end of the day. She leaned back, crooking an arm behind her head in a pose of practiced, swaggering nonchalance. "I mean, I do love to eat you both..."

"You're a pig."

"And you're a bitch."

The word had never been said towards Catra with such naked affection before. She flushed, surprised at her own libido, though whether it was being called a name or the tenderness that enveloped each syllable that came from this handsome woman's mouth. God, they were so fucked up. Nothing about this made any damn sense. Nothing in their situation from the start had made any damn sense, it had always been a flurry of want and impulse decisions, so what was one more poorly thought out choice?

"I'm not promising *anything*." She struggled to get the words out. Catra felt like Sisyphus and the boulder, but maybe... maybe she would make it to the top of that hill eventually. One painstaking push at a time. With her eyes trained to the floor, the magicat asked in a hushed, labored tone, "Can we just take it one day at a time? Just see how it all goes?"

Adora responded by holding her arms open so the brunette could decide for herself if she wanted to come closer. The woman gave a tiny nod, but did not move, and so Adora gently drew the woman into her lap. Petting down her long hair, she breathed into her ear, "All I want, Cat. I'm in no rush."

Catra's body unclenched at the affirmation, as she melted under the feel of large hands anywhere on her body. She wasn't sure if anything had really been decided between them, but it also didn't seem quite as turbid as before. The ambiguity was almost satisfying in a way, because they could mold it into whatever they wanted it to be, shape it to something that worked for them as they went. At the start of all this madness, Adora had asked her, "So, we doing this?"

And it looked like now, just as with back then, they were.

"Adora," Catra said softly after a time, still cradled against the broad chest, the blonde still absently running her fingers over any part of Catra she could reach, "Why didn't you just take stupid costume off last year?" She wasn't fixated, *really*, but as Catra lazily carded over the events of what had just happened, the thought hit her. Everything about the blonde's demeanor as she had told the story seemed to

indicate that she had been embarrassed as all hell in that stupid thing, and its presence also explained why she ducked out as soon as she could (Catra refused to say split, but damn if the word didnt come to mind several fucking times). So why not just ditch the getup in some corner and be done with it?

"Adora's hand paused from where it had been stroking down the fur of Catra's arm, her brows coming together in a point. "Um. Ill be dead honest with you, Catra." The magicat seized for a moment, praying the answer wasnt that the woman had been going commando under her peel. "I didnt think of it." That really was the truth of it all; never once in that whole awkward 45 minutes that Adora had been there did the thought of just removing the costume come to her. "That would have been... Really simple, huh? But also, I would have looked so dumb holding a big ass banana costume in my hand."

"Oh, because *wearing* the big ass banana costume was so much better." Catra couldnt help but laugh, rising from where she had settled on Adora's chest to get a good look at her. A rueful smile rose to the other woman's lips, a perfect blend of bashfulness and "I'm cute, right?" And she was. As much as Catra hated to admit it, the woman she was perched on was just absolutely appealing in every way (god, this word play shit *needed* to stop). Without really even thinking about it, Catra mumbled out a "Dummy" before leaning forward to peck her on the cheek once more. Catra pulled her face away, the pair halting as they regarded one another. She leaned down, just needing to kiss this woman's dumb little face again...

Adora caught her lips, turning what may have been another sweet kiss on the cheek into something else entirely. The opportunity was there, so the blonde took it. From the surprised, but ultimately pleased hum that the brunette gave, Catra certainly wasnt complaining. The two smiled into their kiss, Adora's bashfulness apparently contagious. They broke after a moment, but stayed near, a warm, locked gaze between them as they rested their foreheads together. Overcome by those mismatched, stunning eyes, Adora

moved forward again, another tender kiss shared, longer this time and a little more unwilling to part so easily.

Catra's fingers absently twirled along the back of Adora's head, having risen up from where she had been previously draping them behind her neck. One tiny push, a bare nudge of encouragement, and Adora added some firmness. A most satisfied noise vibrated across Adora's lips as she pressed against Catra's mouth. The blonde parted her lips open, Catra welcoming her eagerly. Their tongues brushed and the noise deepened, though this time Adora couldn't be sure which of them it came from. She knew she gave a little huff as the magicat pulled away for a moment, Catra laughing under her breath. The woman gave no explanation other than swinging her legs around so that they were bracketed on either side of Adora's hips, more than happy to resume their ever growing ferocity.

She kissed Adora with a hunger, their mouths sliding together, Catra moaning openly when the blonde sucked on her bottom lip, nibbling it. Adora's hands were back around her waist, exactly where they should be, squeezing and releasing. Her shirt hiked up just a smidge and the blonde pounced on that little patch of skin, rubbing her fingers all along it, Catra burning at just that bare contact.

"Lemme just get," Adora panted out between kisses, holding Catra against her, thumbing her hips, shuddering at the sliver of soft, warm fur. It was apparent where this was going. "The blinds." As Adora stood from the couch, the magicat locked her legs around her waist, a small noise of surprise and appreciation for her strength was given.

She hadn't chosen this empty bay for any reason in particular , just after a few minutes of stomping around up here, anxiously wondering if Catra was going to follow her, Adora slumped down on the nearest couch, too exhausted from her own anger to keep up the pacing any longer. But it worked out rather well that it was towards the end, fitted with some sun blocking blinds so players could take their shots at any time of day. She started to head towards them,

perfectly intent to keep the woman wrapped around her as she gave them some modicum of privacy should anyone wander up here. Public was apparently their thing, but she really wasn't looking to get Catra banned from the rest of her own birthday. Which speaking of, was that even still going on? Okay, maybe actually they should wait- party couldn't last that much long…

"No." Catra licked a long stripe up the blonde's neck, pressing her fangs against the soft flesh there. If Adora liked breath play, she figured that would drive the woman absolutely wild. She wasn't disappointed by the reaction; the blonde clawing at her back, blunted nails raking down over her shirt, sharply gasping before it dissolved into a low, guttural moan rumbling deep in her throat. Catra could feel the vibrations and wanted to press down harder, mark this woman as her own, but refrained if only so she could whisper, "Leave them open. I like it."

Catra returned to pressing kisses all along her neck, down to her collarbone, pulling back the fabric of her shirt to the top of the woman's binder so she could kiss every available inch of Adora's skin. She placed her hands on that flattened chest, reveling in the feel of the hardened muscles below. So handsome. Not fully conscious of it, she began to rock her hips, searching for purchase to relieve the ache between her thighs.

"Jesus." Adora swallowed, throwing her head back to allow more access. A flash of heat shot straight to her core as she was given the direction, made all the better with the feel of Catra slowly grinding against her. Adora slipped her hands under the back of Catra's shirt, needing to feel the woman directly. If anyone came up here, there'd be no denying what was going on, but the longer she kissed Catra, the less she cared. Her hands ran all along her body, nails dragged down Catra's back with just enough pressure to make the woman whine. Emboldened by how desperate Catra seemed for her already, Adora decided to pull out an arrow from a very special quiver, all just to make the magical quiver. "That's hot as fuck. You are such a little slut"…

Catra shuddered at the words, right down to the tip of her tail. She pulled away from the dark marks she'd been peppering Adora's neck with and faced the blonde head on, eyes blown wide, lips swollen and dark. In a voice thickened with desire, Catra promised, "Only for you."

At the raspy words, Adora growled, one hand shooting up into Catra's hair to bring the woman down into a hard, biting kiss. The other hand stayed low on her, squeezing her ass and occasionally pressing Catra in harder against Adora's torso. The friction she was able to gain in this position was not nearly enough, but damn if Catra didn't love being so pressed up against Adora's body, supported so easily by her. A tree she wanted to climb again and again. The blonde's hand stayed in her hair, running through the silky strands. It wasn't exactly straightened any longer, instead soft waves that Adora's fingers still could easily glide through without fear of disturbing any perfect curls. Catra breathed out over the other woman's lips, following up on something that hadn't gotten a chance to be fulfilled the last time they had seen one another. "Pull"…

Adora obeyed without delay, fisting her hands through Catra's locks, and tugging backwards sharply. The magicat gasped, eyes shuddering, a blissed smile as suddenly her chin was pointed upwards towards the ceiling. God *yes.* Adora took the opportunity and pressed hard kisses along her jaw, the base of her ear, tugs accenting each press of her mouth. Catra whined openly each time, the contrasting sensations driving her wild. It wasn't pain, but it was…and she loved it.

At her ragged breathing, Adora moved upwards towards her sensitive ear, whispering directly into it, "The next time we do this will be in a bed. *My* bed."

The thrill of exhibitionism had its merits, but Adora was lamenting that she couldn't strip this woman down right here, right now, and run her hands over her entirely naked form before tonguing her into submission. So she'd make it clear that she would finally take this woman home at their next meet up, something she'd been promising

to do for far too long. Catra nodded her agreement quickly , thighs shaking from how clenched she had been against the blonde's body, before Adora kissed her on the mouth once more, and laid them down on the couch. It was a little awkward, certainly not designed for such things, but neither cared. Catra's legs had relaxed, knees spread apart, welcoming any part of Adora that wanted to be between them. There was absolutely too much clothing in their way, but the fall breeze and the thrill of being caught tempered the chance for full skin-on-skin contact. With Catra's hands roaming around Adora as she panted heavily beneath the blonde, Adora propped herself on one elbow right above the magicat's head and reached a hand between them. They could probably have gotten away with pulling down Catra's leggings at least to mid thigh, and she could have easily slipped her strap out and just driven into the woman until she came undone. But if Adora couldn't have Catra splayed out naked below her, she at least wanted to fuck her with her own fingers and feel how wet the brunette was for her.

As she made her way down, Adora paused at her tits, paying a fair tribute with a promise to absolutely *lavish* attention there at the next soonest opportunity. She wasn't trying to rush this (really if no workers or other patrons had wandered up here yet, they were probably in the clear), but the last thing either of them needed was a concerned partygoer checking in on them if they took *too long* . Nipping at the hardened nipple over her shirt, and smirking at the whine her teeth had caused, Adora finally slipped a hand underneath the waistband of Catra's bottoms.

It seemed to be a 50-50 chance as to whether she would encounter another layer of fabric and today at least, Adora was immensely grateful to not have to fight any underwear to get where she wanted to be (even if the little lacy things were quite appreciated). Catra twitched with a cut off moan as the pad of Adora's middle finger slid over her, drawing small circles around her clit while she kissed the woman firmly, swallowing the filthy noises all for herself. Adora herself was already breathing heavily;Catra was soaked, Adora' s fingers able to slide and flick so easily around her. She sped up her

motions, adding additional pressure, rolling that needy clit between two fingers. Catra tensed at the increased friction, with a series of broken whines and heavy pants before she rocked her hips in time with Adora. She was so worked up, just so grateful to be under this woman once more. But Catra needed more. Barely moving her lips from the blonde's, she choked out, "Fuck me."

Adora wanted to make the woman beg or at the very least say please, but the desire to be knuckle-deep in her was stronger. She gave one last flick of her fingers, pressing in as she roved back and forth quickly, Catra's hands low on her back and squeezing hard as fingers worked her so relentlessly, before Adora moved lower. Just one would be laughable, Catra was far too open and wet. The pair moaned into each other's mouths as Adora's middle and ring finger slipped into her, thumb moving back to her clit.

There were no thoughts, just Adora fucking her soundly. The woman's fingers were so thick, so large as they curled into her front wall, hitting all the right places. Catra wasn't going to last long like this, not with how she was grinding down on those perfect fingers, not with the searing kisses this intoxicating woman was leaving all across her lips, jaw, and neck. She was certain if Adora commanded it, Catra could come instantly, stuttering her name as the waves overtook her. At a particularly rough thrust, Catra melted into the touch, her ankles hooking around Adora's back as her hands dug into the woman's ass, pulling her forward to fuck her even harder. She swore she felt Adora give a low, throaty chuckle at that, and pressed in so that the tips of her claws could even be felt through the denim of Adora's jeans. The woman certainly wasn't laughing now, breathing out all manner of filthy phrases, dragging Catra ever closer to the edge, until she had no choice but to let go.

Curling her fingers and jutting the heel of her hand against her clit hard, Adora growled for the woman to come for her, and then slotted her mouth over Catra's, to keep the near-screaming moan of her release all to herself. She felt Catra clench hard around all three of her fingers, the magicat's legs a vice grip behind her, ankles crossed

as she drove herself down on Adora's hand. Catra was biting Adora's lips, with a keening wail that tapered off into strained huffs and breathy pants. Adora gathered them all, kissing her slowly, fingers just barely gliding through the last pulses of her pleasure. It was with some regret that she removed them, already missing that silken heat and the feelings that came with being in this beautiful, careful woman. Adora sucked her own fingers clean, Catra watching through a half-lidded gaze. "Next time." The blonde promised with an exaggerated flutter of her tongue, Catra's taste filling her mouth.

The brunette gave a shuddering laugh, the sultry assurance almost too much for her in her highly sensitive state. Whatever Adora wanted. But Catra was going to get her fill of the woman the next time too. The hard press of her strap against the back of her throat had been inhabiting Catra's dirtiest daydreams and she definitely wanted to thank Adora for the wonderful birthday present as she'd just received.

Next time... next time in Adora's bed. A rumbling purr kicked up at the mere thought.

The pair lay there a few moments longer. Adora was sort of crushing her, but it wasn't really in a bad way, almost soothing as Catra came down from her high. She had dropped her legs from around the blonde, tail lifeless as it draped over the back of the couch. When she could speak in full sentences again, Catra murmured, "You know you're here at my party because I want you here... right, dummy?"

Adora toyed with all manner of replies, ranging from a cocky "Duh, how could you not?" to some half-baked joke about how she thought it was just a party favor that she'd gotten a few fingers into the woman this afternoon, who was up next? Thank god that one didn't materialize beyond the few vapors in her brain; it didn't make much sense for one and two, Adora liked her skin not flayed from her bones, not to mention this cuddly, snuggly Catra. She finally settled on a small kiss on the other woman's brow along with, "I wanted to be here too."

With a short sigh, Catra shut her eyes, flopping her head against the cushion of the couch once. Sometimes even the obvious just needed said. Speaking of obvious, "I should probably get back downstairs. Honestly, the fact that Scorpia hasn't sent a search and rescue team for me..." Her smile turned vicious. So many people- her friends, employees, hell the day was pressing on so more patrons might begin to pop up, could have interrupted them at any point. Catra's birthday present got all the sweeter that no one had. She probably would have just told Adora to keep going;whatever ...

Adora chuckled, nodding her agreement that they'd spent way too long up here. She glanced at her watch and frowned. She really should check in with Hope soon, as well as offer to bring the woman a late lunch or at this point, early dinner. Hope and Mara lived not too far from Top Golf. "I hate to do this, really, but"...

"Need to head out?" Catra supplied, able to gather from how the blonde had scowled at her wrist. Adora nodded, and even though she was trying to be cool, really had no reason not to be, disappointment still hung low in Catra's stomach. She shoved it to the side, latching on to something else to distract herself. "What, not going to at least come down to say goodbye to Starla?" Uh. A new, sharper layer of something joined the disappointment. Maybe she wasn't quite ready to joke about that, even if Catra had been the one to start it.

The butch woman blinked for a moment, then rolled her eyes. "You don't seriously think that"...

"You could, yknow." The magicat said softly, pushing past any and all emotions that she'd sprung on herself. They'd just agreed to see how this went;no promises or commitments of any kind had been made. And maybe they had just fucked, but...

"Yeah, I could." Adora agreed with a shrug. "But I don't want to. She's cute enough, I guess, but no spark there. Not like with..." The blonde trailed off, thumb absently thumbing along the clawed hand she held, a small smile rising to her face.

Catra's ear flicked in satisfaction. Good. What Adora did in her spare time with others was her own business, but Catra sure as hell wasn't gonna be stupid enough to suggest it ever again. Self-sabotage was ridiculous.

The magicat cleared her throat, scanning for the best way to approach the next thing on her mind. One day at a time. But what was the next day she'd get to see this handsome woman? "So, uh, I'm o-off this week. If you wanted to"…

"I do." Adora quickly assured, that angry weight in her chest had long since evolved into a happy bubble. Of course she wanted to see Catra again and as soon as possible. "Well, I mean, I did invite you out to my bar, so if you're free this week."

"What, not afraid I'll end up smashed again?" Catra really hadn't touched a drink since that unfortunate night, not even downstairs at the party. All manner of more potent beverages had been offered to her, probably would continue once she returned to the festivities, but she hadn't wanted to chance it if Adora had decided to show. And thank god for that. This was the fuck she should have gotten that night.

"Nah, that was a one-off. Those Portals were nasty as hell, Cat, honestly. No idea how you could drink them." Adora blanched at the memory of the alcohol burning most of her tastebuds off. "But also, I don't police you. You can take care of yourself, decide whether you want to drink or not. They've got great food, so how about you meet me there on Friday? Same deal as the Waste. We'll meet and then..."

"... Your place?" The magicat trilled, her voice dropping low. Maybe they just had, but the thought had her ready to go again. Friday simply couldn't arrive soon enough.

With plans set for what at least the next few days would look like, the pair said their goodbyes. Adora wasn't quite sure what to do, but Catra didn't seem to protest as the blonde wrapped her into a hug,

almost pressing a kiss to the top of her head. Catra squeezed her back and sighed once more, tail wrapping around her wrist before walking away. Adora stood up there a little bemused, but ultimately hopeful before excusing herself to the restroom to wash up. Maybe she'd get something just delivered to Hope, whatever the pregnant woman wanted. It would probably be weird to hang out after everything she had just done.

Catra trickled back to her party, trying to remain as unobtrusive as possible. Maybe if she melded into the background well enough she could pretend that she'd been there for far longer than she actually had. No such luck because it seemed like most everyone had decided to call it for the afternoon. Catra really couldn't blame them; what a weird ass party. Scorpia was up to swing as she sat down on the couch, Perfuma sipping some pink drink from her glass. The woman glanced at Catra from the corner of her eye. "Adora?"

"Had to go."

Perfuma nodded, taking another drink. "It went well?"

Scorpia was whooping and pointing excitedly to how far her ball was careening towards the back target, landing on the ground before rolling in. She pumped her arm and ran up to the screen, as if wanting to verify that her 15 points had been counted. Catra smiled at the antics, heart full at this patient, wonderful person who held so much of her life together. "Yeah, I think so."

Adora had snuck out of the facility with relative ease, walking quickly towards her truck with her head down. She wasn't embarrassed about her actions, actually once safely in her vehicle she glanced at the third floor of Top Golf with no small amount of pride in her grin, but just didn't want to run into anyone she may have met this afternoon and have to give any awkward goodbyes. She backed out of her spot and told her car to call Hope, catching up with the woman and promising to get a whole variety of Thai food delivered ASAP. She needed to gas up, so it was a perfect chance for her to place the order.

When she arrived back at her home, Adora found that her smile hadn't faded in the slightest, nor once she had showered and changed. She gave an almost alarming belly laugh when she saw the only option in her fridge for dinner that evening was a flank steak. She munched on a banana to tide her own as she fired up her grill in the backyard. Yup. Adora had plenty to smile about.

Her alarm lulled her out of a deep, restful slumber, back to her normal of a rather early bedtime. She groped around in the morning twilight of her room for her phone to shut the sound off, surprised to see she had a slew of texts.

Reply to:

[Sent over 1 month ago] **Adora:** *Cup of coffee here with your name on it.*

Catra (2am): pass

Reply to:

[Sent over 1 month ago] **Adora:** *Or a different kind of wake up if you'd prefer…)*

Catra (2am): better

Reply to:

[Sent over 1 month ago] **Adora:** *Fuck that was rude. I mean, I know we enjoyed ourselves last Friday and yesterday but I don't want you to think that's all I'm after from you.*

Catra (2am) idiot. u fuck me like u did then apologize... 🙄 dont

Reply to:

[Sent over 1 month ago] **Adora:** *At least I enjoyed myself. A lot.*

Catra (2am) ...me too

Catra (2am) obviously.

Reply to:

[Sent over 1 month ago] **Adora:** *Maybe we could grab a drink sometime?*

Catra (2am) ur bar better b good fri

Reply to:

[Sent over 1 month ago] **Adora:** *Found that missing stake while we were planting the new pole lol oops think a lawn mower got it, it was pretty torn up.*

Catra (2am) dummy

It continued on this way, usually no more than one or two word replies but each letter made the smile on Adora's face permanent. She probably wouldnt even need cof fee this morning. Good thing she wouldnt be around power tools or live wires for the rest of the week, not with as flighty and carefree as she was bound to be.

Reply to:

[Sent 2 weeks ago] **Adora:** *Hope you made it home safe. Drink lots of water, Catra.*

Catra 2:38am: prefer yellow gatorade

Adora made a mental note of that one, even if blue was the far superior choice.

Reply to:

[Sent 2 weeks ago] **Adora:** *Just thought I'd make sure you were still alive.*

Catra (2:45am) think u no how alive i am after earlier

Catra (2:48am) ur fingers do at least

Catra (6:15am) gn dummy. see u fri

Adora (6:18am) Good morning, Catra. See you Friday!

So much to smile about.


@Tara Teacher3

Chapter End Notes

Oh... Did I fix it? Will it stay fixed? Hmm...

Hello, everyone! Hope you enjoyed this jaunt at Top Of. Fanart by the phenomenal TaraTeacher3 (@tarateacher3 on Twitter) who had been dying to draw this scene ever since I teased it. The infamous banana costume- love it, hate it, or confused by it, is all thanks to RaptorRed. Because when I asked them "What kind of Halloween costume would PA Adora wear?" they immediately replied "Banana." Also thanks to the people on Twitter who all voted banana on my vague poll (my lady had suggested Maverick from TopGun as the other option for Adora to dress as). The joke has sort of taken on a life of itself, so be on the look out for more hidden Cavendishes all around the fandom, from myself and a few others...

Until next time, folks!

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra sighed as the Uber driver stopped in front of the building. It was generally nondescript;brick, fairly small, and had a list of weekly specials on a board mounted outside on one of the walls. Exactly like a million other hole-in-the-wall bars she'd looked right past over the years. But what had Catra rolling her eyes was the giant neon rainbow cactus right in the front window, its blinking, pastel colors taunting her with their utter lack of subtlety. Of course Grayson the Great Gay would claim this as her spot.

"Rainbow Cactus."The driver grunted, his own special way of bringing their transaction to a close.

"Figured that one out myself, thanks."Catra murmured, slipping from the car and slamming the door just a little harder than she meant to. It's possible that the owner of the vehicle flipped her the bird at the slam of her door, but whatever. He would still get five stars from her just from the fact he hadn't tried to fill the forty or so minute drive with any conversation.

Catra went ahead and took care of that now, also tipping the dude a few extra bucks since he had kept the music low and the choices tolerable, shivering slightly as she stood outside in the late October air. Before she could send a text to the dummy and ask for an ETA, a call of her name had her sliding her phone into her coat pocket and a smile sliding out onto her face.

"Catra! Hey!"Adora came up jogging up to her , almost going in for a hug before pulling back and deciding to go with an overzealous wave. Dork.

"Hey , Adora." The magicat's tail swished behind her as the other woman had leaned in, a faint trickle of disappointment that Adora had leaned back again so quickly . But also, yeah, Catra got it. One day at a time.

A beat of silence passed before Adora shoved her hands in her pockets, looking to distract from the slight awkwardness. "Find the place okay?"

Catra crossed her arms over her chest. It was fucking *cold* , but of course Adora wanted to small talk. "Uh, Im here, arent I? And I mean, the Uber driver at least had enough brain cells to type in an address, so yeah. It was fine."

"You took a car." Adora murmured. Maybe it was a chilly October evening, but with the radiance from Adora's smile, it could have been an afternoon in June.

"Yeah, dummy." Catra returned with a small smile in spite of herself, shaking her head at the exuberance of the woman she wanted to spend her Friday night with. "I took a car , Im here, so maybe you could *actually* take me inside? It's fucking cold out here."

"Oh! Right, right. Yes. Inside." Adora vaguely motioned for Catra to move on ahead of her, the magicat rolling her eyes at the other woman for thinking she needed to be told which direction to go. But as Adora stepped in close behind her, one hand along the small of her back, gently leading Catra to the entrance of the bar, Catra found she really didnt mind the guidance after all.

It was larger inside than Catra expected, though that wasnt really saying too much. Immediately to the left of the entrance was a raised platform, presumably for live music and a small patch of wooden flooring directly in front of it, likely for dancing. In the center of the room was the bar itself, with stools lining each of the four sides. The bar had a modest selection of bottles on display, three tiers worth at least, and Catra could spy a few taps offering a mix of domestics and local craft beers. Booths and tables lined the walls of the place and

there seemed to be a smaller room on the right towards the back of the building. Catra's ear flicked as she heard the crack of a pool cue striking a ball. Yeah, that wasn't going to get annoying.

At least it wasn't packed, since they'd opted to meet up for a pretty early dinner time, but there was a smattering of general chatter about the room. Adora was watching Catra's face for reaction, pleased when she felt the brush of a furry tail wrap around her wrist. Looks like it passed the initial scrutiny. "Table or booth?"

"Doesn't matter." Catra shrugged. Dinner was just a formality really, though Adora had made such a big deal out of buying Catra a "birthday burger" when they had been texting yesterday to finalize plans for today. But that was just a thing people did for someone's birthday, even if it wasn't until Sunday, and Catra would just take the free meal. Whatever.

"All righty, let's just take that one then." Adora nodded towards a four person, low top table on their left. "But first, drinks." She placed her hand on Catra's back again, encouraging her to move towards the bar.

"Adora." The woman behind the counter nodded her head in greeting, red and white bandana bobbing in equal acknowledgement of one the bar's regulars.

"Heeey, you!" Adora beamed, her smile wide from the greeting, even if it was a little terse. "So they got you slingin' tonight, huh? Going rules the night of?"

"Wedding." The woman explained, pursing her lips with a short, clipped sigh. "What do you want?"

"Whatever is on tap from Snakes this week, if you got anything in right now. Make that a tall for me and." Adora half-gestured towards her guest, "Then whatever she'd like. You need a draft list, Cat?"

“Just club soda for me.” Catra answered, waving off the offer to review any other choices.

“Nothing in that- splash of vodka, hint of lime even?” Adora suggested, fingers ever so slightly curling around the magicat’s waist.

“Nope.” Catra said quickly, fighting to ignore the flash of excitement that came from Adora tightening her grip. She’d been fighting a headache all day and really didn’t think alcohol would improve things much. Also, Catra made mistakes, plenty, but if she could avoid repeating what had happened while at the Waste a few weeks ago... “The water is fine.”

“Okay.” Adora said gently, handing over her credit card to the worker behind the bar who sighed openly at the delay in their ordering. The bartender hadn’t asked, but Adora still found herself saying, “Yeah, go ahead and keep the tab open. We’ll be up for food in just a couple minutes.”

The sullen woman gave a curt nod, leaving the twenty two ounce mug with Adora’s beer and Catra’s much smaller glass on the counter to wait on a few other people on the other side of the bar.

As they got back to the table with their requested drinks, Adora took a deep gulp from her large, dark beer and smacked her lips, sighing in satisfaction. That brewery was so good, even if it took them forever to produce anything. She stared into the umber liquid, surprised by the tart, fruity flavor that accompanied the strong taste of hops. After a moment of silence to settle themselves in, Adora spoke over the rim of her glass. “You know, it’s funny. I’ve been coming here for years and I still have no idea what that bartender’s name is. I just call her mushroom lady because she’s always in that red and white spotted bandana thing.”

“Yeah, that was pretty fucking obvious from that,” Catra put on her most vapid expression, raising her voice up an octave or two,

“Heeeeeey , you! at the beginning. Gayson, I know even a hint of subtlety is an ask for you, but *c'mon* .”

Adora laughed openly at the mocking impression, shrugging as she took another pull of her beer. “Maybe that’ s why she’s always such a bitch to me, just knows how clueless I am. Kind of a shame Juliet isn't around tonight, though. She and her wife own the place and I think you'd like them.”

Catra sipped at the bubbly, vaguely bitter water and remained quiet at the comment. Easy for Adora to say, the dummy liked everyone she met. As they'd covered earlier in the week, however , Catra was a lot more discerning in her tastes. Privately, she was very relieved to not be meeting any of Adora’s friends tonight. It was enough that she had come to a new place for the woman, nevermind that soon she'd be in Adora’ s *home* . Gayson could just cool it.

A pool cue cracked from the back room, the sound of balls scattering about the table ringing in Catra’s ears. Great news for her headache. It was only a dull throb, nothing excruciating, but just enough to be annoyingly present. Catra had spent most of the afternoon napping, just trying to get it to fuck of f already. Dimly she realized the last time she ate was sometime in the mid-morning, which was also probably not helping matters much. “So, this place has good food, huh?”

“Oh! Y up.” Adora plucked out the menu from behind the carrier for the salt, pepper, and other condiments, passing it over. “I've never had anything bad here and it’s all my treat. I know , for your birthday.” Her smile wavered as she tacked on the last part, taking a drink to cover herself.

“As you mentioned at least twelve times yesterday .” Catra glanced over the menu, not really reading the words. She spoke into the laminated listing of food, tail wrapping around the ankle of the woman across from her. “The way you're building it up, Gayson, you're rendering yourself obsolete. Apparently one bite of burger is enough to make me come.”

"It' s good."Adora confirmed with a nod, repressing a shiver at the furry brush against her leg. Even through her jeans she could feel it so clearly, soft and warm with a comforting weight behind it. Adora raised her drink up to her mouth again and paused there, before curling her lips back into her most smug grin, staring Catra down even as the magicat hid behind her menu. "But I'm better ."

Catra felt a purr kick up into her chest, her tail raising just a little higher on Adora's thigh before pulling away, relaxing to lay on the seat next to her. "God. W orth my time, Grayson. Make it worth my time."

Conversation tapered off for a few minutes as Catra reviewed the menu in earnest. She finally settled on some sort of spicy chicken sandwich, partially just to tweak her dining companion' s nose for as many times as Adora had mentioned how tasty the burgers were, but mostly because it just sounded fucking tasty . Adora didn't comment on her choice, just said she'd be right back and went back up to the cranky mushroom lady at the bar to place their order. A few more people wandered in while Adora was gone and the overall noise around them picked up considerably, gays wanting to unwind after a long week at work. Catra only *audibly* sighed once the jukebox started up too.

"Shouldn't be too long on the food. Looks like we beat the rush." Adora grinned, tapping her fingers to the music against the handle of her mug. She hadn't been seated for more than ten seconds before her eye flicked down. "Need a refill?"

Catra looked down into her short glass, shifting it so that the ice cubes clinked together. "Y eah, guess so. See if she'll put it into a taller one. I don't need that mammoth mug your idiot self is drinking from, but that was barely a swallow."

"Y ou got it, Cat."Adora excused herself again and Catra couldn't help but laugh when she saw mushroom lady's face go even stonier at the blonde's third approach in less than ten minutes. Adora was giving the woman her cheesiest grin, leaning almost completely over

the top of the counter and nodding enthusiastically. Adora chattered away aimlessly as the bartender filled a pint glass with seltzer , then a second one at Adora's request. Catra was pretty sure it was all just an act to get under the worker's nerves a little, but she kinda liked seeing that side of Adora. It was funny when Catra wasn't the one she was trying to vastly irritate.

"She' s gonna spit in your beer when you go up there again." Catra remarked at Adora's return, shaking her head at how the woman was double fisting the drinks, accepting one of them with the other on deck for later. "Tell me she has nothing to do with our food."

"Nah, your chicken is safe, they've got kitchen staff to bring it out. But yeah, that's why I got two glasses for you this time, limit the amount I go up so I don't get decked across the face. Good thing I was only planning on one drink tonight, considering." She arched a brow, a knowing little smirk across her face.

Considering that after a sandwich it would be back to Adora's apartment, house, wherever the butch called home. Catra's stomach fluttered in anticipation, the bubbles from her seltzer doing nothing to calm them. The remainder of her week after the adventures at Top Golf had passed a little too slowly for Catra' s tastes; she certainly didn't want to rush her one vacation a year , but also it was hard to focus on relaxing when memories of Adora's fingers filling her so perfectly as her mouth laved across her neck, biting and sucking dark, claiming marks onto her skin inhabited nearly every corner of Catra's mind. More than once Catra almost broke and checked to see if maybe the other woman could meet up earlier than Friday… But she couldn't seem desperate. They said Friday so she would wait until Friday. Nevermind that Catra made sure to set it for the earliest time she could get away with and still be able to call it dinner.

"I also closed out the tab while I was up there, but honestly , if you decide you want anything more, just holler . Mushroom lady got a more than generous tip, so don't feel too bad." Adora explained, slowing her drinking down now that she was almost halfway through

her beverage. She definitely wanted some of it left to wash down her burger.

"Okay ," Catra nodded, looking around them once more. Nearly every other table was full by this point, all manner of patrons inhabiting them. People obviously just done at the office snagging a drink before heading home, long standing couples out for an early bite, not to mention a few townies who had probably been drinking here since the bar opened at noon that day. A few people were in half-assed costumes, getting into the Halloween spirit early . Right. That was a thing. "Sure as fuck wasnt gonna lose sleep over her . But I can't believe how busy it's gotten."

"Yeah, the Cactus is pretty popular. I usually just pick up take-out, maybe Ill swing by for a pint every couple weeks or so. They do live music on Thursdays and Saturdays, Friday is karaoke." At the suspicious, highly irritated look on the magicat's face, Adora moved quickly to diffuse the situation. "It's not until 7, so relax. People just get here early to get nice and wasted before making asses of themselves. Part of why I was so stoked that you were free at 4:30 today. No chance that well get caught up in that crap."

Catra's tail stopped its frantic lashing, easing back down behind her. At least Grayson showed some good sense. "I'd of fucking walked out the first time I heard some idiot belt out Dont Stop Believin' or Bar of Hearts."

"You and me both, Cat. You and me both."

"All right, I give up. Where's the fucking bathroom in this place?" Catra stopped craning her head around the bar and growled in Adora's direction. It was basically one fucking room, it should not be this difficult to find the place to piss.

Once she had a bit of direction, it wasnt difficult to find. A sign on the wall behind the pool tables pointed towards the hallway with the restrooms. Catra tapped her foot against the ground, claws making an impatient clicking noise against the worn tile. What the fuck kind

of bar only had *one* set of bathrooms though? Adora had said there was another down in the basement, which, wow, great design choice for the stumbling drunks, but it needed a key as it technically was for the employees. Adora offered to grab it since she was that good with the staff (mushroom lady aside), but like hell Catra was going to bring any more attention to the fact she had to pee.

Sighing with an irritated huff that the two doors leading to the neutral restrooms continued to remain locked, Catra looked around her surroundings as she waited. So unlike the Waste, but also some things were just part of dive bars. Faded advertisements for concerts long since passed and sign ups for darts leagues or cornhole tournaments speckled the short hallway where she stood for her turn. And while it was nothing like the pure art on the walls of her bar, random scribbling adorned the plaster here at the Cactus too.

To Catra's left, slightly above eye level, it read *Gabbyisqueer* . Okay, well, good for you, dude. Join the fucking club.

Along the doorframe, written sideways, the wall proclaimed, *For a good time call 6…* Just another guy severely overestimating their own prowess or maybe the juvenile prank of drunkards, scrawling their dumb friend's phone number on the wall. Whatever. Catra didn't bother to read past the area code.

Before she could examine what *Wild Angeline* had decided to imprint upon the wall, because yeah, really fucking badass with that sharpie there Ang, one of the bathrooms finally opened up. Catra shouldered past the person, mentally cursing the inconvenient building design once more.

Minutes later she was back at her table with Adora, the woman nursing her tall beer. Their food had arrived while she was gone, much to Catra's relief. The other patrons seemed to be going all out, possibly since it was the weekend before the dumb holiday, and were getting downright obnoxious. Was it really necessary to scream at the person right next to you? And who the fuck kept playing *Deer* ?

The pair munched at the food in relative silence, at least between the two of them, until halfway through her meal, Adora abruptly stopped chewing and set her burger down on her plate. "You're pretty miserable here, aren't you?"

Catra paused before taking another bite of her admittedly delicious fried chicken sandwich, chewing slowly. "My head hurts." She explained, ear flicking as yet another costumed idiot hollered with tipsy laughter behind her. That was the truth of it. Before things had picked up, her headache was at manageable levels. But the longer she sat in the general chaos, the more it picked up. The discomfort was now a periodic throb, one that not even perfectly crispy, spicy chicken could make up for.

"Why didn't you say something earlier? Look, give me two seconds to flag someone down and I'll get us a couple of to-go boxes." Adora gestured at their mostly full plates. "Then we'll scram."

"What? No, it's fine." Maybe Catra wasn't having the most stellar time, but she wasn't going to be a whiny baby about it. It was a bar. Bars had people. People inherently made things more unpleasant. Such was the way of life. "Don't rush."

"I'm over this, Cat." Adora said plainly, draining the last swig of beer from her glass and standing up from the table. "I really should have thought about the fact it's almost Halloween and the queers would be nuts this weekend. Let's split before any bananas walk in." The woman winked before walking back towards the kitchen.

Catra rolled her eyes heavily at the joke, not at all amused by Adora's little "I'm so cute" smile. "One day at a time" was going to turn into last day ever if the blonde kept it up. She quickly gave in as the warm contralto voice through the jukebox warbled about how if only she could
"*Turn back time*". Sure, the food was good, but it was loud as fuck in here and much like Adora, Catra was over it. She absently stole one of Adora's fries and did her best to tune the room out. If another bar ruined her shot at getting laid tonight...

"I'm ready if you are."Adora said while quickly shoving her half-eaten burger and fries into a box. She moved to do the same to Catra's remaining food and then stopped herself, handing the recyclable container over to the magicat. There was helpful and then there was weird and uncalled for.

Relief hit Catra almost as quickly as the cold fall air did. The difference between the inside and the outside of the bar was staggering, the quiet evening almost smothering with its comfort. Catra shivered next to the entrance of the Cactus, waiting for Adora to catch up to her. She had rushed out of the bar the minute her food was stored, anxious to get away from the increasingly rowdy crowd. Someone had just started to play the Monster Mash and Catra needed *out* .

The taller woman finally appeared, wiggling her way past some other patrons headed out for a smoke on the side of the building. Upon seeing Catra huddled a few steps from the doorway, tail wrapped around her waist and hands tucked in tight against her sides, Adora immediately wrapped an arm around the magicat, doing her best to rub some warmth into her. If she had her jacket still, it would already be around the woman's shoulders. "I'm not parked far ."Adora promised, squeezing once before starting to head that way . As soon as she got there, she could get the truck heating up and make the short ride better for her passenger.

Catra huffed as the arm dropped away and Adora paused midstride, blinking as she registered the cause of the unhappy noise. Wordlessly she replaced her arm back across Catra's shoulders, a foolish grin breaking across her face. Catra's tail thwacked against the back of Adora's legs once, a clear warning to not bring any attention to what had just happened. Like Adora would be *that* stupid.

They walked to the car in silence, warmed against the brisk wind by one another, and Adora quickly stashed their food in the backseat while Catra climbed into the front. The magicat's heart was hammering, a beat to rival how her head had throbbed back in the

bar. She really needed to get a hold of herself, because at the end of the day.Catra wanted this. So much was unclear in their situation or at least as of yet unexplored, but the lingering warmth of Adora's arm against her shoulder, the solid presence of the butch not even a foot from her, and that stupid smile that just wouldn't budge from the blonde's face as they buckled up made the truth irrefutable. She wanted to be with the dummy and no amount of bad music or obnoxious queers or self-sabotaging denial was going to change that. The vice grip of her head was making a valiant effort there for a while, but Catra could overcome anything.

"Sooo,"Adora fiddled with her set of keys for a few seconds before finally placing them into the ignition. She didn't immediately turn over the engine."Where, uh, to?"

"Thought you said tonight was ending 'in your bed'."Catra muttered, hands balled into fists on her thighs. Realizing, she unclenched, but in the wake of her thoughts she couldn't yet bring herself to face the driver. It was so weird being in the front seat with Adora and if that didn't truly sum up how fucked their time in each other's lives really had been.And maybe it had been weeks and was completely all in her head, but Catra could have sworn she smelled traces of their backseat activities all around them. Another tick in the fucked up column that she was strangely comforted by it.

Adora flushed at the memory, a small swell of pride at what had been a very hot moment just a few short days ago. Yeah, she had said that. Meant it too. But if Catra wasn't feeling well, there would be other nights for them. "Well, yeah, but if your head hurts..."

"Just drive, Adora."The headache was already back down to its dull ache, since she was no longer being subjected to the crack of pool cues and raucous chatter of the bar. Catra just had to contend with one fumbling dummy, but she knew what she'd signed up for with that one. Being alone with the woman was what she'd been waiting for all week. "It's not that bad."

"Okay , Cat."Adora fought down a wave of excitement, training her gaze forward and checking all her mirrors as she pulled out onto the street. She definitely wanted to be on her best driving behavior. It was a short trek, really if it had been the summer they might have walked down from her house, but still, part of her couldn't believe this was happening. Catra was finally coming home with her. Adora had made sure to be extra diligent with her cleaning, organizing things that probably didn't really need it, anything to make the hours go faster so that Friday night would finally come.

Switching her schedule with Mara had been worth it in the end, no question about that, but it also made for a very boring week at work to be stuck behind the desk. Things with Catra had reached a peaceful equilibrium so when the magicat had only sent a thumbs up to her "Good morning, see you Friday!"text, Adora hadn't wanted to push it. She managed to hang on and not be the one to text again first, but nearly ended up spilling her afternoon cup of coffee all over some contract she was trying to review when her phone flashed with Catra's name yesterday. She floated through the rest of her work day and was barely present today, daydreaming about seeing the other woman. And now three stop lights and two turns later, Catra was at her home.

"Home, sweet home."Adora said tentatively as she pulled into her driveway. It was such a short drive that her truck just barely fit, but currently the garage was filled with her home gym. She had vague plans of continuing to renovate the basement, a project for the winter once work slowed down. She lost Mara's help early on in Hope's pregnancy, and it was definitely now that the due date was fast approaching, but Adora would get back to it on her first free weekend. Really. "Ready to go inside?"

Catra flicked an ear at the question, certain that it was Adora's way of checking in while absolutely not checking in. Catra hadn't really relaxed during the drive, but she also wasn't entirely wound up either. The music had been kept low and conversation nearly non-existent. Oddly, that combination didn't make for a tense atmosphere

to ride in, more like something closer to anticipatory. It was the steady *clink, clink, clink* up the track of the rollercoaster. Catra could get off at the top, but she'd spent the last few days preparing herself for the plummet down.

She responded to the question by opening her car door and stepping outside. If nothing else, actually leaving the truck before fucking was considerable progress. And if Adora took her against the side of her stupid yellow house, why, they'd be back to exactly where they started with one another!It wasn't quite an alleyway between Adora's house and the neighbor's, but hopefully the people next door weren't too nosy. Because obviously they weren't going to just walk inside and fuck in a bed like normal people. That wasn't *them*.

But as she waited for Adora to finally find the right key for the lock she undoubtedly used multiple times a day, Catra shook off the odd train of thought. Because maybe it could be.

Chapter End Notes

Hey, everyone. Hope you enjoyed this morsel... The summertime is nuts for me work wise. We're encouraged to take every possible hour of overtime that we can and well, I've got a wedding to pay for next year. Unfortunately, that doesn't lend well to creativity/free time. So, I know this one is waaaaaay shorter than my normal, but I love these two silly lesbians and wanted to show my lovely readers that the story isn't dead!The author is just a victim of capitalism.

Hopefully the next update won't take as long. Thank you as always for your patience as I continue to spread myself thin in the real world and on AO3, with my 12 million projects. Until next time, folks.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As soon as they entered the small house, Adora opened a slender door just a few steps away from the front and immediately shrugged out of her thick, maroon cable knit cardigan. She sighed in relief once she was down to just a plain white t-shirt, pulling off her tan Timberlands one at a time and tossing them inside the bottom of the coat closet as well. "Much better. It's hot inside."

Catra stood stiffly by the entrance, clutching her coat against herself. If this was what Adora called hot... Maybe it was just the effect of having been just outside or in a car that really didn't have time to warm up, but the living room was about the room temperature of a freezer. She arched her brow at the sight of Adora's thick arms coming into view, feeling a flicker of warmth stir low in her abdomen, but otherwise remained frozen in place.

"Hey, lemme get your coat." Adora's soft voice cut through her thoughts. The blonde gestured with one free hand, balancing the takeout boxes in the other.

Catra ignored the offer and sauntered into the house with a confidence she did not feel, but damned if she was going to let onto that. She'd gone this far, hadn't she? "Trying to undress me already, Grayson?"

The question hung thickly between them, as much playful banter as it was true suggestion. Adora's eyes were locked on Catra as she passed by, a slow smile creeping up as she felt Catra's tail brush her against her wrist. The low timbre of her voice matched the magicat's as she replied with, "Can you really blame me?"

"Hmm." Catra's hum was appraising, noncommittal, and seemingly disinterested. Her gaze flicked back to where the dummy was still standing, watching her with a lascivious glint to her eye and unbidden, the corner of Catra's mouth crooked up into a smile. "Not really."

"I'm gonna go heat these up," Adora lifted the takeout boxes and pointed to the kitchen area at the far end of the open living room, "but hold onto that thought and *definitely* make yourself at home."

At home, sure. After a moment's pause, debating whether she was really going to let such an interesting train of thought go that easily, Catra padded over to the brown leather couch and settled herself at the opposite end of where it was clear from the worn arm Adora mostly spent her nights. She sat on the very edge of the sofa, tail swishing behind her. A multitude of new scents assaulted her nose, though they were all wrapped up around one central theme: Adora. Which duh, she was in the woman's house, that would follow, but still Catra found herself willing the fur on her arms to lower and her heart rate to decrease. Because she was *in Adora's house* .

It wasn't that she didn't want to be here, after all she wouldn't be if that were the case. It just felt so... anticlimactic somehow . The few times Catra had pictured coming back to Adora's for the first time, she'd always figured she'd be at least half drunk, the pair mindlessly pawing at one another and maybe not even making it further than the front door. So to walk in like that; completely sober , with intention, and just sit down...

And not only that, but to share a meal of all things. Despite the fact that Catra wasn't sure if she was even still hungry or not, here was Adora, off in her kitchen heating up food that probably hadn't even had a chance to perceptibly cool down. It had been a scant twenty minutes since they left the noisy bar, fleeing before any drunk idiots began to bellow at karaoke. And what was the plan then? Eat, maybe on opposite ends of this stupid couch or perhaps at the small, circular table just outside the kitchen? It was all just so... normal.

Catra shook the thought off, the very tip of her tail flicking with supreme irritation at herself. Yes, she was here and it was kind of weird that it wasn't weird at all. But her inner dialogue could just shut up about it already. She slid back on the couch slightly, ear swiveling towards her left at the slight clatter of dishes from the kitchen. Was the dummy really about to use *real* plates? Catra would have just eaten it out of the take-out container as it was.

At a loss of what the hell else to do while Adora puttered around in the kitchen with the remains of their dinner, Catra roamed her eyes over the living room, starting with where she entered. Not much to see by the front door other than the closet and one overzealous houseplant on a stand by a window. The magicat knew jackall about plants, but it looked happy enough, particularly with the small rainbow flag proudly sticking out of its pot. Next to the couch she was seated on was an equally worn dark purple recliner, obviously another favorite seat of the blonde. A half-filled bookcase stood against a wall, unofficially marking where the living room ended and the small dining area off the kitchen began. There were a few scattered books and a handful of small knick knacks along the shelves, including at least three large jar candles that Catra could see from her current spot. Certainly explained the competing smells about the house; lavender, sugar cookies, and something kind of woodsy all culminated together, mixing with the inherent scent that was Adora. Catra really couldn't decide if she liked it or not, but it didn't seem to be making her headache any worse. Yet.

Directly across from the couch was a modest television on a rather obnoxiously large entertainment center. A few video game whatevers sat on the shelves of the stand, along with yet another large, three wick candle. The bottom layer was a dark orange, then a lighter orange, followed by a band of white and topped off with various shades of pink. Catra's back relaxed a little more as she shook her head at another not so subtle nod to the queerness of one Adora Grayson. Even the few movies the homeowner had on her shelves seemed to all be gay. Shocking.

Other than candles and baubles on the bookcase, there wasn't much in the way of decor about the room and Catra had to admit she was surprised. She'd never stopped to ponder the living quarters of the butch very often, but no pictures of friends or family on every surface? Even Catra had a couple of throw pillows on her couch back at her apartment, even if that was all Scorpia's doing. It was at least a little something to bring some life into the room.

Whatever, she wasn't here to judge the woman on her interior decorating skills. Catra was here to... Another louder clatter sounded from the kitchen, along with a soft mutter of "Shit." Really, what the hell was the dumbass up to? Microwaving a couple of picked at sandwiches really couldn't possibly take this long.

Catra turned her head away from the kitchen, glancing over her left shoulder and towards a hallway that undoubtedly led to the remainder of the house. Her eyebrow raised immediately as she registered the only thing resembling true decoration in the whole room. A framed cross stitch hung on the wall near the hallway. It showed a simple log cabin on top of a few rows of dark green Catra suspected was supposed to be grass. A trail of pink hearts zigzagged above the peak of the stitched cabin, each heart growing larger as they ascended high into the sky. It was sickenly cute and idyllic, but Catra snorted loudly as she regarded the rest of the handmade art. In bright blue letters were the words, *"A house is not a home without a strap-on."* A flower border that would be the delight of any grandma framed the words on one side.

If it were possible that someone could still be questioning whether a lesbian lived here even after making it past the rainbow flag in the plant by the door or the pride candle by the TV, the quaint craft on the wall would be the final clue.

"Here," Adora re-entered the living room, carrying a tray loaded up with condiments, silverware, and two plates of food. Two circular red pills and a tall glass of water were nestled next to the remains of Catra's chicken sandwich and waffle fries. "Advil. Unless you want Excedrin, think I have a few in my work bag out in my truck." Her

blue eyes glanced thoughtfully in the direction of the driveway, trying to recall what she had stashed to be able to make it through her work day.

"Fucking hell, you take The Bag to work every day , don't you?" Catra teased, swallowing down the offered ibuprofen with a long drink of water. Now just give her twenty minutes and she'd be good to go. "Just always have to be prepared to please."

"Different bag. Though the one you're referring to would make you feel even better." The woman winked and a slow , sly grin creeped up across her face. "And pretty sure you like my need to please."

"Idiot." Catra rolled her eyes heavily , even as she felt her stomach flip pleasantly at the memories their banter had awoken. Hands, mouth, strap; how soon could they get to Adora using any (or shit, *all*) of those in her effort to please? Catra let herself relax into the couch fully, knowing the fastest way to get where she wanted them to be was to just roll with it. Let Adora have her little moment of sharing this supposedly earth-shattering meal with her and then they could turn to other matters. It was no different than having a drink together at the bar before the couple other times that they had hooked up. And that hadn't always been *completely* terrible so…

Catra reviewed the spread the woman had thrown together for them, shaking her head. Three different kinds of barbeque sauce for an already dressed and half eaten sandwich? Ketchup, ranch dressing, hot sauces... It was all so extra and obviously trying *way* too hard. The dummy settled in with her own plate on the other end of the couch and Adora immediately tucked into the remains of her burger. She made periodic happy noises as she chewed, which on anyone else would be completely annoying and would utterly kill Catra's appetite. But instead she just started to pick at what was left of her own meal.

"Thanks for the pills." Catra eventually broke the quiet that surrounded them as they ate. It wasn't all that uncomfortable, but the longer she sat on Adora's couch, growing more accustomed to the

setting and just being with the woman, the more Catra's mind continued to wander towards the upcoming after dinner activities. Maybe she hadn't made it far into the woman's house, but undoubtedly, Adora had a bed here somewhere. A bed that she had been *commanded* to be in tonight. That particular recollection was enough to make her shiver, her gaze flicking over to the woman on the other side of the couch. Catra was over this part of the night and more than ready to get under Adora for the next. Still, earlier nagged at her; one night of great sex had already been ruined by her behavior at a bar and now that her temples no longer throbbed unmercifully, even Catra wasn't fool enough to risk it happening a second time. "Sorry I've been such a bitch tonight."

"Have you?" Adora asked, chewing thoughtfully. She frowned and shook it off with a shrug. "I didn't really noticed. I mean, I know the Cactus was a bust, but that's on me. I really wasn't thinking about how busy it would be with the holiday and all. I hope it's not completely blacklisted for you. It can be a really fun place."

"It was fine." Catra returned the shrug, inwardly rolling her eyes. Leave it to Adora to not even think twice about her needlessly cranky mood earlier. She didn't want it to continue or let anything damper the rest of the evening. She set her plate on the coffee table, the meal as finished as it ever was going to be. It was tasty and all, but Catra had something much more filling in mind.

"Oh, you're done?" Adora paused, almost guiltily staring at how much she still had left. She was normally a very fast eater, more so than she should be, but she liked to savor this particular meal.

Catra nodded, side eyeing Adora as unobtrusively as she could. She wasn't sure if Adora was more concerned with Catra's comfort or taking her time with her meal, but she assumed it was the former. After all, Catra was already as relaxed as she could be for as long as her clothes remained on her body. And if Adora wanted to make her more comfortable... well, Catra was pretty damn keen to get to the part of the evening where she *could* relax further. And surely Adora

wasn't too dumb to realize that while her leftovers would still be there tomorrow, Catra was less inclined to sit around before being eaten.

"W as it okay? I got a few other things out there that I could fix up for you if you're still hungry . Or-..."

"Adora." Catra' s voice was firm as she interrupted the blonde's fussing.

"Mmm?"

"I'm *fine* ." The magicat stressed the word, letting her shoulders drop and finally shrugging off her coat. She tossed it towards the recliner; it was close enough to the front closet. Her fur prickled uncomfortably as the cool air of the living room hit her, the low neckline of her shirt momentarily an iffy choice. But as Adora stopped looking towards the kitchen and finally started looking at her, Catra knew it was worth the risk of frostbite.

Adora immediately set down her plate and took a quick drink of her water to rinse her mouth, her eyes never once leaving the expanse and sharp dips of Catra's collarbone. A smirk immediately sprung to her lip as she raked her gaze over the magicat' s sudden display of skin. "Fine, hmm?"

Adora's voice had dropped low, slowly wetting her lips as she continued to stare at Catra intently. She had shifted on the couch, and in the right direction, but was still too far away for Catra's liking. Catra took a long sip of her water, purposefully ignoring Adora's leading inquiry about her state of being. She studied the titles of the movies in the entertainment stand, not really able to read a single word as she felt the other woman's eyes on her. Her ear flicked subconsciously in Adora's direction as the presence on the other end of the couch moved a little closer once more.

"Just fine?" Adora ventured out again, she was still on her own seat cushion, though just barely . That insufferable smirk was back across her face as she waited for Catra to respond. Her hunger had

switched focus however, so mere seconds later, she crooned out, "Nothing I could do to make you more *comfortable*?"

Catra's tail flicked at the question, eyebrow raising an almost imperceptible amount. She briefly considered continuing to ignore the woman, curious about the lengths Adora would go to gain her attention. But Catra also wasn't going to run the risk of continuing to sound like a bad porno and left to her own devices, who knew what sort of things Adora might say? She couldn't risk the mood being destroyed even before it could really begin. "Get your ass over here, dummy. Now."

Adora complied without hesitation, though Catra could have done without the wholly satisfied little chuckle that came with it. Within seconds she was next to Catra, her arm wrapping around the magicat in what was inevitably the most cheesy move out there. So why did a purr threaten to stir in her chest the moment Adora's hand touched her shoulder, a jolt of excitement striking through her body the second that she could feel the heat from the woman's fingers?

"Better?" Adora asked lightly, already certain of the answer.

"Shut up." Catra pulled the woman in by her shirt collar, now completely done with any games. She'd gone to Adora's bar, she'd made herself comfortable in the woman's house, and they'd more or less enjoyed a meal together. It was time for Adora to make good on her promise that tonight would end in her bed. Not to mention shut her mouth already, or at least busy it doing something more interesting....

Adora allowed herself to be drawn into the kiss, more than a little excited by how blatant Catra's want was from the moment she drew near to her. Catra was moving quickly, hungrily pressing against her lips and though her hands hadn't loosened their grip against Adora's shirt collar in the slightest, Adora couldn't deny the pressure around her neck was bringing this to new heights. Her hands came to instinctively rest upon Catra's hips and without breaking their kiss,

the magicat was suddenly in her lap, her long, lithe legs wrapped around Adora's middle.

Adora realized her hands had moved to squeeze Catra's ass, both women groaning in great appreciation of the action and as difficult as it was to not get lost in the feel of her lips, the brush of her tongue and the point of her fang, Adora purposefully slowed her response. The woman was here at her house, finally, and she intended to take her time. She would savor every moment that she had Catra against her, under her, and show her that being in a space where Adora could be intentional would indeed be worth her time. With no small amount of effort, the blonde guided them into a much slower, more deliberate pace, her fingertips resting against Catra's chin as they kissed. Adora couldn't help but laugh at the huff of satisfied protest Catra gave once it was made clear who was actually in charge tonight.

Catra surrendered to the soft lips and languid pace, gave into the feel of Adora's thick fingers caressing her jaw as their mouths slid together. Her hands settled along the strong back of the butch, up near her shoulderblades, lost in the memory of how easily they supported her against that wall during their first meeting. She shivered at the recollection and curled her fingers into the muscle, claw tips not quite pressing into her skin. Adora's pace picked up slightly at the increase, a low groan coming from the woman holding her. Catra was desperate to feed into that moan and skated her claws down Adora's back, the blonde sitting upright more, grasping her ass and pulling Catra forward. She was good and truly pressed up against Adora now, the position giving more purchase for Catra's hands to wander along the hardened dips of her back muscles. Fuck. She was certain that even Adora's dumb senses would be able to smell how turned on she was already, but as Catra reached the hem of the blonde's t-shirt, she really couldn't care less. Adora was hot and a good lay;what more needed said?

Adora flinched as Catra's fingertips grazed under her shirt. She was used to the woman's touch burning in its wake, but this was different.

She leaned her forehead against Catra's and between heavy breaths asked, "Are you cold?"

Catra huffed as their languorous kisses were broken and her exploration of that delicious sliver of Adora's skin was interrupted even before she really got to start. Dummy, breaking her concentration. "Well, it is fucking freezing in here." She leaned in and captured Adora's lips for her own again, satisfied by the moan the nip of her fangs against the blonde's bottom lip had garnered. "Warm me up."

It was somewhere between a question and a command and one that Adora met eagerly. She came back and kissed her with even more fervor than Catra had displayed, hands encircling the small of the woman's waist and guiding her to lay back against the couch. Catra arched into each press of her mouth, pulling Adora closer, only content once the butch was settled over top of her just as they had been the other day on that much more cramped Top Of couch. Except this time, there was no chance of interruption nor any need to stay quiet. Catra whined as Adora began trailing down her jaw, leaving a path of burning kisses. The sound turned into a sharp inhale as Adora hovered over her pulse point, working a large, dark mark that was sure to even be visible against her tawny complexion. The weight of the butch's body as she worked her way down certainly was warming Catra up quickly.

Adora's mouth reached the top of her collarbone and though the neckline of her shirt was cut low, she soon found that being above the material was simply not enough contact. The blonde scooted her large frame down Catra's torso, the magicat automatically parting her legs to welcome her. They were both certainly flexible enough, that had been demonstrated in spades, contorting every which way in the back of Adora's truck, but as each had to reposition along the couch to shuffle how they needed to be, Adora paused. They had much better options available to them this time. They needed to move to a place where she could actually have some damn room to work.

With her head resting just between the apex of Catra's thighs and the bottom of her stomach, Adora glanced up, catching Catra's multi-hued gaze, how her eyes were blown wide and just the tiniest kiss of a blush made the freckles along her cheeks stand out, and in a heady, thick voice saturated with want, Adora remarked, "The bedroom's warmer."

The intention was clear in those words and Catra truthfully wanted to sprint from the couch, pulling Adora along and finally getting what she wanted. But the blonde was already between her legs, gazing at her with such undisguised desire. Catra couldn't help the smirk that curled across her lips. "That's your best line?"

"Not a chance." Adora laughed softly, leaning down even lower. She felt Catra tense as her mouth hovered over her center, eyes flicking up with a single brow raised. "It's a pretty good one, but you *know* I can do better."

"Oh, yeah, that W e doing this?was *so* smooth and-"

Catra squeaked as Adora pressed her mouth against her pussy. Her leggings did very little to block the promise of the butch's warm mouth. The asshole was laughing, just a soft chuckle that melded into a lazy smile at Catra's *perfectly justified* reaction.

Catra was somewhere between calling an Uber to take her home and shoving Adora's mouth back where it belonged, but before she could make up her mind on which way to go, Adora sat up, her hands once again coming to rest on Catra's hips. She thumbed lightly as she spoke, "W orked, didn't it? But in all seriousness. My bedroom is smaller and I've got a fireplace I can light up. I want you to be comfortable when you're here."

Catra's ear flicked at the words and she willed her face to remain blank. Something about Adora's words made it seem as if she expected this to be a regular occurrence. That was perhaps not entirely farfetched;maybe neither one had made any *promises* to the other, but if Adora showed her a good enough time, Catra wouldn't

be opposed. The thrill of being caught in public was a thing, but she was interested in testing just how good the butch could work in private.

Adora interrupted her thoughts with a wink and a grin that showed just how cute this dummy really thought she was. "C'mon, Cat. We're doing this?"

"Bedroom. Now ." Catra answered shortly , not for one second allowing herself to admit that Adora was pretty damn cute...even when she was being a coy little shit.

Adora rose from her kneeled position between Catra's legs with surprising grace, offering a hand down to help the other woman up. She ignored it and motioned for Adora to move along already. Catra might be able to stand just fine right now , but Adora had better make it so she couldn't *walk* by the end of the night.

The blonde shrugged and moved towards the hallway, Catra only a step behind her. She led them a short distance and into the first room on the right, closing the door behind them. Once inside she crossed over and turned on the lamp on her bedside table. "Just give me a minute here to get the fireplace going."

Catra entered the room cautiously, though a low thrum of excitement pounded in her chest. Finally. As the dummy busied herself with making it a remotely inhabitable temperature, Catra glanced around the inner sanctum of the butch. Once again, little in the way of decor, though Catra purred in appreciation of the king bed in the center of the room. Maybe the dark gray duvet with the lighter gray throw was a little monotone, but she couldn't argue with the size. She could be bent every which way across this massive thing.

Her tail flicked in impatience as she tried to judge how much longer Adora would be. She supposed the delay was worth it, particularly once clothing was removed. An ounce of patience now to gain a few good inches later…

As she waited, not quite ready to just throw herself onto the bed yet, Catra's eyes caught the sight of a large black armoire next to a crouching Adora fiddling with the still dark fireplace. Not uncommon for a bedroom to have by any means, but placed atop the dresser was a brick. Strange on its own, but the brick also had three obnoxiously large dildos sticking out from some holes that had been bored through the building block. It was pure horrified curiosity that made Catra cross over to get a closer look.

She found it made even less sense up close. Her ears flattened as she surveyed it; a regular-ass terra cotta brick with a smattering of names scrawled across it? As much as she feared the answer, Catra found herself spitting out, "What the fuck is this?"

"Purity brick." Came the disinterested reply, as if that answered everything. Adora's eyes had barely flicked over to her left to verify what Catra was asking about, as engrossed as she was in getting the fire lit. She had a tiny ember, but it was a delicate process to feed enough gas to avoid a great whoosh of flame, though keep it steady enough to stay lit. She really should get someone to update it one of these days, but... Dont fix what aint (completely) broke was her justification of protecting the charm of old houses like hers.

"That tells me absolutely fucking nothing, but you know what, I dont think I want to know." Catra mumbled, crossing her arms over her chest.

"Church camp thing," Adora supplied, distracted by watching the flame she was trying to cultivate. "Whole big ass ceremony and they gave each of the young women a fucking brick at the end. Supposed to go to our husbands on our wedding day- something about how our virginity was the foundation of a happy marriage? Whatever. Thought about tossing it in the lake, but I found other uses for it." Finally satisfied with her work, the tall woman stood and moved near to where Catra was standing. "You can sign it too, if you want."

Catra almost couldnt believe how nonchalant Adora sounded about the whole thing, even if it also felt completely in line with some of the

shit religious places tried to pull. Sign her brick, the idiot *had* to be joking. But as Catra reviewed the names and sensual sentiments left behind by the people who had contributed to Adora's crumbled, virginal foundations, she knew there was no chance of that.

Tearing her eyes away after seeing one person had written *Good scromping!* before signing their single initial on the brick, Catra's penchant for punishment only continued when she asked, "You dont use *those*, right?" She gestured to the impressive length of each piece mounted on the brick, shifting uncomfortably on her heels. Might as well hear the whole gory truth while she was getting this fascinating look into the butch's life, not to mention set a few boundaries about how many inches she was willing and able to take.

"What? No! It's *art*."

"Right. Art. Like the cross stitch in the living room?" Catra raised an eyebrow.

Adora smiled in spite of herself, a rueful little grin. "Queer Craft Night is a lot of fun, you should check it out some time." At the less than impressed look on the other woman's face, Adora moved back to the original subject, gesturing below the homemade art installation and to the armoire properly. "Anyway, my functional pieces are in the first and second drawers."

Catra relaxed at the news, though her tail swished back and forth at the information. Multiple dresser drawers full of… "Fucking hell, how many do you own?" She stared in disbelief at the array of apparatuses suddenly on view as Adora pulled open the top drawer.

"I told you once that I had options." Adora shrugged, looking over her collection with no small amount of pride. It just sort of had grown over the years. A sale here, a new feature she simply had to make sure was in her arsenal there. Some were used more than others, but each had a special place in her heart. And in her harness. "Pick one if you see one you like. I can switch with what I've already got on."

Catra stared at the open drawer, her stomach plting at the contents within. All matter of shapes, arranged by size and thickness, and more colors than a pride parade;it was overwhelming. Af fecting an air of calm she certainly did not feel in the presence of so many toys that undoubtedly Adora knew how to wield and wield well, not to mention the reminder that Adora was *already* packing, Catra looked away and mumbled, "Whatever . All the same to me."

Adora had seen how Catra's eyes had gone wide and couldnt help but notice how her tail was lashing wildly back and forth as the woman roved over the collection. She inched forward carefully, pointing out a few choice pieces. "If you say so, but you couldnt be more wrong. Different tools for different jobs, babe. Like this one hits *deep* , especially if youre on top, and this one." Adora' s eyes fell almost tenderly to a shorter, though almost unreasonably thick purple strap. "She vibrates."

Catra's ear flicked. She honestly couldnt decide which one of these stars in Adora's impressive collection sounded better. Maybe if they hurried up and got to it already, shed have the opportunity to sample a few tonight. It was still early;they could get a few rounds in. "Just pick your favorite. Ill take whatever you give me."

Adora's pulse quickened at the low rasp as Catra continued to review the contents of her cabinet. She moved behind the woman, loosely wrapping her arms around Catra's waist, pulling the woman in so her back was plastered against Adora's front. Once there, she leaned in and whispered, "Y es, you will."

Catra shivered at the warm press of Adora's lips brushing against her neck and the steel in her voice. Yes, this was what she wanted. Adora's hands moved up from her waist, resting against her stomach. She worked her mouth along the side of Catra's neck, making her way towards the base of her sensitive ear. Catra tilted her head for better access, the rumbling purr that kicked up the moment Adora came near giving her away entirely. That quiet assertion, the feel of Adora's mouth working in tandem as the woman's hands traveled along her sides... Catra was irritated and

enthralled by the whole thing. She was absolutely toying with her and Catra was loving every minute.

"Turn around."

Catra bit her lip as the faint whisper hit her ear. Though part of her wanted to ignore the command, thrilled by the prospect of riling the butch further, she knew it was in her best interest to obey. Catra turned so she was facing Adora full on, her tail coming to wrap around the taller woman's thigh.

"Good girl," Adora's voice was a gossamer brush, running her thumb over Catra's bottom lip as she held her gaze. "Go to the bed."

So many ways to play this, but Catra settled on the most rewarding path. It was only a few steps to the bed, though she could feel Adora's eyes watching her the entire way, hence the extra sway to her hips and how her tail swung lazily back and forth. Once there, Catra weighed her options. She was excited, her panties already feeling uncomfortably damp as she waited for Adora to join her at the bedside. It didn't take long. Adora resumed her position in front of Catra, her fingers trailing along the hem of the other woman's shirt. Now it was her turn to just barely tease the sliver of skin and soft fur that had been revealed. Catra moaned as Adora's teeth grazed her bottom lip, arching into the pleasant pressure of the woman's fingertips. When Adora did not move further, only continued to kiss her, her hands now slotted firmly over her hips, Catra reached down to begin pulling her own shirt off. If the dummy was going to continue to be a *tease* about the whole thing…

The material had barely lifted an inch before Adora's hands replaced her own, slowly lifting the shirt up and away. The blonde was transfixed as Catra was stripped, her eyes falling immediately to her chest and the lacy black bra that cupped Catra's breasts. Catra was emboldened by the undisguised and unashamed hunger in the gaze. Adora *wanted* her.

And she wanted Adora.

With that admission driving her, Catra again pulled on Adora's shirt collar, bring the butch back into a heated kiss. Her hands moved to the back of Adora's neck, claw tips gently arching upwards, just enough that Catra was granted a deep moan from the woman she was kissing so passionately. She gave a slight tug down, just enough to encourage the thought that they should be horizontal now. To her great satisfaction, Adora leaned into the touch, drawing them both onto the bed without breaking their kiss.

The pair lay side by side across the mattress, hands wandering and limbs hooking together. Catra was pleased that they seemed to be getting somewhere and the longer she felt the press of Adora's strap against her thigh, the butch's heat and hard muscles flexing beneath her hands. The more she needed to fuck this handsome woman.

With that thought, Catra slid over top of Adora, bracketing her legs on either side of Adora's hips so the butch was in a loose pin. Adora smirked into their kiss as her back pressed against the mattress, hands splaying down Catra's waist as they moved into the new position. From there they traveled up to deftly unhook the other woman's bra with two fingers. Catra purred as her tits came free, the smooth straps sliding down her arms, the article quickly tossed to a corner of the room.

"Fuck." Adora softly exhaled, eyes not leaving the view of Catra straddled atop of her, topless, all but sticking her chest in her face, daring the woman to lick and bite all around them.

"That's the idea." Catra's tail flicked wildly behind her, certain she had to be soaked through her underwear entirely by this point. Adora groaned as she rolled her hips down, a wicked smile across her face. Her excitement only grew as she heard the butch fumble with her belt, hastily unclasping so she could shuck off her jeans. Catra watched from atop her perch, unembarrassed to admit that the sound of the buckle coming undone was enough to make her practically drool and grind herself even harder against the solid press of the woman's abs. The fever only grew when Adora quickly

removed her t-shirt and Catra was left to feast upon the sight of her chiseled stomach.

Adora quirked a smile at Catra's quip, now down to just her boxer briefs and half-binder. "Mmmm, sure is, babe. As much as I love the sight of you, tits out and riding me, why don't we switch and I can get to it?"

A thoroughly enticing prospect to have Adora on top of her once more, but as Catra slid down the length of the blonde's body, an overwhelming rush hit her. She would get hers tonight, but first... "Is that what you *really* want?"

Adora swallowed, not quite able to bring herself to speak as Catra settled herself much lower along her body.

"Gotta say, this constant 'give, give, give' is very self-sacrificing of you and all, but I'm sure I can think of something you'd like much more." Her eyes flicked down to the bulge in Adora's boxers, unconsciously licking her lips. Maybe the back of her truck after the alley had just been a fluke and Catra would find that silicone was a pretty neutral dessert, but from the way her clit throbbed just at the thought. "So you can drop the act already."

Even as Catra's hand moved, grabbing around her strap through her boxers, stroking and pushing the base down against her, Adora seized a little at the words. Catra didn't mean anything by it, but it stuck at her and Adora found that she couldn't quite get into the feeling. As she shifted away from Catra's touch and placed a hand on her wrist to stop the other woman's motions, her voice came out eerily quiet. "It's not an act."

Catra's smile faded, a cold streak going through her stomach. It instantly chilled the heat that was building as she felt Adora pull away, leaving her feeling as though she were teetering on the edge of a precipice. Her words fell first, drifting away from her. "I..."

Adora continued on, trying to catch Catra's eye. She was firm on this point, too many years spent figuring out what actually worked for her and was comfortable for *her* . Too many times bending herself to be what she thought was ‘normal'. "I dont just get you of f because I feel like I have to or something. I *really* like taking care of my partner. Im not like, secondary or anything like that. Making you come as many times as I possibly can just does it for me. I dont really need much myself."

"Okay , but you gotta admit that it's been a little one-sided. With us." Catra swallowed, her voice equally quiet. Her eyes were trained on the slightly scuffed hardwood floors of her host's bedroom, tracing the swirling patterns of the dark grain. "I'm not complaining, but I havent really gotten to. Not since the car .

"And I liked sucking you of f. A lot. It turned me on." Catra whispered the admission, not giving Adora the chance to break her stride. Her cheeks turned rosy, arms crossing over her chest to cover herself. She hadnt been expecting this kind of heart-to-heart discussion with the blonde, not when she was half naked and trying to get laid, though the fact Adora wanted to give her endless orgasms was certainly promising. Maybe it was just like finishing dinner and Catra needed to see it through.

"It turns me on too." Adora said firmly , running her hand down Catra's arm in a reassuring manner. She relaxed when Catra unfolded her arms at her touch. "A lot."

"Okay ." It helped to hear Adora say it, even if Catra was still feeling a little twisted by this unexpected bank to the left, unable to meet the gaze of the person she was still inexplicably straddling.

After a few beats of uncertain silence, Adora's hand dropped to enclose around Catra's much smaller one, giving it a squeeze. "Catra? I really do like when we do that." A self-ef facing grin passed over her face, more than a little flushed. *Liking it* was the understatement of the century; if Mara knew just how frequently Adora's mind drifted towards the image of this sinful woman, mouth

around her strap, bright cerulean eye winking at her as Catra took more and more with every bob of her head. "Joint ownership of the business or not, her cousin would drop her from the payroll for all the missed hours. Probably make Adora pay her back for them too. "But I want to be clear; sometimes I'm only going to be interested in taking care of you. More than sometimes. Frequently. And repeatedly. It's definitely not an 'act.' When you suck me off, I'm not in it for the, ah, *release*? I just think it's hot. That *you're* hot."

Catra's ear twitched, interest rising as she felt Adora's appreciative gaze rove over her. Not particularly surprising information given how their hook-ups had gone thus far. And maybe it wasn't how she operated, but Catra didn't really need to *get* it, just accept it. "Fine by me. I'm sure as fuck not complaining here that you *want* to get me off as much as possible. Just don't want anyone to think I'm… selfish." Her stomach roiled briefly at the word. Maybe Catra had heard that descriptor a time or two when she thought good times were being had all around. Maybe it stung and stuck with her longer than it should. Maybe-. She cut off her own stupid train of thoughts before they could lose any more of the night. Looking Adora head on, Catra lightly ran her tongue over her bottom lip and murmured, "It's as much for me as it is for you."

Adora exhaled slowly before nodding, utterly transfixed as the woman atop her shifted, Catra's hips bracketing her own. Talking was good; talking was partially how the pair had finally managed to end up in Adora's bedroom rather than some dim alley or cramped backseat. But it was getting all the harder to focus on talk when Catra just went around the world looking like *that* all the time. "I don't think you're selfish. Not at all. I love fucking you Catra, you're so sexy and god." Adora trailed off, eyes roving lower down her body, settling to where she could feel Catra's heat coming through her leggings, poised against Adora's stomach. Those needed to come off.

Catra flushed under the darkened gaze, aware how all parts of her were perking to attention by it. Adora's hand moved from holding her

own, now skimming along the tops of her leggings, suggestive little swipes. Pleasant, but Catra knew what she wanted, if Adora was okay with it that is. "So, uh, is this one of those times when you're interested in my mouth? Or just my pussy?" There was a potential for some disappointment, but either way, Catra could adjust. It's not like there was exactly any *losing* in this situation. Oh boo hoo, the handsome butch wanted to fuck her most of the time. Cue the world's tiniest violin. And even if Catra ruined even that for herself completely, running her mouth like she had, that was okay too. The headache was mostly gone, but it wouldn't hurt her to head to her own apartment, maybe get some more sleep. Her vacation week wasn't over yet, so perhaps tomorrow after some time and a better apology...

"You do want me *bad*, don't you?" Adora smirked, thumb now hooked fully under the waistband of Catra's pants. She didn't miss the way the woman sat up taller as her fingers explored, a small noise of appreciation garnered when two of Adora's fingers wrapped around her hips as well. She certainly felt it when Catra began to grind down softly again in response to Adora's hands caressing all along her sides.

"You? No." Catra's breath hitched when Adora traveled up, her thumb brushing against Catra's hardened nipple. Instinctively she beared down harder against the prone blonde, Adora's muscles bunching under her. With a growl born of her impatient desire, Catra asked, "Do you want sucked off first or not?"

"Hmmm." Adora pretended to think it over, fingers of one hand gliding over Catra's tits, feeling how perfectly each fit in the palm of her hand. The little whine that Catra gave as Adora moved was easily the most delicious thing she'd had all night; Adora wanted to glut herself on the woman, devote herself to spending the whole night bringing Catra over and over again... Far be it from her to deny this beauty anything she truly wanted. "Have you kiss it before it fucks you. Yeah, I think I can work with that." Adora capped things off

with a smile that was almost lazy, utterly indulgent, and more than just a little impressed with herself.

Catra's tail lashed, though the rest of her body stilled. The cocky asshole was just trying to be funny, but Adora could hold on to that command for the future…

"Oh. You liked that one, didn't you?" Adora blinked through her surprise before her smile turned devilish. Her hand was now fully down Catra's pants, squeezing the woman's firm ass. She could *feel* how much Catra enjoyed it through her leggings.

Catra's eyes were blown wide as she sat with herself for a moment, damn near catching her breath. It was almost embarrassing how much this handsome idiot turned her on. Every instinct was telling her to deny it, do anything to wipe that smug grin off this dummy's face. But her first instincts really hadn't done much to serve her in the recent past. And Adora would *absolutely* serve her tonight. Catra took another moment's pause, then replied with a resoundingly thick, "Yes."

The air around them grew charged again, expectant and wanting. Adora reached up, running a single knuckle down Catra's cheek and whispering, "Good girl. Why don't you show me just how much?"

The butch drew the other woman down and close, pressing a bruising kiss to Catra's lips, each moaning heavily into the sensation. Even with what they both knew was coming next, it was hard for them to halt their kisses, too drunk on each other's mouths. Catra really couldn't say how, but somehow Adora had managed to strip her leggings off, the blonde's hands deftly working the skintight material off of her. She only realized once she registered only a thin silky layer left between her and the vast heat radiating off Adora's body. With great effort, also near unbearable anticipation of things to come (and come and come), Catra positioned herself down onto the hardwood floor. Adora sucked in a breath, stomach jolting at the sight of the gorgeous woman below her. She stood, the toy straining against the snug material. It had taken some thought earlier, O-ring

boxers for comfort or the traditional harness, but there was just something about the soft leather and bright gold buckles of Adora's favorite harness that just screamed "I'm here to woo."…

Wordlessly, Adora slid her boxers down, smirking openly at the small whine Catra gave at its reveal. She kicked the underwear away and stood tall, waiting. Adora saw the other woman readjust, evening the pressure between her knees, Catra's mismatched eyes level with the dark red, almost bordering on purple, strap. It was a striking color, unlike anything else in Adora's collection and she almost chuckled at the realization that Catra's lace panties were near the same shade. A rich burgundy that just garnered attention from first view. It certainly had the brunette transfixed, though Adora saw the barest hint of hesitation cross the other woman's face, but after a quick glance up and a nod to proceed, Catra's gaze was now shining with lust, bright and excited.

Catra gave a small shudder the moment it touched her lips. She welcomed the strap into her mouth eagerly, moaning softly. Just as before there was no discernible taste, the scent of Adora's arousal filled her nose, intensifying the whole experience. She took more of it, as much as she could, the strap pressing against the back of her throat. She began to pull back slowly, working her way back up the toy. As Catra moved her mouth, she flicked her gaze upwards, wanting to see the look on the woman's face as she pleasured her.

Adora hissed a sharp breath as their eyes met. Gods, Catra was gorgeous always, but now, positioned in between Adora's legs, mouth working her cock. "Fuck, you're beautiful." It came out as a breathy moan, with undisguised wonder and bare affection lacing every syllable.

Catra shuddered at the compliment, eyes closing in libidinous contentment. She could hear the other woman's breathing grow more and more labored as she continued to move, Adora's hips lightly rocking with the rhythm of her mouth. Catra had always enjoyed it in the past when partners had used her mouth for their pleasure, but there was something even more alluring about doing

this. Adora was so expressive, every new motion gaining Catra a new noise and moan of vast appreciation for her efforts. And when the blonde's hand came to fist through her hair, encouraging Catra further, the woman on her knees could feel the wetness dripping down her thighs in response.

Adora felt another six months of productivity at work slip away at the image of Catra so ardently sucking her off, the woman's hands coming up to grip around the base and make absolutely certain that Adora was getting the best show possible. It was so hot, Catra so sexy, Adora just needed to... She hooked her fingers under Catra's jaw, roughly pulling her away from the toy. The woman grunted at the change, Catra's breathing heavy and uneven, eyes glazed over with want.

"On the bed."

Catra heard the words dimly, blood rushing in her fervor to obey. She had barely stood upright before Adora descended on her, the taller woman biting and kissing against her neck, hands feverish in their attempt to feel all of her body at once. The switch was abrupt, momentarily jarring, but when Adora wanted, she *got*. With no real memory of whether she laid down herself or was thrown onto the bed in a lust-driven haste, Catra laid back, chest heaving, skin flushed, and utterly burning with desire. Her mouth was aching with pleasure as Adora had so eagerly fucked it, the blonde's hands pulling her forward to take more and more with each thrust of her hips. It had been agony for Catra to resist dipping a hand underneath her underwear, fingering her throbbing center as she sucked hard on the toy. To come with Adora's strap down her throat...

"Sit up." Adora barely waited for the woman to rise before pulling Catra to the edge of the bed and sinking low before her. Though they had switched places, Catra felt somehow less in control, absolutely willing and *wanting* to hand over everything to the handsome, skilled butch that was sure to take good, good care of her. The noises she was making as Adora stared at her hungrily were almost appalling in nature and she hadn't even been *touched* yet.

Catra's underwear came off slowly, the silky material peeling away from her soaked and heated core, stained even darker with her wetness. Adora hummed in approval of her state, placing open-mouthed kisses along the inside of her thighs. Catra winced at every pull of the woman's lips and groaned heavily as she felt Adora nip and tease her way up closer to her need. Catra surrendered to the feel, clenching on nothing, wanting so desperately to be filled, but also in no rush for this to end. She'd waited days for the opportunity to be Adora's once more and would indulge herself in every possible second.

Hovering just over Catra's pussy, just as she had been out on the couch, Adora gave one long appraising look of the naked woman in front of her, from Catra's soaked folds up to her toned stomach, pebbled nipples and flushed cheeks. The curve of her neck was covered in the results of Adora's expert attention, her long hair tousled and wild, softening her sharp angles with a feral beauty. She was stunning always, but this. With a salacious, unwavering gaze and her voice a solemn, lewd prayer Adora promised, "I'm going to ruin you."

Before Catra could even formulate a reply, not that she had much to say to *that* , Adora buried her head between Catra's thighs, the receiving woman near screaming with pleasure from the first moment the butch licked up, long and slow, letting her tongue come to a point directly against Catra's swollen, needy clit. She flicked her tongue back and forth in steady, controlled motions as Catra's moans grew more wild and desperate with every pull. Every swirl and lash of her tongue built Catra up higher and higher until the woman's hands were both fisted through Adora's short hair, tugging roughly, with all manner of filthy praise streaming from her lips. Sensing her approaching peak, Adora wrapped her lips to suck gently. The change had Catra bucking her hips into the sensation, urgent and rough. Adora's strong hands came to hold her in place, steel biceps wrapped firmly along the outside of Catra's thighs.

Being so effectively pinned only made each second that Adora spent between her legs licking and sucking all the more electrifying. Catra wouldn't, couldn't, last much longer like this, not with the precision and skill the butch was using against her. Not when Catra knew it was this handsome, good, achingly-and-confusingly sweet person bringing her to new planes of existence with just her mouth. Catra's thighs squeezed around Adora's ears and with a high pitched, shuddering wail, white-hot relief poured outward from her. Adora's tongue slowed to a lazy pace, unwilling to part from the delectable taste of the woman as the last few shockwaves of orgasm threaded through Catra's body.

It could have been seconds or hours later before Catra's awareness fully fluttered back. At some point during her resurrection, Adora must have turned off the bedside lamp so that they could better enjoy the glow of the fireplace. Just like the tray of condiments earlier, it was so completely extra, but Catra just let herself have the moment as a treat. Her body was pleasantly awash with a cocktail of feel-good chemicals and a healthy thrum of arousal still remained, made all that more salient as Adora kissed her lightly and Catra tasted herself on the other woman's lips. Despite how warm the bedroom was from the robust fire that crackled merrily in the background, Catra shivered and pulled Adora closer to her.

"Mmm, I can tell someone's not done here." Adora murmured over her lips, breaking the return to several long minutes of searing kisses.

"That was a decent start, but-..." The word flickered in the back of Catra's mind. *Pitiful* .

"Since you're all nice and wet for me," At the proclamation, two of Adora's fingers slipped beneath Catra's curls as if needing to verify for herself. Catra hissed at the brush, sensitive and still agonizingly turned on. She rocked up into the touch, silently begging the butch to go lower and fill her need. Adora chuckled lowly at the twitch and with fingers still teasing against the woman's clit, raised herself on the bed. "Let's see if I can do better than just *decent* ."

Adora slid in easily, at Catra's pleading behest, not stopping until every inch was swallowed. She was on her knees, upright on the bed, Catra sprawled out below her. Adora watched eagerly as pleasure broke out across the other woman's face. The tiniest slide of her hips had Catra gasping, though she tried to maintain some semblance of control this early on. It was cute, in a steamy kind of way, but also Adora would have none of that. She was here to utterly wreck this woman.

As the pace of her thrusts began to build along with the panting reply of the woman taking her in full, Adora hooked both her arms under Catra's thighs to bring her up to a better angle. The reaction was immediate, Catra blindly grasping up with one hand to hold the bars of Adora's bedframe, bracing herself as the butch relentlessly rocked into her. Every thrust was indescribable;Catra stretched and so full, Adora hitting every spot just right, and she knew the noises that filled the room were coming from her mouth, but Catra did not care in the least, not when every nerve ending in her body was alight and alive.

Adora looked down at the gasping woman underneath her, dropping low across Catra's torso and putting all her weight onto one elbow so she could thrust all the harder. Catra's eyes were closed, brows drawn together sharply, mouth parted open and heaving. The woman had her hands grasped against Adora's ass, claws digging in, pushing the butch in deeper with each frantic thrust. Catra's legs were spread wide, her ankles hooked around the back of Adora's thighs, a litany of curses and broken pants interspersed between them eqally .

The pair kissed, all tongue and teeth, Catra's back arching off the bed and Adora's muscles straining to keep up the demand. But she wouldnt, could not stop, not until-...

"Fuck, fuck, fuck!" Catra cried out, somewhere between a reverent whisper and exhilarated shout. "A-Adora, Im..."

Arms under each of Catra's shoulders, holding the woman close to her chest, Adora rocked her hips with staccato, hard thrusts, angling

so she could feel the strap press into her own clit as she drove relentlessly into Catra's tight cunt. The bed shrieked and groaned in protest, headboard likely doing a level of damage to the wall that Adora could be proud of later. Everything in the room was tense, pulled taut. Catra's whole body seized, then every muscle released and shook. Her cry was choked, almost inhuman as pleasure wracked through her. She heard Adora give a similar labored cry as the butch grinded the strap into her with another few quick pulses, an extra flush of pride and satisfaction layering her release. Maybe the woman didn't *need* it, but if fucking her pussy was that good...

"C'mere, you." Adora pawed thickly for the smaller woman, both of them sweaty and sticky in the wake of their exertions. Catra should probably care and care a lot, but her craving for Adora's touch was nowhere near sated, even if currently all she could handle was being held. Adora was warm and solid, Catra fatigued and elated and definitely ruined. Ruined for time spent with and in any other person's bed, at least for the time being.

She woke up with her body draped across Adora's, stretched out against her chest, save for her left leg that was diagonal across the bed. Catra was taking up *way* more space that she really needed to, though the owner of the bed she was in really didn't seem to register. Adora had one arm tucked behind her head, the other securing Catra close to her chest. Her mouth was kind of open as she dozed and that absolutely wasn't the least bit cute and-...

"Hey," Adora's mumbled voice was syrupy, more than a little tinged with satisfaction. Only one bright blue eye fluttered open on her first try, though after a yawn Adora was able to shift her head enough to glance at the clock. 11:56pm. No idea when they first started fucking to know how long this particular bout of lesbian time travel lasted, but she and Catra had already been together nearly eight hours. That in and of itself was heart-stoppingly amazing. "You awake?"

A yawn, a look at her clock, then asking if she was awake. Catra had been through this enough times to recognize what this was all a precursor to. She had to admit it stung a little coming from Adora, but

there really weren't any set *rules* to their thing. It was late and they'd been together a fucking long time already. "I-I can go."

"Oh." Adora's dark brows hitched together, a flash of something indiscernible flitting across her face for just a moment until it fell into something approaching a neutral state. "I mean, yeah, of course."

Catra was instantly up, grabbing her clothes from the pile on the floor, thankful for her night vision. The dumb fire had waned to dying embers, just like their night together apparently had. Hopefully on a holiday weekend Uber wouldn't be too delayed, though the premiums were sure to be outrageous, especially for a completely private ride home. The last thing Catra could deal with right now was interacting with any drunk idiots hopping from one Halloween party to the next.

"Do you want to?"

The voice was small, devoid of the normal swagger and easy confidence that the butch normally strode through life cloaked in. It gave Catra pause, holding her bra in her hands, caught halfway between deciding whether to put the damn thing on again or just carry it home. It really had only been an ornament, something for Adora to enjoy taking off of her-...

The lamp on the bedside table clicked on and Catra blinked to adjust, now hating her night vision a bit as the brightness threatened to kick her headache up again. She was tired, frankly a little embarrassed at already taking up so much of Adora's night, and not really looking forward to a cold, 40+ minute ride home in a stranger's ride-share gig. She really should have driven herself; Catra knew she wasn't going to be drinking tonight and should have realized at some point, Adora would want to sleep. And without Catra invading her space any more than a quick roll in the sack called for.

"Because Cat, I'll be honest here. I don't want you to leave yet." Adora held up one hand and chuckled, its sound somehow coming

out even more queer and nervous than herself. "I know that's probably *a lot*, but we agreed on one day at a time, right?"

Catra's tail twitched, not really sure what to make of this. To be fair, the blatant honesty was refreshing, if also a little nerve wracking. And the vagueness of their whole agreement was working for her, at least for now. She turned the lace bra over in her hands, still deliberating on its fate, before answering with a light, "Yeah, we did."

"It's a new day." Adora jutted her finger towards the time. 12:01am.

Catra looked at the clock, then back towards Adora, stunned relief settling over her. "You're an idiot."

Adora's returned smile to Catra's incredulous laughter was sheepish, but pleased. "Yeah, I know. Stay?"

"What would we even do?" Catra wasn't tired exactly, at least to the point of actually being able to sleep again any time soon. And now that she maybe wasn't being kicked out after a night of lurid, incredible, sign-her-up-for-more-ASAP sex, maybe she could admit that she kind of, sorta wanted to stay too. Still, she had to be *sure*. "It's midnight, don't you want me to finally get the fuck out so you can sleep or whatever?"

Adora pretended to think about it a moment before she shook her head, her grin wide and infectious. "Nope. I think I want pie. You want some pie?"

Catra remained speechless at the offer, even more dumbfounded when she ended up pulling on an entirely too big for her, but incredibly soft hoodie that belonged to Adora so she wouldn't freeze as the pair wandered out to the kitchen. The pie though- freshly baked from her great aunt or something, ended up being delicious. One day at a time.

Chapter End Notes

... Hey, everyone. How we feeling? This is normally the part when I cheerfully tell you all that "hopefully it won't be so long between updates!" and then, for a variety of very valid, mostly personal reasons, I don't follow through on that. So this time, even though I have more written for these two and so much, much more in mind on where I could bring them, I'm deciding to call it here. That being said, if ever I feel the urge, I may add to this. Stay subscribed to it (and/or me) if that's strong enough to keep your interest.

PA became more than I ever thought it could be and candidly, I think it contains some of my best and strongest writing. I care for it deeply. But with where I am at now in life, having these unfinished stories "hanging over my head" is not serving me. I know I did it to myself- but that means I also gotta take steps to dig myself out, yeah? So, for now we say goodbye, but with the comforting knowledge that these two are being relatively honest with each other. That being said, not even talking before a nice fuck on a Top's couch can fix everything in a couple days. Nor can a night out together or a few returned texts. Keep that in mind if you feel Catra's knee-jerk reaction at the end is a step backwards or concerning in any way. We all need to take things one day at a time and progress is not always linear, but even one step towards what you want can set you on a solid path. And hey, pie can fix a lot just on its own.

I hope for what its worth you enjoyed this story and are satisfied enough by this chapter. Who knows what the future will bring for this and anything else under my name. I appreciate you all. Thank you.

P.S.- A huge thank you to candycornsnake, wildangeline, and lologoblens for beta-ing this chapter, sometimes multiple times over and all at different stages of its development. None of you saw this complete version, so hopefully it's not too rough. 😅 It

was a long struggle overall and I'm a pain in the ass, I know, but you're all wonderful friends whom I am very grateful to have on this colonizer-holiday weekend (and beyond).

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